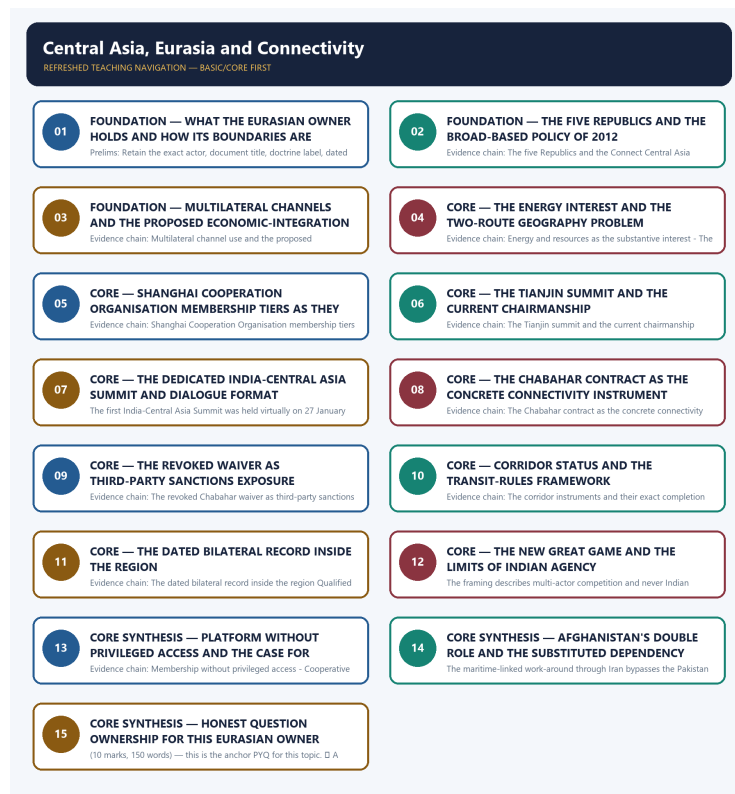


COMPLETE LEARNING SESSION

Central Asia, Eurasia and Connectivity - Learner-v2 Refreshed

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing



Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Central Asia, Eurasia and Connectivity - Learner-v2

Complete Learning Session

Authoring-only generation: 2026-09-03. No PDF was rendered and no tracker or index was mutated.

SOURCE, PROGRESSION AND CURRENT-LINKAGE AUDIT

- **Generation date:** 2026-09-03.
- **Repository-first evidence:** the Basic owner is taught first and preserved in full; the Advanced owner is retained only in the optional final teaching block.
- **OCR evidence:** Repository Markdown was primary. The OCR-searchable official General Studies question papers held under books\mains and books\more_previous_papers were read only to confirm the printed wording of routed demands. No official answer key, marking scheme, page precision or unsupported quotation was imported from them.
- **Qdrant:** not used; repository Markdown and available OCR context were sufficient.
- **PYQ integrity:** Two General Studies Paper II Mains demands are routed to this topic in the audited routing ledgers and each is reproduced below as a demand card with its printed year, paper, question number, directive, marks and word limit exactly as the ledger records them: 2018 General Studies Paper II question 10 on outside powers in Central Asia and India joining the Ashgabat Agreement, a Discuss the implications demand of 10 marks and 150 words, for which the ledger records that the printed word-limit tail was corrupted in the scan and that the Core route supersedes the older Advanced ownership; and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 10 on India's evolving diplomatic, economic and strategic relations with the Central Asian Republics, a Critically analyse demand of 10 marks and 150 words. One objective demand is also routed to this owner and is carried as a coverage requirement only: 2025 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 62 on International North-South Transport Corridor connectivity, for which the official Set-A key is present locally. No option or answer letter is recorded or inferred for that objective demand, and the presence of a locally held key is not treated as permission to publish one. Where a printed word limit or stem tail is recorded as corrupted in the scan, that defect is reported rather than silently repaired by invented wording. The locally held OCR-searchable official General Studies papers were read only to confirm the printed wording of the routed Mains demands; no question was invented from them, no stem was paraphrased into an apparent routing, and no marking scheme or official answer key was imported.
- **Live-link boundary:** Live official verification was attempted on 2026-09-03 in the priority order required for this topic: the Ministry of External Affairs pages first, then the Press Information Bureau, the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation Secretariat, the Eurasian Economic Union and the Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways. Every outcome is recorded exactly as observed. The Ministry of External Affairs pages returned a browser-requirement stub or the Ministry's own error page, the Press Information Bureau index returned HTTP 403, and the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation Secretariat returned only an anniversary banner. The Eurasian Economic Union and the Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways returned general background text with no dated item bearing on India, so no new live item was obtained that would add, alter or date any claim in this package. The package therefore uses only the dated official anchors already carried by the repository owners, each with its actor, exact evidentiary level and date. It invents no corridor or project status, no route alignment, no summit outcome, no sanctions measure, no membership or participation category, no energy or trade share, no port access, no treaty or statement wording, no border or diplomatic status, no date, no previous-year question, no answer key and no current claim.
- **Fact/inference discipline:** no current-affairs item, PYQ wording, figure or quotation is invented.

LIVE OFFICIAL-SOURCE ATTEMPT LOG

Every live check below was attempted on 2026-09-03 in the priority order required for International Relations: Ministry of External Affairs official pages first, then other official government or international-organisation documents. Access failures are recorded exactly as observed and no claim is reconstructed from a failed fetch.

- <https://www.mea.gov.in/press-releases.htm> - attempted 2026-09-03; the request redirected to a browser-requirement stub and returned no press release text, so no live item was taken from it.
- <https://www.mea.gov.in/bilateral-documents.htm> - attempted 2026-09-03; the request redirected to a browser-requirement stub and returned no bilateral document text, so no live item was taken from it.
- <https://www.mea.gov.in/foreign-relation.htm> - attempted 2026-09-03; the request redirected to the Ministry's own error page, so no country brief was taken from it.
- <https://www.pib.gov.in/indexd.aspx?reg=3&lang=1> - attempted 2026-09-03; the request returned HTTP 403, so no release was taken from it.
- <https://eng.sectesco.org/> - attempted 2026-09-03; the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation Secretariat site returned only a single anniversary banner line with no membership table, summit record or declaration text, so no membership, participation-category or summit-outcome claim was taken from it.
- <http://www.eaeunion.org/?lang=en> - attempted 2026-09-03; the Eurasian Economic Union site returned substantive historical text on the union's formation from 1994 onward, which is background rather than a status report, and it carried nothing on the India free-trade negotiation, so no negotiation-status claim was taken from it.
- <https://shipmin.gov.in/> - attempted 2026-09-03; the Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways home page returned a general descriptive statement of the Ministry's mandate and no dated item, so no corridor, port-access or capacity claim was taken from it.

BASIC LEARNING SESSION

DEEP-REVIEW LEARNING CONTRACT

Control	Binding rule for this package
Syllabus boundary	Complete International Relations Basic/Core is answer-complete before optional Advanced depth.
Status boundary	Announced, negotiated, initialled, signed, ratified, entered into force, operational, suspended and completed remain distinct.
Institutional method	Treaty basis or political character -> exact membership/status -> mandate -> decision rule -> national instrument -> implementation -> outcome.
Level mapping	Bilateral, subregional/regional, minilateral/plurilateral and systemic levels are separated and then connected.
Policy method	Strategic objective -> chosen instrument -> implementing actors/resources -> observed output/outcome -> alternative and residual risk.
Evidence method	Claim -> named India-centric treaty, institution, corridor, operation, agreement or summit -> analysis -> official source/date/status and causal qualification.
Neutrality method	Contested borders, maritime claims and conflicts are attributed neutrally; policy doctrine is distinguished from retrospective analytical label.
Practice contract	Every solved item has demand decoding, a detailed examiner-grade model, executable timed/compression plan, marks rationale and answer-specific improvement.
Approval	This immutable successor remains approved: false pending explicit approval.

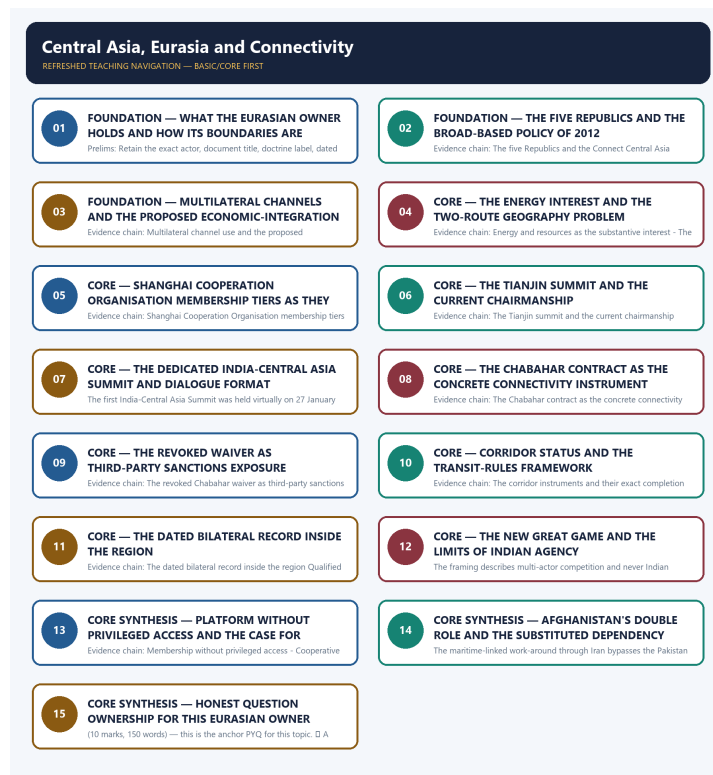
Canonical Basic/Core owner: upsc-ai-kit\knowledge\International-Relations\basic\05_Central-Asia-Eurasia-and-Connectivity.md **Substantive canonical provenance owner:** upsc-ai-kit\knowledge\International-Relations\05_Central-Asia-Eurasia-and-Connectivity_Learner-V2-Complete-Topic-Package.md **Optional Advanced owner:** upsc-ai-kit\knowledge\International-Relations\advanced\05_Central-Asia-Eurasia-and-Connectivity.md **Official syllabus mapping:**

EVIDENCE, PYQ AND CURRENT-STATUS CONTROL

- **Membership discipline:** member, observer, dialogue partner, chair, guest and invited participant are not interchangeable; verify the relevant date.
- **Mandate discipline:** treaty organisation, UN organ, specialised agency, court, summit process, political forum, coalition and minilateral retain exact legal character and competence.
- **Agreement discipline:** announcement, negotiation, signature, ratification, entry into force, domestic implementation and measured outcome remain separate.
- **Connectivity discipline:** concept, financing, contract, construction, trial movement, operational segment, completed corridor and commercially viable use remain separate.
- **Conflict discipline:** distinguish verified event, party claim, independent attribution, legal characterisation and analytical inference; use neutral language for contested borders and conflicts.
- **Causal discipline:** chronology, summit language, trade change, deployment or project completion does not alone establish strategic effect; state mechanism, counterfactual and alternatives.
- **Trade-off discipline:** interests, capabilities, constraints, partner agency, escalation, dependence, finance, legitimacy, domestic distribution, alternatives and implementation risks are explicit.
- **PYQ discipline:** exact wording is preserved only where verified; routed or reconstructed demands remain labelled and no model is presented as an official UPSC answer.
- **Current-status note, rechecked 2026-09-03:** volatile relations, agreements, corridors, operations, conflicts, trade and summit outcomes retain official source, publication date and operative/interim/completed status; stale officeholders are omitted.

Generation-local live/current sources:

- <https://www.mea.gov.in/press-releases.htm> - attempted 2026-09-03; the request redirected to a browser-requirement stub and returned no press release text, so no live item was taken from it.
- <https://www.mea.gov.in/bilateral-documents.htm> - attempted 2026-09-03; the request redirected to a browser-requirement stub and returned no bilateral document text, so no live item was taken from it.
- <https://www.mea.gov.in/foreign-relation.htm> - attempted 2026-09-03; the request redirected to the Ministry's own error page, so no country brief was taken from it.
- <https://www.pib.gov.in/indexd.aspx?reg=3&lang=1> - attempted 2026-09-03; the request returned HTTP 403, so no release was taken from it.
- <https://eng.sectscsco.org/> - attempted 2026-09-03; the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation Secretariat site returned only a single anniversary banner line with no membership table, summit record or declaration text, so no membership, participation-category or summit-outcome claim was taken from it.
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- <https://shipmin.gov.in/> - attempted 2026-09-03; the Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways home page returned a general descriptive statement of the Ministry's mandate and no dated item, so no corridor, port-access or capacity claim was taken from it.



Refreshed teaching navigation

Distinct embedded teaching-navigation image. The separate continuous Cārvāka-style flowchart package remains an independent at-a-glance artifact.

SESSION 1 - FOUNDATION - WHAT THE EURASIAN OWNER HOLDS AND HOW ITS BOUNDARIES ARE ROUTED

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Evidence chain: What this Eurasian owner holds and how its boundaries are routed
Qualified use: Open a Central Asia demand by fixing ownership so the answer does not drift into another owner's evidence.

Technical definition: Prelims: Retain the exact actor, document title, doctrine label, dated instrument and evidentiary level attached to What the Eurasian owner holds and how its boundaries are routed, and never upgrade a vision statement into a treaty, a signature into a ratification, a participation category into membership, or an announced corridor into an operating one.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Evidence chain: What this Eurasian owner holds and how its boundaries are routed
Qualified use: Open a Central Asia demand by fixing ownership so the answer does not drift into another owner's evidence.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- FOUNDATION
- What the Eurasian owner holds
- how its boundaries are routed
- Evidence chain
- Qualified use
- This

How to use them: Frame the answer through FOUNDATION; define What the Eurasian owner holds, connect how its boundaries are routed with Evidence chain to explain the mechanism, and use Qualified use for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

WHAT THE EURASIAN OWNER HOLDS AND HOW ITS BOUNDARIES ARE ROUTED

01. What this Eurasian owner holds and how its boundaries are routed

BOUNDARY -> The grouping profile belongs to topic 10, the China relationship to topic 03, the energy limb of Chabahar to topic 06 and route geography to Geography.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

This topic owns the five Central Asian Republics, the Connect Central Asia Policy, the India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue mechanisms, India's Central Asian use of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the connectivity instruments of the International North-South Transport Corridor, Chabahar port and the Ashgabat Agreement, the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation and the New Great Game framing, and its distinctive feature is that its examinable spine is a constraint rather than an opportunity, because two verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2018 and 2024 and one objective demand from 2025 are routed here; the full institutional profile of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation belongs to topic 10, the India-China strategic relationship belongs to topic 03, the West Asian and energy-security limb of Chabahar belongs to topic 06, physical and route geography belongs to the Geography owner, and Soviet-era regional chronology with the nineteenth-century Great Game belongs to the World History owner.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- This topic owns the five Central Asian Republics, the Connect Central Asia Policy, the India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue mechanisms, India's Central Asian use of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the connectivity instruments of the International North-South Transport Corridor, Chabahar port and the Ashgabat Agreement, the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation and the New Great Game framing, and its distinctive feature is that its examinable spine is a constraint rather than an opportunity, because two verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2018 and 2024 and one objective demand from 2025 are routed here; the full institutional profile of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation belongs to topic 10, the India-China strategic relationship belongs to topic 03, the West Asian and energy-security limb of Chabahar belongs to topic 06, physical and route geography belongs to the Geography owner, and Soviet-era regional chronology with the nineteenth-century Great Game belongs to the World History owner.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- The grouping profile belongs to topic 10, the China relationship to topic 03, the energy limb of Chabahar to topic 06 and route geography to Geography.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact actor, document title, doctrine label, dated instrument and evidentiary level attached to What the Eurasian owner holds and how its boundaries are routed, and never upgrade a vision statement into a treaty, a signature into a ratification, a participation category into membership, or an announced corridor into an operating one.
- **Mains:** Open a Central Asia demand by fixing ownership so the answer does not drift into another owner's evidence.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** What this Eurasian owner holds and how its boundaries are routed
- **Qualified use:** Open a Central Asia demand by fixing ownership so the answer does not drift into another owner's evidence.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - FOUNDATION - WHAT THE EURASIAN OWNER HOLDS AND HOW ITS BOUNDARIES ARE ROUTED

START / CONCEPT: FOUNDATION - What the Eurasian owner holds and how its boundaries are routed

|
v

EXACT TERMS: FOUNDATION · What the Eurasian owner holds · how its boundaries are routed · Evidence chain · Qualified use · This

|
v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Prelims: Retain the exact actor, document title, doctrine label, dated instrument and evidentiary level attached to What the Eurasian owner holds and how its boundaries are routed, and never upgrade a vision statement into a treaty, a signature into a ratification, a participation category into membership, or an announced corridor into an operating one.

|
v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Mains: Open a Central Asia demand by fixing ownership so the answer does not drift into another owner's evidence.

|
v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: This topic owns the five Central Asian Republics, the Connect Central Asia Policy, the India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue mechanisms, India's Central Asian use of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the connectivity instruments of the International North-South Transport Corridor, Chabahar port and the Ashgabat Agreement, the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation and the New Great Game framing, and its distinctive feature is that its examinable spine is a constraint rather than an opportunity, because two verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2018 and 2024 and one objective demand from 2025 are routed here; the full institutional profile of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation belongs to topic 10, the India-China strategic relationship belongs to topic 03, the West Asian and energy-security limb of Chabahar belongs to topic 06, physical and route geography belongs to the Geography owner, and Soviet-era regional chronology with the nineteenth-century Great Game belongs to the World History owner.

|
v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Evidence chain: What this Eurasian owner holds and how its boundaries are routed Qualified use: Open a Central Asia demand by fixing ownership so the answer does not drift into another owner's evidence.

SESSION 2 - FOUNDATION - THE FIVE REPUBLICS AND THE BROAD-BASED POLICY OF 2012

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: The five Central Asian Republics are Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan, and the Connect Central Asia Policy launched in 2012 aims at strengthening and expanding India's relations with those countries through a broad-based approach including political, security, economic and cultural connections; the owners insist on the word broad-based because reducing the policy to energy alone misdescribes its declared scope, and they treat the 2012 launch as the foundational Indian policy approach against which every later mechanism in this topic is measured.

Technical definition: Evidence chain: The five Republics and the Connect Central Asia Policy Qualified use: Name the five states and the founding policy precisely so the answer opens on verifiable ground rather than generalities.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The five Central Asian Republics are Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan, and the Connect Central Asia Policy launched in 2012 aims at strengthening and expanding India's relations with those countries through a broad-based approach including political, security, economic and cultural connections; the owners insist on the word broad-based because reducing the policy to energy alone misdescribes its declared scope, and they treat the 2012 launch as the foundational Indian policy approach against which every later mechanism in this topic is measured.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- FOUNDATION
- The five Republics

- the broad-based policy of 2012
- Evidence chain
- Qualified use
- The five Central Asian Republics

How to use them: Frame the answer through FOUNDATION; define The five Republics, connect the broad-based policy of 2012 with Evidence chain to explain the mechanism, and use Qualified use for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

THE FIVE REPUBLICS AND THE BROAD-BASED POLICY OF 2012

01. The five Republics and the Connect Central Asia Policy

BOUNDARY -> The policy is broad-based across political, security, economic and cultural connections and is not an energy policy.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

The five Central Asian Republics are Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan, and the Connect Central Asia Policy launched in 2012 aims at strengthening and expanding India's relations with those countries through a broad-based approach including political, security, economic and cultural connections; the owners insist on the word broad-based because reducing the policy to energy alone misdescribes its declared scope, and they treat the 2012 launch as the foundational Indian policy approach against which every later mechanism in this topic is measured.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- The five Central Asian Republics are Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan, and the Connect Central Asia Policy launched in 2012 aims at strengthening and expanding India's relations with those countries through a broad-based approach including political, security, economic and cultural connections; the owners insist on the word broad-based because reducing the policy to energy alone misdescribes its declared scope, and they treat the 2012 launch as the foundational Indian policy approach against which every later mechanism in this topic is measured.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- The policy is broad-based across political, security, economic and cultural connections and is not an energy policy.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact actor, document title, doctrine label, dated instrument and evidentiary level attached to The five Republics and the broad-based policy of 2012, and never upgrade a vision statement into a treaty, a signature into a ratification, a participation category into membership, or an announced corridor into an operating one.
- **Mains:** Name the five states and the founding policy precisely so the answer opens on verifiable ground rather than generalities.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** The five Republics and the Connect Central Asia Policy
- **Qualified use:** Name the five states and the founding policy precisely so the answer opens on verifiable ground rather than generalities.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - FOUNDATION - THE FIVE REPUBLICS AND THE BROAD-BASED POLICY OF 2012

START / CONCEPT: FOUNDATION - The five Republics and the broad-based policy of 2012

|
v

EXACT TERMS: FOUNDATION · The five Republics · the broad-based policy of 2012 · Evidence chain · Qualified use · The five Central Asian Republics

|
v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Evidence chain: The five Republics and the Connect Central Asia Policy
Qualified use: Name the five states and the founding policy precisely so the answer opens on verifiable ground rather than generalities.

|
v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: The policy is broad-based across political, security, economic and cultural connections and is not an energy policy.

|
v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: the policy is broad-based across political, security, economic and cultural connections and is not...

|
v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: The five Central Asian Republics are Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan, and the Connect Central Asia Policy launched in 2012 aims at strengthening and expanding India's relations with those countries through a broad-based approach including political, security, economic and cultural connections; the owners insist on the word broad-based because reducing the policy to energy alone misdescribes its declared scope, and they treat the 2012 launch as the foundational Indian policy approach against which every later mechanism in this topic is measured.

SESSION 3 - FOUNDATION - MULTILATERAL CHANNELS AND THE PROPOSED ECONOMIC-INTEGRATION INSTRUMENT

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: The proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement is now pursued as the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation, which formally began on 3 June 2017 at St Petersburg and remained under negotiation, with the second round held in Moscow on 22-25 June 2026; the owners fix the status precisely as under negotiation and neither signed nor in force, so an answer may cite the dated rounds as evidence of sustained economic engagement and may never assert conclusion, signature or entry into force.

Technical definition: Evidence chain: Multilateral channel use and the proposed economic-integration instrument - The India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation and its exact status
Qualified use: Cite the dated negotiation rounds as evidence of sustained engagement without asserting an outcome.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Evidence chain: Multilateral channel use and the proposed economic-integration instrument - The India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation and its exact status
Qualified use: Cite the dated negotiation rounds as evidence of sustained engagement without asserting an outcome.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **FOUNDATION**
- **Multilateral channels**
- **the proposed economic-integration instrument**
- **Evidence chain**
- **Qualified use**
- **India**

How to use them: Frame the answer through FOUNDATION; define Multilateral channels, connect the proposed economic-integration instrument with Evidence chain to explain the mechanism, and use Qualified use for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

MULTILATERAL CHANNELS AND THE PROPOSED ECONOMIC-INTEGRATION INSTRUMENT

01. Multilateral channel use and the proposed economic-integration instrument

|
v

02. The India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation and its exact status

BOUNDARY -> A proposal is intent and an open negotiation is not signature, conclusion or entry into force.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

India engages Central Asia partly through existing fora described in the sources as the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the Eurasian Economic Community and the Custom Union, and it has proposed a Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement to integrate its markets with the Eurasian space; the examinable discipline is that a proposal is an instrument of intent rather than an operating arrangement, so an answer must name the proposal by its exact title and then trace what actually happened to it rather than implying that market integration has already occurred. The proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement is now pursued as the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation, which formally began on 3 June 2017 at St Petersburg and remained under negotiation, with the second round held in Moscow on 22-25 June 2026; the owners fix the status precisely as under negotiation and neither signed nor in force, so an answer may cite the dated rounds as evidence of sustained economic engagement and may never assert conclusion, signature or entry into force.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- India engages Central Asia partly through existing fora described in the sources as the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the Eurasian Economic Community and the Custom Union, and it has proposed a Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement to integrate its markets with the Eurasian space; the examinable discipline is that a proposal is an instrument of intent rather than an operating arrangement, so an answer must name the proposal by its exact title and then trace what actually happened to it rather than implying that market integration has already occurred.
- The proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement is now pursued as the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation, which formally began on 3 June 2017 at St Petersburg and remained under negotiation, with the second round held in Moscow on 22-25 June 2026; the owners fix the status precisely as under negotiation and neither signed nor in force, so an answer may cite the dated rounds as evidence of sustained economic engagement and may never assert conclusion, signature or entry into force.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- A proposal is intent and an open negotiation is not signature, conclusion or entry into force.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact actor, document title, doctrine label, dated instrument and evidentiary level attached to Multilateral channels and the proposed economic-integration instrument, and never upgrade a vision statement into a treaty, a signature into a ratification, a participation category into membership, or an announced corridor into an operating one.
- **Mains:** Cite the dated negotiation rounds as evidence of sustained engagement without asserting an outcome.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** Multilateral channel use and the proposed economic-integration instrument -> The India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation and its exact status
- **Qualified use:** Cite the dated negotiation rounds as evidence of sustained engagement without asserting an outcome.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - FOUNDATION - MULTILATERAL CHANNELS AND THE PROPOSED ECONOMIC-INTEGRATION INSTRUMENT

START / CONCEPT: FOUNDATION - Multilateral channels and the proposed economic-integration instrument

|
v

EXACT TERMS: FOUNDATION • Multilateral channels • the proposed economic-integration instrument •
Evidence chain • Qualified use • India

|
v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: India engages Central Asia partly through existing fora described in the sources as the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the Eurasian Economic Community and the Custom Union, and it has proposed a Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement to integrate its markets with the Eurasian space; the examinable discipline is that a proposal is an instrument of intent rather than an operating arrangement, so an answer must name the proposal by its exact title and then trace what actually happened to it rather than implying that market integration has already occurred.

|
v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: A proposal is intent and an open negotiation is not signature, conclusion or entry into force.

|
v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: The proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement is now pursued as the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation, which formally began on 3 June 2017 at St Petersburg and remained under negotiation, with the second round held in Moscow on 22-25 June 2026; the owners fix the status precisely as under negotiation and neither signed nor in force, so an answer may cite the dated rounds as evidence of sustained economic engagement and may never assert conclusion, signature or entry into force.

|
v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Evidence chain: Multilateral channel use and the proposed economic-integration instrument - The India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation and its exact status Qualified use: Cite the dated negotiation rounds as evidence of sustained engagement without asserting an outcome.

SESSION 4 - CORE - THE ENERGY INTEREST AND THE TWO-ROUTE GEOGRAPHY PROBLEM

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: India looks to Central Asia as a long-term partner in energy and natural resources, given the region's substantial hydrocarbon and mineral endowment, and this interest is what makes the connectivity question consequential rather than merely administrative; the owners keep the claim at the level of a stated policy interest and do not attach any volume, share, price or contract figure to it, because no such figure is carried by the sources and an invented number would convert a defensible interest claim into a fabricated one.

Technical definition: Evidence chain: Energy and resources as the substantive interest - The two-route geography problem as a binding structural constraint Qualified use: Establish why connectivity matters and then convert the constraint into the analytical spine of the answer.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Evidence chain: Energy and resources as the substantive interest - The two-route geography problem as a binding structural constraint Qualified use: Establish why connectivity matters and then convert the constraint into the analytical spine of the answer.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- The energy interest
- the two-route geography problem
- Evidence chain
- Qualified use
- India
- Central Asia

How to use them: Frame the answer through The energy interest; define the two-route geography problem, connect Evidence chain with Qualified use to explain the mechanism, and use India for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

THE ENERGY INTEREST AND THE TWO-ROUTE GEOGRAPHY PROBLEM

01. Energy and resources as the substantive interest

|

v

02. The two-route geography problem as a binding structural constraint

BOUNDARY -> No volume, share or contract figure is carried by the sources, and both overland routes carry a serious political or geographic difficulty.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

India looks to Central Asia as a long-term partner in energy and natural resources, given the region's substantial hydrocarbon and mineral endowment, and this interest is what makes the connectivity question consequential rather than merely administrative; the owners keep the claim at the level of a stated policy interest and do not attach any volume, share, price or contract figure to it, because no such figure is carried by the sources and an invented number would convert a defensible interest claim into a fabricated one. India has no direct land access to the Central Asian Republics because Pakistan and Afghanistan lie in between, so the first overland option is politically and security constrained, while Sikri records that any energy pipeline from Eurasia to India not crossing Afghanistan or Pakistan has to be routed via Xinjiang and then across the Karakoram and the Himalayan mountain ranges, which is geographically extreme and would require Chinese cooperation; the owners are categorical that this is a structural rather than a merely technical problem, so both plausible overland routes carry a serious political or geographic difficulty at the same time.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- India looks to Central Asia as a long-term partner in energy and natural resources, given the region's substantial hydrocarbon and mineral endowment, and this interest is what makes the connectivity question consequential rather than merely administrative; the owners keep the claim at the level of a stated policy interest and do not attach any volume, share, price or contract figure to it, because no such figure is carried by the sources and an invented number would convert a defensible interest claim into a fabricated one.
- India has no direct land access to the Central Asian Republics because Pakistan and Afghanistan lie in between, so the first overland option is politically and security constrained, while Sikri records that any energy pipeline from Eurasia to India not crossing Afghanistan or Pakistan has to be routed via Xinjiang and then across the Karakoram and the Himalayan mountain ranges, which is geographically extreme and would require Chinese cooperation; the owners are categorical that this is a structural rather than a merely technical problem, so both plausible overland routes carry a serious political or geographic difficulty at the same time.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- No volume, share or contract figure is carried by the sources, and both overland routes carry a serious political or geographic difficulty.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact actor, document title, doctrine label, dated instrument and evidentiary level attached to The energy interest and the two-route geography problem, and never upgrade a vision statement into a treaty, a signature into a ratification, a participation category into membership, or an announced corridor into an operating one.
- **Mains:** Establish why connectivity matters and then convert the constraint into the analytical spine of the answer.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** Energy and resources as the substantive interest -> The two-route geography problem as a binding structural constraint
- **Qualified use:** Establish why connectivity matters and then convert the constraint into the analytical spine of the answer.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CORE - THE ENERGY INTEREST AND THE TWO-ROUTE GEOGRAPHY PROBLEM

START / CONCEPT: CORE - The energy interest and the two-route geography problem

|
v

EXACT TERMS: The energy interest · the two-route geography problem · Evidence chain · Qualified use
· India · Central Asia

|
v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: India looks to Central Asia as a long-term partner in energy and natural resources, given the region's substantial hydrocarbon and mineral endowment, and this interest is what makes the connectivity question consequential rather than merely administrative; the owners keep the claim at the level of a stated policy interest and do not attach any volume, share, price or contract figure to it, because no such figure is carried by the sources and an invented number would convert a defensible interest claim into a fabricated one.

|
v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: India has no direct land access to the Central Asian Republics because Pakistan and Afghanistan lie in between, so the first overland option is politically and security constrained, while Sikri records that any energy pipeline from Eurasia to India not crossing Afghanistan or Pakistan has to be routed via Xinjiang and then across the Karakoram and the Himalayan mountain ranges, which is geographically extreme and would require Chinese cooperation; the owners are categorical that this is a structural rather than a merely technical problem, so both plausible overland routes carry a serious political or geographic difficulty at the same time.

|
v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: no volume, share or contract figure is carried by the sources.

|
v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Evidence chain: Energy and resources as the substantive interest - The two-route geography problem as a binding structural constraint Qualified use: Establish why connectivity matters and then convert the constraint into the analytical spine of the answer.

SESSION 5 - CORE - SHANGHAI COOPERATION ORGANISATION MEMBERSHIP TIERS AS THEY NOW STAND

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: As of 3 August 2026 the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation has ten full members, namely Belarus, China, India, Iran, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Pakistan, Russia, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan, two observers, namely Afghanistan and Mongolia, and fifteen dialogue partners, with Pakistan a member since 2017, Iran since 2023 and Belarus since 2024, while a decision of 1 September 2025 envisages consolidating the observer and dialogue-partner categories into a single SCO Partner status whose enabling amendments had not entered into force; the owners warn expressly that Sikri's book-period note placing Pakistan, Iran and Mongolia in observer status is period-specific and must be dated whenever it is quoted.

Technical definition: Evidence chain: Shanghai Cooperation Organisation membership tiers as they now stand Qualified use: Win close-option marks by stating current membership tiers exactly and dating any book-period description.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Evidence chain: Shanghai Cooperation Organisation membership tiers as they now stand Qualified use: Win close-option marks by stating current membership tiers exactly and dating any book-period description.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Evidence chain
- Qualified use
- As
- Shanghai Cooperation Organisation
- Belarus
- China

How to use them: Frame the answer through Evidence chain; define Qualified use, connect As with Shanghai Cooperation Organisation to explain the mechanism, and use Belarus for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

SHANGHAI COOPERATION ORGANISATION MEMBERSHIP TIERS AS THEY NOW STAND

01. Shanghai Cooperation Organisation membership tiers as they now stand

BOUNDARY -> Pakistan and Iran are full members rather than observers, and the single partner status had not entered into force.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

As of 3 August 2026 the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation has ten full members, namely Belarus, China, India, Iran, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Pakistan, Russia, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan, two observers, namely Afghanistan and Mongolia, and fifteen dialogue partners, with Pakistan a member since 2017, Iran since 2023 and Belarus since 2024, while a decision of 1 September 2025 envisages consolidating the observer and dialogue-partner categories into a single SCO Partner status whose enabling amendments had not entered into force; the owners warn expressly that Sikri's book-period note placing Pakistan, Iran and Mongolia in observer status is period-specific and must be dated whenever it is quoted.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- As of 3 August 2026 the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation has ten full members, namely Belarus, China, India, Iran, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Pakistan, Russia, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan, two observers, namely Afghanistan and Mongolia, and fifteen dialogue partners, with Pakistan a member since 2017, Iran since 2023 and Belarus since 2024, while a decision of 1 September 2025 envisages consolidating the observer and dialogue-partner categories into a single SCO Partner status whose enabling amendments had not entered into force; the owners warn expressly that Sikri's book-period note placing Pakistan, Iran and Mongolia in observer status is period-specific and must be dated whenever it is quoted.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- Pakistan and Iran are full members rather than observers, and the single partner status had not entered into force.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact actor, document title, doctrine label, dated instrument and evidentiary level attached to Shanghai Cooperation Organisation membership tiers as they now stand, and never upgrade a vision statement into a treaty, a signature into a ratification, a participation category into membership, or an announced corridor into an operating one.
- **Mains:** Win close-option marks by stating current membership tiers exactly and dating any book-period description.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** Shanghai Cooperation Organisation membership tiers as they now stand
- **Qualified use:** Win close-option marks by stating current membership tiers exactly and dating any book-period description.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CORE - SHANGHAI COOPERATION ORGANISATION MEMBERSHIP TIERS AS THEY NOW STAND

START / CONCEPT: CORE - Shanghai Cooperation Organisation membership tiers as they now stand

|
v

EXACT TERMS: Evidence chain · Qualified use · As · Shanghai Cooperation Organisation · Belarus · China

|
v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: As of 3 August 2026 the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation has ten full members, namely Belarus, China, India, Iran, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Pakistan, Russia, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan, two observers, namely Afghanistan and Mongolia, and fifteen dialogue partners, with Pakistan a member since 2017, Iran since 2023 and Belarus since 2024, while a decision of 1 September 2025 envisages consolidating the observer and dialogue-partner categories into a single SCO Partner status whose enabling amendments had not entered into force; the owners warn expressly that Sikri's book-period note placing Pakistan, Iran and Mongolia in observer status is period-specific and must be dated whenever it is quoted.

|
v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Pakistan and Iran are full members rather than observers, and the single partner status had not entered into force.

|
v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: shanghai Cooperation Organisation membership tiers as they now stand Qualified use.

|
v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Evidence chain: Shanghai Cooperation Organisation membership tiers as they now stand Qualified use: Win close-option marks by stating current membership tiers exactly and dating any book-period description.

SESSION 6 - CORE - THE TIANJIN SUMMIT AND THE CURRENT CHAIRMANSHIP

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: The 2025 Heads of State Council summit of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation met at Tianjin on 31 August and 1 September 2025 and adopted the Tianjin Declaration, Kyrgyzstan holds the 2025-26 chairmanship and the next summit is scheduled for Bishkek, while India's own accession to full membership in 2017 is treated as chronology owned by the World History and Polity owners; the owners permit the summit and declaration to be cited as dated evidence of India's continued multilateral engagement and permit no claim about the declaration's contents beyond its adoption at that meeting.

Technical definition: Evidence chain: The Tianjin summit and the current chairmanship Qualified use: Supply one dated multilateral anchor that proves continued engagement without overstating its substance.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The 2025 Heads of State Council summit of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation met at Tianjin on 31 August and 1 September 2025 and adopted the Tianjin Declaration, Kyrgyzstan holds the 2025-26 chairmanship and the next summit is scheduled for Bishkek, while India's own accession to full membership in 2017 is treated as chronology owned by the World History and Polity owners; the owners permit the summit and declaration to be cited as dated evidence of India's continued multilateral engagement and permit no claim about the declaration's contents beyond its adoption at that meeting.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- The Tianjin summit
- the current chairmanship
- Evidence chain
- Qualified use
- Heads
- 2025-26

How to use them: Frame the answer through The Tianjin summit; define the current chairmanship, connect Evidence chain with Qualified use to explain the mechanism, and use Heads for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

THE TIANJIN SUMMIT AND THE CURRENT CHAIRMANSHIP

01. The Tianjin summit and the current chairmanship

BOUNDARY -> The summit and declaration may be cited only as adopted at that meeting, with no claim about their contents.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

The 2025 Heads of State Council summit of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation met at Tianjin on 31 August and 1 September 2025 and adopted the Tianjin Declaration, Kyrgyzstan holds the 2025-26 chairmanship and the next summit is scheduled for Bishkek, while India's own accession to full membership in 2017 is treated as chronology owned by the World History and Polity owners; the owners permit the summit and declaration to be cited as dated evidence of India's continued multilateral engagement and permit no claim about the declaration's contents beyond its adoption at that meeting.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- The 2025 Heads of State Council summit of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation met at Tianjin on 31 August and 1 September 2025 and adopted the Tianjin Declaration, Kyrgyzstan holds the 2025-26 chairmanship and the next summit is scheduled for Bishkek, while India's own accession to full membership in 2017 is treated as chronology owned by the World History and Polity owners; the owners permit the summit and declaration to be cited as dated evidence of India's continued multilateral engagement and permit no claim about the declaration's contents beyond its adoption at that meeting.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- The summit and declaration may be cited only as adopted at that meeting, with no claim about their contents.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact actor, document title, doctrine label, dated instrument and evidentiary level attached to The Tianjin summit and the current chairmanship, and never upgrade a vision statement into a treaty, a signature into a ratification, a participation category into membership, or an announced corridor into an operating one.
- **Mains:** Supply one dated multilateral anchor that proves continued engagement without overstating its substance.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** The Tianjin summit and the current chairmanship
- **Qualified use:** Supply one dated multilateral anchor that proves continued engagement without overstating its substance.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CORE - THE TIANJIN SUMMIT AND THE CURRENT CHAIRMANSHIP

START / CONCEPT: CORE - The Tianjin summit and the current chairmanship

|

v

EXACT TERMS: The Tianjin summit · the current chairmanship · Evidence chain · Qualified use · Heads
· 2025-26

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Evidence chain: The Tianjin summit and the current chairmanship Qualified use:
Supply one dated multilateral anchor that proves continued engagement without overstating its
substance.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Mains: Supply one dated multilateral anchor that proves continued
engagement without overstating its substance.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: the 2025 Heads of State Council
summit of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation met at...

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: The 2025 Heads of State Council summit of the Shanghai Cooperation
Organisation met at Tianjin on 31 August and 1 September 2025 and adopted the Tianjin Declaration,
Kyrgyzstan holds the 2025-26 chairmanship and the next summit is scheduled for Bishkek, while
India's own accession to full membership in 2017 is treated as chronology owned by the World
History and Polity owners; the owners permit the summit and declaration to be cited as dated
evidence of India's continued multilateral engagement and permit no claim about the declaration's
contents beyond its adoption at that meeting.

SESSION 7 - CORE - THE DEDICATED INDIA-CENTRAL ASIA SUMMIT AND DIALOGUE FORMAT

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Evidence chain: The dedicated India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue format Qualified use: Answer an increasing-significance demand honestly by pairing the dated mechanisms with the unheld summit.

Technical definition: The first India-Central Asia Summit was held virtually on 27 January 2022, the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue at foreign-minister level met in New Delhi on 6 June 2025 and envisaged preparing the ground for a second summit, and the third meeting of Secretaries of Security Councils and National Security Advisers met at Bishkek on 16 October 2025, while no second leader-level summit had been recorded as held by 3 August 2026; the owners treat that absence as a candid indicator that the dedicated format has not yet institutionalised at leader level, and they require the gap to be stated rather than glossed over when a demand asks about increasing significance.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The first India-Central Asia Summit was held virtually on 27 January 2022, the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue at foreign-minister level met in New Delhi on 6 June 2025 and envisaged preparing the ground for a second summit, and the third meeting of Secretaries of Security Councils and National Security Advisers met at Bishkek on 16 October 2025, while no second leader-level summit had been recorded as held by 3 August 2026; the owners treat that absence as a candid indicator that the dedicated format has not yet institutionalised at leader level, and they require the gap to be stated rather than glossed over when a demand asks about increasing significance.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- The dedicated India-Central Asia Summit
- Dialogue format
- Evidence chain
- Qualified use
- India-Central Asia Summit
- India-Central Asia Dialogue

How to use them: Frame the answer through The dedicated India-Central Asia Summit; define Dialogue format, connect Evidence chain with Qualified use to explain the mechanism, and use India-Central Asia Summit for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

THE DEDICATED INDIA-CENTRAL ASIA SUMMIT AND DIALOGUE FORMAT

01. The dedicated India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue format

BOUNDARY -> No second leader-level summit had been recorded as held by 3 August 2026, and that gap must be stated.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

The first India-Central Asia Summit was held virtually on 27 January 2022, the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue at foreign-minister level met in New Delhi on 6 June 2025 and envisaged preparing the ground for a second summit, and the third meeting of Secretaries of Security Councils and National Security Advisers met at Bishkek on 16 October 2025, while no second leader-level summit had been recorded as held by 3 August 2026; the owners treat that absence as a candid indicator that the dedicated format has not yet institutionalised at leader level, and they require the gap to be stated rather than glossed over when a demand asks about increasing significance.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- The first India-Central Asia Summit was held virtually on 27 January 2022, the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue at foreign-minister level met in New Delhi on 6 June 2025 and envisaged preparing the ground for a second summit, and the third meeting of Secretaries of Security Councils and National Security Advisers met at Bishkek on 16 October 2025, while no second leader-level summit had been recorded as held by 3 August 2026; the owners treat that absence as a candid indicator that the dedicated format has not yet institutionalised at leader level, and they require the gap to be stated rather than glossed over when a demand asks about increasing significance.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- No second leader-level summit had been recorded as held by 3 August 2026, and that gap must be stated.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact actor, document title, doctrine label, dated instrument and evidentiary level attached to The dedicated India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue format, and never upgrade a vision statement into a treaty, a signature into a ratification, a participation category into membership, or an announced corridor into an operating one.
- **Mains:** Answer an increasing-significance demand honestly by pairing the dated mechanisms with the unheld summit.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** The dedicated India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue format
- **Qualified use:** Answer an increasing-significance demand honestly by pairing the dated mechanisms with the unheld summit.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CORE - THE DEDICATED INDIA-CENTRAL ASIA SUMMIT AND DIALOGUE FORMAT

START / CONCEPT: CORE - The dedicated India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue format

|
v

EXACT TERMS: The dedicated India-Central Asia Summit · Dialogue format · Evidence chain · Qualified use · India-Central Asia Summit · India-Central Asia Dialogue

|
v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Evidence chain: The dedicated India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue format Qualified use: Answer an increasing-significance demand honestly by pairing the dated mechanisms with the unheld summit.

|
v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: No second leader-level summit had been recorded as held by 3 August 2026, and that gap must be stated.

|
v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: the first India-Central Asia Summit was held virtually on 27 January 2022, the fourth...

|
v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: The first India-Central Asia Summit was held virtually on 27 January 2022, the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue at foreign-minister level met in New Delhi on 6 June 2025 and envisaged preparing the ground for a second summit, and the third meeting of Secretaries of Security Councils and National Security Advisers met at Bishkek on 16 October 2025, while no second leader-level summit had been recorded as held by 3 August 2026; the owners treat that absence as a candid indicator that the dedicated format has not yet institutionalised at leader level, and they require the gap to be stated rather than glossed over when a demand asks about increasing significance.

SESSION 8 - CORE - THE CHABAHAR CONTRACT AS THE CONCRETE CONNECTIVITY INSTRUMENT

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: India Ports Global Limited and Iran's Ports and Maritime Organisation signed a ten-year long-term contract for Chabahar port on 13 May 2024, with India announcing roughly one hundred and twenty million United States dollars in equipment investment and a two hundred and fifty million United States dollar credit window for mutually identified infrastructure; the owners require these to be cited as announced investment and an announced credit window rather than as delivered equipment or disbursed finance, because an announcement and a delivery are different evidentiary levels and the difference is exactly what a critical demand tests.

Technical definition: Evidence chain: The Chabahar contract as the concrete connectivity instrument Qualified use: Cite the dated port instrument that a connectivity demand expects, priced at its exact evidentiary level.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Evidence chain: The Chabahar contract as the concrete connectivity instrument Qualified use: Cite the dated port instrument that a connectivity demand expects, priced at its exact evidentiary level.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- The Chabahar contract as the concrete connectivity instrument
- Evidence chain
- Qualified use
- India Ports Global Limited
- Iran's Ports
- Maritime Organisation

How to use them: Frame the answer through The Chabahar contract as the concrete connectivity instrument; define Evidence chain, connect Qualified use with India Ports Global Limited to explain the mechanism, and use Iran's Ports for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

THE CHABAHAR CONTRACT AS THE CONCRETE CONNECTIVITY INSTRUMENT

01. The Chabahar contract as the concrete connectivity instrument

BOUNDARY -> Announced investment and an announced credit window are not delivered equipment or disbursed finance.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

India Ports Global Limited and Iran's Ports and Maritime Organisation signed a ten-year long-term contract for Chabahar port on 13 May 2024, with India announcing roughly one hundred and twenty million United States dollars in equipment investment and a two hundred and fifty million United States dollar credit window for mutually identified infrastructure; the owners require these to be cited as announced investment and an announced credit window rather than as delivered equipment or disbursed finance, because an announcement and a delivery are different evidentiary levels and the difference is exactly what a critical demand tests.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- India Ports Global Limited and Iran's Ports and Maritime Organisation signed a ten-year long-term contract for Chabahar port on 13 May 2024, with India announcing roughly one hundred and twenty million United States dollars in equipment investment and a two hundred and fifty million United States dollar credit window for mutually identified infrastructure; the owners require these to be cited as announced investment and an announced credit window rather than as delivered equipment or disbursed finance, because an announcement and a delivery are different evidentiary levels and the difference is exactly what a critical demand tests.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- Announced investment and an announced credit window are not delivered equipment or disbursed finance.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact actor, document title, doctrine label, dated instrument and evidentiary level attached to The Chabahar contract as the concrete connectivity instrument, and never upgrade a vision statement into a treaty, a signature into a ratification, a participation category into membership, or an announced corridor into an operating one.
- **Mains:** Cite the dated port instrument that a connectivity demand expects, priced at its exact evidentiary level.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** The Chabahar contract as the concrete connectivity instrument
- **Qualified use:** Cite the dated port instrument that a connectivity demand expects, priced at its exact evidentiary level.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CORE - THE CHABAHAR CONTRACT AS THE CONCRETE CONNECTIVITY INSTRUMENT

START / CONCEPT: CORE - The Chabahar contract as the concrete connectivity instrument

|
v

EXACT TERMS: The Chabahar contract as the concrete connectivity instrument · Evidence chain · Qualified use · India Ports Global Limited · Iran's Ports · Maritime Organisation

|
v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: India Ports Global Limited and Iran's Ports and Maritime Organisation signed a ten-year long-term contract for Chabahar port on 13 May 2024, with India announcing roughly one hundred and twenty million United States dollars in equipment investment and a two hundred and fifty million United States dollar credit window for mutually identified infrastructure; the owners require these to be cited as announced investment and an announced credit window rather than as delivered equipment or disbursed finance, because an announcement and a delivery are different evidentiary levels and the difference is exactly what a critical demand tests.

|
v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Announced investment and an announced credit window are not delivered equipment or disbursed finance.

|
v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: the Chabahar contract as the concrete connectivity instrument Qualified use.

|
v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Evidence chain: The Chabahar contract as the concrete connectivity instrument Qualified use: Cite the dated port instrument that a connectivity demand expects, priced at its exact evidentiary level.

SESSION 9 - CORE - THE REVOKED WAIVER AS THIRD-PARTY SANCTIONS EXPOSURE

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: The United States State Department revoked the 2018 Chabahar sanctions waiver on 16 September 2025 with effect from 29 September 2025, and a subsequent assurance of non-exposure ran only to 26 April 2026, so any status beyond that date requires fresh verification; the owners state the legal character precisely, because this is a change in another state's domestic sanctions posture that creates exposure risk for entities rather than an international legal obligation binding on India, and its practical effect is to convert the Iran work-around from a geographic question into a financing and sanctions-exposure question.

Technical definition: Evidence chain: The revoked Chabahar waiver as third-party sanctions exposure Qualified use: Supply the decisive counter-evidence that converts the Iran route into a financing question.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The United States State Department revoked the 2018 Chabahar sanctions waiver on 16 September 2025 with effect from 29 September 2025, and a subsequent assurance of non-exposure ran only to 26 April 2026, so any status beyond that date requires fresh verification; the owners state the legal character precisely, because this is a change in another state's domestic sanctions posture that creates exposure risk for entities rather than an international legal obligation binding on India, and its practical effect is to convert the Iran work-around from a geographic question into a financing and sanctions-exposure question.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- The revoked waiver as third-party sanctions exposure
- Evidence chain
- Qualified use
- The United States State Department
- Chabahar
- India

How to use them: Frame the answer through The revoked waiver as third-party sanctions exposure; define Evidence chain, connect Qualified use with The United States State Department to explain the mechanism, and use Chabahar for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

THE REVOKED WAIVER AS THIRD-PARTY SANCTIONS EXPOSURE

01. The revoked Chabahar waiver as third-party sanctions exposure

BOUNDARY -> Exposure created by another state's domestic law is not an international legal obligation binding on India.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

The United States State Department revoked the 2018 Chabahar sanctions waiver on 16 September 2025 with effect from 29 September 2025, and a subsequent assurance of non-exposure ran only to 26 April 2026, so any status beyond that date requires fresh verification; the owners state the legal character precisely, because this is a change in another state's domestic sanctions posture that creates exposure risk for entities rather than an international legal obligation binding on India, and its practical effect is to convert the Iran work-around from a geographic question into a financing and sanctions-exposure question.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- The United States State Department revoked the 2018 Chabahar sanctions waiver on 16 September 2025 with effect from 29 September 2025, and a subsequent assurance of non-exposure ran only to 26 April 2026, so any status beyond that date requires fresh verification; the owners state the legal character precisely, because this is a change in another state's domestic sanctions posture that creates exposure risk for entities rather than an international legal obligation binding on India, and its practical effect is to convert the Iran work-around from a geographic question into a financing and sanctions-exposure question.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- Exposure created by another state's domestic law is not an international legal obligation binding on India.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact actor, document title, doctrine label, dated instrument and evidentiary level attached to The revoked waiver as third-party sanctions exposure, and never upgrade a vision statement into a treaty, a signature into a ratification, a participation category into membership, or an announced corridor into an operating one.
- **Mains:** Supply the decisive counter-evidence that converts the Iran route into a financing question.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** The revoked Chabahar waiver as third-party sanctions exposure
- **Qualified use:** Supply the decisive counter-evidence that converts the Iran route into a financing question.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CORE - THE REVOKED WAIVER AS THIRD-PARTY SANCTIONS EXPOSURE

START / CONCEPT: CORE - The revoked waiver as third-party sanctions exposure

|

v

EXACT TERMS: The revoked waiver as third-party sanctions exposure · Evidence chain · Qualified use
· The United States State Department · Chabahar · India

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Evidence chain: The revoked Chabahar waiver as third-party sanctions exposure
Qualified use: Supply the decisive counter-evidence that converts the Iran route into a financing question.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Exposure created by another state's domestic law is not an international legal obligation binding on India.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: supply the decisive counter-evidence that converts the Iran route into a financing question.

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: The United States State Department revoked the 2018 Chabahar sanctions waiver on 16 September 2025 with effect from 29 September 2025, and a subsequent assurance of non-exposure ran only to 26 April 2026, so any status beyond that date requires fresh verification; the owners state the legal character precisely, because this is a change in another state's domestic sanctions posture that creates exposure risk for entities rather than an international legal obligation binding on India, and its practical effect is to convert the Iran work-around from a geographic question into a financing and sanctions-exposure question.

SESSION 10 - CORE - CORRIDOR STATUS AND THE TRANSIT-RULES FRAMEWORK

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: The International North-South Transport Corridor is a connectivity framework intended to open a maritime-linked route to Central Asia and Eurasia bypassing Pakistan, and the owners require it to be treated as an announced and developing corridor with operating segments rather than a completed, full-capacity corridor; the same discipline extends to Chabahar, because connectivity-project timelines routinely lag announcements, so any specific capacity, throughput or completion claim requires independent dated verification instead of being assumed to match the original announcement.

Technical definition: Evidence chain: The corridor instruments and their exact completion status - The Ashgabat Agreement as a transit-rules framework
Qualified use: Refuse the completion narrative while still crediting the rules architecture India actually joined.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Evidence chain: The corridor instruments and their exact completion status - The Ashgabat Agreement as a transit-rules framework
Qualified use: Refuse the completion narrative while still crediting the rules architecture India actually joined.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Corridor status
- the transit-rules framework
- Evidence chain
- Qualified use
- The International North-South Transport Corridor
- Central Asia

How to use them: Frame the answer through Corridor status; define the transit-rules framework, connect Evidence chain with Qualified use to explain the mechanism, and use The International North-South Transport Corridor for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

CORRIDOR STATUS AND THE TRANSIT-RULES FRAMEWORK

01. The corridor instruments and their exact completion status

|
v

02. The Ashgabat Agreement as a transit-rules framework

BOUNDARY -> A developing corridor with operating segments is not a completed corridor, and a facilitation framework finances nothing.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

The International North-South Transport Corridor is a connectivity framework intended to open a maritime-linked route to Central Asia and Eurasia bypassing Pakistan, and the owners require it to be treated as an announced and developing corridor with operating segments rather than a completed, full-capacity corridor; the same discipline extends to Chabahar, because connectivity-project timelines routinely lag announcements, so any specific capacity, throughput or completion claim requires independent dated verification instead of being assumed to match the original announcement. The Ashgabat Agreement was signed at Ashgabat on 25 April 2011 to establish an international multimodal transport and transit corridor between Central Asia and the Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman, and India joined with effect from 3 February 2018, which adds a rules-and-transit framework to India's Chabahar and corridor strategy and reduces dependence on direct territorial access through Pakistan; the owners attach the limitation directly, because it is a facilitation framework rather than an infrastructure-finance mechanism, so its value depends on connected ports, rail and road segments, customs coordination and Iran-related sanctions exposure.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- The International North-South Transport Corridor is a connectivity framework intended to open a maritime-linked route to Central Asia and Eurasia bypassing Pakistan, and the owners require it to be treated as an announced and developing corridor with operating segments rather than a completed, full-capacity corridor; the same discipline extends to Chabahar, because connectivity-project timelines routinely lag announcements, so any specific capacity, throughput or completion claim requires independent dated verification instead of being assumed to match the original announcement.
- The Ashgabat Agreement was signed at Ashgabat on 25 April 2011 to establish an international multimodal transport and transit corridor between Central Asia and the Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman, and India joined with effect from 3 February 2018, which adds a rules-and-transit framework to India's Chabahar and corridor strategy and reduces dependence on direct territorial access through Pakistan; the owners attach the limitation directly, because it is a facilitation framework rather than an infrastructure-finance mechanism, so its value depends on connected ports, rail and road segments, customs coordination and Iran-related sanctions exposure.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- A developing corridor with operating segments is not a completed corridor, and a facilitation framework finances nothing.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact actor, document title, doctrine label, dated instrument and evidentiary level attached to Corridor status and the transit-rules framework, and never upgrade a vision statement into a treaty, a signature into a ratification, a participation category into membership, or an announced corridor into an operating one.
- **Mains:** Refuse the completion narrative while still crediting the rules architecture India actually joined.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** The corridor instruments and their exact completion status -> The Ashgabat Agreement as a transit-rules framework
- **Qualified use:** Refuse the completion narrative while still crediting the rules architecture India actually joined.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CORE - CORRIDOR STATUS AND THE TRANSIT-RULES FRAMEWORK

START / CONCEPT: CORE - Corridor status and the transit-rules framework

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v

EXACT TERMS: Corridor status · the transit-rules framework · Evidence chain · Qualified use · The International North-South Transport Corridor · Central Asia

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: The International North-South Transport Corridor is a connectivity framework intended to open a maritime-linked route to Central Asia and Eurasia bypassing Pakistan, and the owners require it to be treated as an announced and developing corridor with operating segments rather than a completed, full-capacity corridor; the same discipline extends to Chabahar, because connectivity-project timelines routinely lag announcements, so any specific capacity, throughput or completion claim requires independent dated verification instead of being assumed to match the original announcement.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: A developing corridor with operating segments is not a completed corridor, and a facilitation framework finances nothing.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: The Ashgabat Agreement was signed at Ashgabat on 25 April 2011 to establish an international multimodal transport and transit corridor between Central Asia and the Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman, and India joined with effect from 3 February 2018, which adds a rules-and-transit framework to India's Chabahar and corridor strategy and reduces dependence on direct territorial access through Pakistan; the owners attach the limitation directly, because it is a facilitation framework rather than an infrastructure-finance mechanism, so its value depends on connected ports, rail and road segments, customs coordination and Iran-related sanctions exposure.

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Evidence chain: The corridor instruments and their exact completion status - The Ashgabat Agreement as a transit-rules framework Qualified use: Refuse the completion narrative while still crediting the rules architecture India actually joined.

SESSION 11 - CORE - THE DATED BILATERAL RECORD INSIDE THE REGION

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: The Ministry of External Affairs India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief is current as on April 2026 and is the authoritative dated record for that relationship, and the owners instruct that this brief be cited for any specific current claim about it rather than a general assertion of warm ties; the wider methodological point is that a region-level policy claim and a country-level status claim require different evidence, so a candidate should name the dated brief when the demand turns on the present state of a particular bilateral relationship.

Technical definition: Evidence chain: The dated bilateral record inside the region Qualified use: Cite the dated bilateral brief when a demand turns on the present state of one relationship.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Evidence chain: The dated bilateral record inside the region Qualified use: Cite the dated bilateral brief when a demand turns on the present state of one relationship.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- The dated bilateral record inside the region
- Evidence chain
- Qualified use
- The Ministry of External Affairs India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief
- The Ministry
- External Affairs India-Uzbekistan

How to use them: Frame the answer through The dated bilateral record inside the region; define Evidence chain, connect Qualified use with The Ministry of External Affairs India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief to explain the mechanism, and use The Ministry for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

THE DATED BILATERAL RECORD INSIDE THE REGION

01. The dated bilateral record inside the region

BOUNDARY -> A region-level policy claim and a country-level status claim require different evidence.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

The Ministry of External Affairs India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief is current as on April 2026 and is the authoritative dated record for that relationship, and the owners instruct that this brief be cited for any specific current claim about it rather than a general assertion of warm ties; the wider methodological point is that a region-level policy claim and a country-level status claim require different evidence, so a candidate should name the dated brief when the demand turns on the present state of a particular bilateral relationship.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- The Ministry of External Affairs India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief is current as on April 2026 and is the authoritative dated record for that relationship, and the owners instruct that this brief be cited for any specific current claim about it rather than a general assertion of warm ties; the wider methodological point is that a region-level policy claim and a country-level status claim require different evidence, so a candidate should name the dated brief when the demand turns on the present state of a particular bilateral relationship.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- A region-level policy claim and a country-level status claim require different evidence.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact actor, document title, doctrine label, dated instrument and evidentiary level attached to The dated bilateral record inside the region, and never upgrade a vision statement into a treaty, a signature into a ratification, a participation category into membership, or an announced corridor into an operating one.
- **Mains:** Cite the dated bilateral brief when a demand turns on the present state of one relationship.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** The dated bilateral record inside the region
- **Qualified use:** Cite the dated bilateral brief when a demand turns on the present state of one relationship.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CORE - THE DATED BILATERAL RECORD INSIDE THE REGION

START / CONCEPT: CORE - The dated bilateral record inside the region

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v

EXACT TERMS: The dated bilateral record inside the region · Evidence chain · Qualified use · The Ministry of External Affairs India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief · The Ministry · External Affairs India-Uzbekistan

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: The Ministry of External Affairs India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief is current as on April 2026 and is the authoritative dated record for that relationship, and the owners instruct that this brief be cited for any specific current claim about it rather than a general assertion of warm ties; the wider methodological point is that a region-level policy claim and a country-level status claim require different evidence, so a candidate should name the dated brief when the demand turns on the present state of a particular bilateral relationship.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: The resulting consequence is that the dated bilateral record inside the region Qualified use.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: the dated bilateral record inside the region Qualified use.

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Evidence chain: The dated bilateral record inside the region Qualified use: Cite the dated bilateral brief when a demand turns on the present state of one relationship.

SESSION 12 - CORE - THE NEW GREAT GAME AND THE LIMITS OF INDIAN AGENCY

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Evidence chain: The New Great Game as multi-actor competition without Indian determinism
Qualified use: Place India's effort inside a competitive field, which is what a critical directive on this topic rewards.

Technical definition: The framing describes multi-actor competition and never Indian determinism over regional outcomes.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Evidence chain: The New Great Game as multi-actor competition without Indian determinism
Qualified use: Place India's effort inside a competitive field, which is what a critical directive on this topic rewards.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- The New Great Game
- the limits of Indian agency
- Evidence chain
- Qualified use
- Sikri
- Central Asia

How to use them: Frame the answer through The New Great Game; define the limits of Indian agency, connect Evidence chain with Qualified use to explain the mechanism, and use Sikri for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

THE NEW GREAT GAME AND THE LIMITS OF INDIAN AGENCY

01. The New Great Game as multi-actor competition without Indian determinism

BOUNDARY -> The framing describes multi-actor competition and never Indian determinism over regional outcomes.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

Sikri frames Central Asia as a geographical area that abuts on the borders of major powers in Asia and will always attract foreign presences, which describes ongoing great-power competition for influence rather than any Indian ability to determine regional outcomes, and the owners add that Russia's and China's greater historical and geographic proximity constrains how much relative influence India can realistically build however effective its own diplomacy; the examinable consequence is that outcomes in this region are co-determined by Russian, Chinese and Western engagement, so an answer must place India's effort inside a competitive field rather than presenting it as the decisive variable.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- Sikri frames Central Asia as a geographical area that abuts on the borders of major powers in Asia and will always attract foreign presences, which describes ongoing great-power competition for influence rather than any Indian ability to determine regional outcomes, and the owners add that Russia's and China's greater historical and geographic proximity constrains how much relative influence India can realistically build however effective its own diplomacy; the examinable consequence is that outcomes in this region are co-determined by Russian, Chinese and Western engagement, so an answer must place India's effort inside a competitive field rather than presenting it as the decisive variable.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- The framing describes multi-actor competition and never Indian determinism over regional outcomes.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact actor, document title, doctrine label, dated instrument and evidentiary level attached to The New Great Game and the limits of Indian agency, and never upgrade a vision statement into a treaty, a signature into a ratification, a participation category into membership, or an announced corridor into an operating one.
- **Mains:** Place India's effort inside a competitive field, which is what a critical directive on this topic rewards.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** The New Great Game as multi-actor competition without Indian determinism
- **Qualified use:** Place India's effort inside a competitive field, which is what a critical directive on this topic rewards.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CORE - THE NEW GREAT GAME AND THE LIMITS OF INDIAN AGENCY

START / CONCEPT: CORE - The New Great Game and the limits of Indian agency

|

v

EXACT TERMS: The New Great Game · the limits of Indian agency · Evidence chain · Qualified use · Sikri · Central Asia

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Sikri frames Central Asia as a geographical area that abuts on the borders of major powers in Asia and will always attract foreign presences, which describes ongoing great-power competition for influence rather than any Indian ability to determine regional outcomes, and the owners add that Russia's and China's greater historical and geographic proximity constrains how much relative influence India can realistically build however effective its own diplomacy; the examinable consequence is that outcomes in this region are co-determined by Russian, Chinese and Western engagement, so an answer must place India's effort inside a competitive field rather than presenting it as the decisive variable.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: The framing describes multi-actor competition and never Indian determinism over regional outcomes.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: place India's effort inside a competitive field, which is what a critical directive on...

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Evidence chain: The New Great Game as multi-actor competition without Indian determinism Qualified use: Place India's effort inside a competitive field, which is what a critical directive on this topic rewards.

SESSION 13 - CORE SYNTHESIS - PLATFORM WITHOUT PRIVILEGED ACCESS AND THE CASE FOR FUNCTIONAL COOPERATION

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: India's full membership of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation provides a seat and a platform but not privileged influence, because the same forum includes China, Russia and Pakistan, so its outputs reflect compromise among competing major-power interests rather than an India-centred agenda, and Pakistan's own membership means the forum cannot itself resolve the transit-access problem; the owners therefore separate two claims that answers routinely merge, namely that membership sustains political, security and economic engagement, and that membership does not by itself create physical connectivity, which depends on separate corridor projects.

Technical definition: Evidence chain: Membership without privileged access - Cooperative management of a shared external dependency Qualified use: Escape the crude choice between pure rivalry and naive partnership by separating the functional issue.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

India's full membership of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation provides a seat and a platform but not privileged influence, because the same forum includes China, Russia and Pakistan, so its outputs reflect compromise among competing major-power interests rather than an India-centred agenda, and Pakistan's own membership means the forum cannot itself resolve the transit-access problem; the owners therefore separate two claims that answers routinely merge, namely that membership sustains political, security and economic engagement, and that membership does not by itself create physical connectivity, which depends on separate corridor projects.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **CORE SYNTHESIS**
- **Platform without privileged access**
- **the case for functional cooperation**
- **Evidence chain**
- **Qualified use**
- **India's**

How to use them: Frame the answer through CORE SYNTHESIS; define Platform without privileged access, connect the case for functional cooperation with Evidence chain to explain the mechanism, and use Qualified use for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

PLATFORM WITHOUT PRIVILEGED ACCESS AND THE CASE FOR FUNCTIONAL COOPERATION

01. Membership without privileged access

|
v

02. Cooperative management of a shared external dependency

BOUNDARY -> Membership sustains engagement without creating physical connectivity, and cooperation on one function does not dissolve strategic mistrust.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

India's full membership of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation provides a seat and a platform but not privileged influence, because the same forum includes China, Russia and Pakistan, so its outputs reflect compromise among competing major-power interests rather than an India-centred agenda, and Pakistan's own membership means the forum cannot itself resolve the transit-access problem; the owners therefore separate two claims that answers routinely merge, namely that membership sustains political, security and economic engagement, and that membership does not by itself create physical connectivity, which depends on separate corridor projects. Sikri argues that India must try to develop an understanding on energy with China because both are major energy consumers often seeking energy from the same sources and their competition is only benefiting the energy producers, which the owners treat as a rare explicit call for cooperative management of a shared dependency despite broader strategic mistrust; the analytical value of this anchor is that it shows competition and cooperation coexisting on a specific functional issue, so a critical answer can avoid the crude choice between pure rivalry and naive partnership.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- India's full membership of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation provides a seat and a platform but not privileged influence, because the same forum includes China, Russia and Pakistan, so its outputs reflect compromise among competing major-power interests rather than an India-centred agenda, and Pakistan's own membership means the forum cannot itself resolve the transit-access problem; the owners therefore separate two claims that answers routinely merge, namely that membership sustains political, security and economic engagement, and that membership does not by itself create physical connectivity, which depends on separate corridor projects.
- Sikri argues that India must try to develop an understanding on energy with China because both are major energy consumers often seeking energy from the same sources and their competition is only benefiting the energy producers, which the owners treat as a rare explicit call for cooperative management of a shared dependency despite broader strategic mistrust; the analytical value of this anchor is that it shows competition and cooperation

coexisting on a specific functional issue, so a critical answer can avoid the crude choice between pure rivalry and naive partnership.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- Membership sustains engagement without creating physical connectivity, and cooperation on one function does not dissolve strategic mistrust.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact actor, document title, doctrine label, dated instrument and evidentiary level attached to Platform without privileged access and the case for functional cooperation, and never upgrade a vision statement into a treaty, a signature into a ratification, a participation category into membership, or an announced corridor into an operating one.
- **Mains:** Escape the crude choice between pure rivalry and naive partnership by separating the functional issue.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** Membership without privileged access -> Cooperative management of a shared external dependency
- **Qualified use:** Escape the crude choice between pure rivalry and naive partnership by separating the functional issue.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CORE SYNTHESIS - PLATFORM WITHOUT PRIVILEGED ACCESS AND THE CASE FOR FUNCTIONAL COOPERATION

START / CONCEPT: CORE SYNTHESIS - Platform without privileged access and the case for functional cooperation

|

v

EXACT TERMS: CORE SYNTHESIS • Platform without privileged access • the case for functional cooperation • Evidence chain • Qualified use • India's

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Evidence chain: Membership without privileged access - Cooperative management of a shared external dependency Qualified use: Escape the crude choice between pure rivalry and naive partnership by separating the functional issue.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Membership sustains engagement without creating physical connectivity, and cooperation on one function does not dissolve strategic mistrust.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Sikri argues that India must try to develop an understanding on energy with China because both are major energy consumers often seeking energy from the same sources and their competition is only benefiting the energy producers, which the owners treat as a rare explicit call for cooperative management of a shared dependency despite broader strategic mistrust; the analytical value of this anchor is that it shows competition and cooperation coexisting on a specific functional issue, so a critical answer can avoid the crude choice between pure rivalry and naive partnership.

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: India's full membership of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation provides a seat and a platform but not privileged influence, because the same forum includes China, Russia and Pakistan, so its outputs reflect compromise among competing major-power interests rather than an India-centred agenda, and Pakistan's own membership means the forum cannot itself resolve the transit-access problem; the owners therefore separate two claims that answers routinely merge, namely that membership sustains political, security and economic engagement, and that membership does not by itself create physical connectivity, which depends on separate corridor projects.

SESSION 14 - CORE SYNTHESIS - AFGHANISTAN'S DOUBLE ROLE AND THE SUBSTITUTED DEPENDENCY

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Evidence chain: Afghanistan as simultaneously the bridge and the barrier - Substituted dependency rather than eliminated dependency Qualified use: Deliver the honest verdict that the problem is converting goodwill into reliable access across contested transit space.

Technical definition: The maritime-linked work-around through Iran bypasses the Pakistan land constraint but substitutes one set of external dependencies, namely Iran-linked geopolitics and sanctions risk, for another, so no unilateral connectivity solution exists and the dependency problem is managed rather than removed; the owners pair this with the timeline warning that announcements outrun delivery in this sector, which together give the honest verdict that India's Central Asia problem is not an absence of interest but the conversion of diplomatic goodwill into reliable access across contested transit space.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Evidence chain: Afghanistan as simultaneously the bridge and the barrier - Substituted dependency rather than eliminated dependency Qualified use: Deliver the honest verdict that the problem is converting goodwill into reliable access across contested transit space.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- CORE SYNTHESIS
- Afghanistan's double role
- the substituted dependency
- Evidence chain
- Qualified use
- Afghanistan

How to use them: Frame the answer through CORE SYNTHESIS; define Afghanistan's double role, connect the substituted dependency with Evidence chain to explain the mechanism, and use Qualified use for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

AFGHANISTAN'S DOUBLE ROLE AND THE SUBSTITUTED DEPENDENCY

01. Afghanistan as simultaneously the bridge and the barrier

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02. Substituted dependency rather than eliminated dependency

BOUNDARY -> The shortest route is the least available one, and the work-around manages rather than removes dependence.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

Afghanistan sits at the centre of the connectivity problem because it is the potential land-bridge to Central Asia while being itself a source of instability that currently forecloses that option, and the owners record this as a genuine unresolved tension rather than a solved problem; the consequence for answer writing is that Afghanistan cannot be treated either as a ready corridor or as an irrelevant space, and any recommendation must be calibrated to a situation in which the shortest route is the least available one. The maritime-linked work-around through Iran bypasses the Pakistan land constraint but substitutes one set of external dependencies, namely Iran-linked geopolitics and sanctions risk, for another, so no unilateral connectivity solution exists and the dependency problem is managed rather than removed; the owners pair this with the timeline warning that announcements outrun delivery in this sector, which together give the honest verdict that India's Central Asia problem is not an absence of interest but the conversion of diplomatic goodwill into reliable access across contested transit space.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- Afghanistan sits at the centre of the connectivity problem because it is the potential land-bridge to Central Asia while being itself a source of instability that currently forecloses that option, and the owners record this as a genuine unresolved tension rather than a solved problem; the consequence for answer writing is that Afghanistan cannot be treated either as a ready corridor or as an irrelevant space, and any recommendation must be calibrated to a situation in which the shortest route is the least available one.
- The maritime-linked work-around through Iran bypasses the Pakistan land constraint but substitutes one set of external dependencies, namely Iran-linked geopolitics and sanctions risk, for another, so no unilateral connectivity solution exists and the dependency problem is managed rather than removed; the owners pair this with the timeline warning that announcements outrun delivery in this sector, which together give the honest verdict that India's Central Asia problem is not an absence of interest but the conversion of diplomatic goodwill into reliable access across contested transit space.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- The shortest route is the least available one, and the work-around manages rather than removes dependence.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact actor, document title, doctrine label, dated instrument and evidentiary level attached to Afghanistan's double role and the substituted dependency, and never upgrade a vision statement into a treaty, a signature into a ratification, a participation category into membership, or an announced corridor into an operating one.
- **Mains:** Deliver the honest verdict that the problem is converting goodwill into reliable access across contested transit space.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** Afghanistan as simultaneously the bridge and the barrier -> Substituted dependency rather than eliminated dependency
- **Qualified use:** Deliver the honest verdict that the problem is converting goodwill into reliable access across contested transit space.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CORE SYNTHESIS - AFGHANISTAN'S DOUBLE ROLE AND THE SUBSTITUTED DEPENDENCY

START / CONCEPT: CORE SYNTHESIS - Afghanistan's double role and the substituted dependency

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EXACT TERMS: CORE SYNTHESIS · Afghanistan's double role · the substituted dependency · Evidence chain · Qualified use · Afghanistan

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MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: The maritime-linked work-around through Iran bypasses the Pakistan land constraint but substitutes one set of external dependencies, namely Iran-linked geopolitics and sanctions risk, for another, so no unilateral connectivity solution exists and the dependency problem is managed rather than removed; the owners pair this with the timeline warning that announcements outrun delivery in this sector, which together give the honest verdict that India's Central Asia problem is not an absence of interest but the conversion of diplomatic goodwill into reliable access across contested transit space.

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CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Afghanistan sits at the centre of the connectivity problem because it is the potential land-bridge to Central Asia while being itself a source of instability that currently forecloses that option, and the owners record this as a genuine unresolved tension rather than a solved problem; the consequence for answer writing is that Afghanistan cannot be treated either as a ready corridor or as an irrelevant space, and any recommendation must be calibrated to a situation in which the shortest route is the least available one.

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UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: The shortest route is the least available one, and the work-around manages rather than removes dependence.

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ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Evidence chain: Afghanistan as simultaneously the bridge and the barrier - Substituted dependency rather than eliminated dependency Qualified use: Deliver the honest verdict that the problem is converting goodwill into reliable access across contested transit space.

SESSION 15 - CORE SYNTHESIS - HONEST QUESTION OWNERSHIP FOR THIS EURASIAN OWNER

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: The audited ledgers route two General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, namely 2018 General Studies Paper II question 10 on outside powers in Central Asia and India joining the Ashgabat Agreement, a Discuss the implications demand of 10 marks and 150 words for which the ledger records that the printed word-limit tail was corrupted in the scan and that the Core route supersedes the older Advanced ownership, and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 10 on India's evolving relations with the Central Asian Republics, a Critically analyse demand of 10 marks and 150 words; one objective demand is also routed here and carried as a coverage requirement only, namely 2025 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 62 on International North-South Transport Corridor connectivity, for which the official Set-A key is present locally while no option or answer letter is recorded or inferred; the locally held OCR-searchable official papers were read only to confirm printed wording and no question, key or marking scheme was imported from them.

Technical definition: (10 marks, 150 words) - this is the anchor PYQ for this topic. **FACT:** A strong answer to 2024 Q10 should cite the Connect Central Asia Policy (2012), the proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement, SCO membership, and the energy/connectivity constraint (Afghanistan/Pakistan access problem) as concrete evidence of both the relationship's evolution and its structural limits. **ANALYSIS:** The first India-Central Asia Summit (27 January 2022, held virtually) and the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue (New Delhi, 6 June 2025) illustrate the "increasing significance" the question asks about - **ANALYSIS:** but a second leader-level summit had not been recorded as held by 3 August 2026, which is itself an honest indicator of the pace of institutionalisation.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Evidence chain: Honest question ownership for this Eurasian owner Qualified use: Close with an explicit ownership boundary that keeps the package honest about what the ledgers actually record.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- CORE SYNTHESIS
- Honest question ownership for this Eurasian owner
- Evidence chain
- Qualified use
- Subject
- Tier

How to use them: Frame the answer through CORE SYNTHESIS; define Honest question ownership for this Eurasian owner, connect Evidence chain with Qualified use to explain the mechanism, and use Subject for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

HONEST QUESTION OWNERSHIP FOR THIS EURASIAN OWNER

01. Honest question ownership for this Eurasian owner

BOUNDARY -> A corrupted printed word-limit tail is reported rather than repaired, and no routed objective demand is answered from a key.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

The audited ledgers route two General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, namely 2018 General Studies Paper II question 10 on outside powers in Central Asia and India joining the Ashgabat Agreement, a Discuss the implications demand of 10 marks and 150 words for which the ledger records that the printed word-limit tail was corrupted in the scan and that the Core route supersedes the older Advanced ownership, and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 10 on India's evolving relations with the Central Asian Republics, a Critically analyse demand of 10 marks and 150 words; one objective demand is also routed here and carried as a coverage requirement only, namely 2025 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 62 on International North-South Transport Corridor connectivity, for which the official Set-A key is present locally while no option or answer letter is recorded or inferred; the locally held OCR-searchable official papers were read only to confirm printed wording and no question, key or marking scheme was imported from them.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- The audited ledgers route two General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, namely 2018 General Studies Paper II question 10 on outside powers in Central Asia and India joining the Ashgabat Agreement, a Discuss the implications demand of 10 marks and 150 words for which the ledger records that the printed word-limit tail was corrupted in the scan and that the Core route supersedes the older Advanced ownership, and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 10 on India's evolving relations with the Central Asian Republics, a Critically analyse demand of 10 marks and 150 words; one objective demand is also routed here and carried as a coverage requirement only, namely 2025 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 62 on International North-South Transport Corridor connectivity, for which the official Set-A key is present locally while no option or answer letter is recorded or inferred; the locally held OCR-searchable official papers were read only to confirm printed wording and no question, key or marking scheme was imported from them.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- A corrupted printed word-limit tail is reported rather than repaired, and no routed objective demand is answered from a key.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact actor, document title, doctrine label, dated instrument and evidentiary level attached to Honest question ownership for this Eurasian owner, and never upgrade a vision statement into a treaty, a signature into a ratification, a participation category into membership, or an announced corridor into an operating one.
- **Mains:** Close with an explicit ownership boundary that keeps the package honest about what the ledgers actually record.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** Honest question ownership for this Eurasian owner
- **Qualified use:** Close with an explicit ownership boundary that keeps the package honest about what the ledgers actually record.

COMPLETE BASIC OWNER EVIDENCE BANK

Subject: International Relations | **Tier:** Must-Do (foundation) | **GS Paper:** GS-II. **Core area:** The five Central Asian Republics (CARs); the India-Central Asia Dialogue; the Connect Central Asia Policy; security, energy and connectivity constraints. **Grounded in:** M. Laxmikanth, *Indian Polity* (Connect Central Asia Policy section); Rajiv Sikri, *Challenges and Strategy*; MEA India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief; 00_Master-Framework.md Sections 2 and 5. **FACT:** = source-grounded | **ANALYSIS:** = analytical inference | **CURRENT:** = current anchor. *Companion:* advanced/05_Central-Asia-Eurasia-and-Connectivity.md.

1. Visual foundation



Core proposition: ANALYSIS: India's Central Asia engagement pursues genuine energy, security and connectivity interests through a mix of bilateral diplomacy and multilateral platforms (SCO, the Dialogue mechanism), but is structurally constrained by the region's landlocked geography and India's lack of direct land access - a constraint that shapes every connectivity initiative discussed here.

2. Essential definitions

Concept	Exam-ready meaning
FACT: Connect Central Asia Policy (2012)	FACT: Launched in 2012, this policy aims at "strengthening and expanding... India's relations with the Central Asian countries" (Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan) through "a broad-based approach including political, security, economic and cultural connections."
FACT: Multilateral engagement channels	FACT: India engages Central Asia partly through "existing fora like the SCO, Eurasian Economic Community (EEC) and the Custom Union," and has "proposed a Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement to integrate its markets with the... Eurasian space." CURRENT: That proposal is now pursued as the India-Eurasian Economic Union (EAEU) free-trade negotiation , formally begun on 3 June 2017 at St Petersburg and still under negotiation - the second round was held in Moscow on 22-25 June 2026. ANALYSIS: Under negotiation, not signed or in force.
CURRENT: India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue	The dedicated, region-specific mechanisms: the first India-Central Asia Summit was held virtually on 27 January 2022; the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue (foreign-minister level) met in New Delhi on 6 June 2025 and envisaged preparing the ground for a second summit; the third meeting of Secretaries of Security Councils/NSAs met at Bishkek on 16 October 2025. ANALYSIS: A second summit had not been recorded as held by 3 August 2026.
FACT: SCO membership and participation tiers	ANALYSIS: Sikri's book-period note that Pakistan, Iran and Mongolia "held observer status" is period-specific. CURRENT: As of 3 August 2026 the SCO has 10 full members (Belarus, China, India, Iran, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Pakistan, Russia, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan), 2 observers (Afghanistan and Mongolia) and 15 dialogue partners - Pakistan and Iran are now members, not observers. A 1 September 2025 decision envisages consolidating the observer/dialogue-partner categories into a single "SCO Partner" status, but the enabling amendments had not entered into force.
ANALYSIS: "New Great Game"	FACT: Sikri's framing that Central Asia, "as a geographical area that abuts on the borders of major powers in Asia... will always attract foreign presences" - describing ongoing great-power competition for influence, not Indian determinism over the outcome.
ANALYSIS: Connectivity constraint	India's lack of direct land access to Central Asia (absent transit through Pakistan or Afghanistan) is the structural limitation every connectivity initiative (INSTC, Chabahar) must address.

3. How the Central Asia engagement mechanism works

- Policy launch and scope:** FACT: the Connect Central Asia Policy (2012) establishes a broad-based political-security-economic-cultural engagement framework with the five CARs.
- Multilateral channel use:** FACT: India uses SCO, the EEC and Custom Union fora for "multilateral engagement with Central Asian partners," alongside a proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement to integrate markets with the Eurasian space.
- Energy/resource rationale:** FACT: India looks to Central Asia "as a long-term partner in energy[] and natural resources," given the region's substantial hydrocarbon and mineral endowment.

4. **Connectivity constraint identification:** FACT: Sikri notes any energy pipeline

from Eurasia to India not crossing Afghanistan/Pakistan "has to be routed via Xinjiang and then across the Karakoram and the Himalayan mountain ranges" - illustrating that every connectivity route faces a serious geographic or security constraint.

5. **Great-power-competition backdrop:** FACT: Sikri's "New Great Game" framing

places India's engagement within a wider field of external actors (Russia, China, the US, and others) also competing for regional influence, without any single power holding a determinative position.

4. **Institutions and agreements**

- FACT: **Connect Central Asia Policy (2012):** the foundational Indian policy document/approach for the region.

- FACT: **Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO):** the principal multilateral forum linking India with Central Asia, China, Russia and Pakistan (India became a full member in 2017 - World History/Polity own precise accession chronology). CURRENT: The 2025 Heads of State Council summit met at Tianjin on 31 August-1 September 2025 and adopted the **Tianjin Declaration**; Kyrgyzstan holds the 2025-26 chairmanship, with the next summit scheduled for Bishkek.

- CURRENT: **India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue:** first Summit 27 January 2022 (virtual); fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue, New Delhi, 6 June 2025; third NSA/Security Council Secretaries' meeting, Bishkek, 16 October 2025.

- CURRENT: **India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief (as on April 2026):** the current authoritative MEA record for the India-Uzbekistan relationship - cite this dated brief for any specific current claim.

- CURRENT: **Chabahar port (Iran):** India Ports Global Limited and Iran's Ports and Maritime Organisation signed a **10-year long-term contract on 13 May 2024**, with India announcing roughly USD 120 million in equipment investment and a USD 250 million credit window for mutually identified infrastructure. ANALYSIS: The US State Department revoked the 2018 sanctions waiver on 16 September 2025, effective **29 September 2025**, with a subsequent assurance of non-exposure running to 26 April 2026 - status beyond that date requires fresh verification. ANALYSIS: Sanctions exposure is a risk to Indian entities, not a legal obligation on India.

- ANALYSIS: **INSTC (International North-South Transport Corridor):** a connectivity framework intended to open a maritime-linked route to Central Asia/Eurasia bypassing Pakistan - treat as an announced/developing corridor with operating segments, not a completed, full-capacity corridor.

- FACT: **Ashgabat Agreement:** signed at Ashgabat on **25 April 2011** to establish an international multimodal transport and transit corridor between Central Asia and the Persian Gulf/Gulf of Oman. India joined with effect from **3 February 2018**. **Significance:** it adds a rules-and-transit framework to India's Chabahar/INSTC strategy and reduces dependence on direct territorial access through Pakistan. **Limitation:** it is a facilitation framework, not an infrastructure-finance mechanism; value depends on connected ports, rail/road segments, customs coordination and Iran-related sanctions exposure.

- ANALYSIS: **India-EAEU FTA:** under negotiation since 3 June 2017; the second round met in Moscow on 22-25 June 2026. ANALYSIS: Negotiation, not signature.

5. **Indian applications and examples**

- FACT: **Direct PYQ (2024 Q10):** *Critically analyse India's evolving diplomatic, economic and strategic relations with the Central Asian Republics (CARs) highlighting their increasing significance in regional and global geopolitics. * (10 marks, 150 words) - this is the anchor PYQ for this topic.

- FACT: A strong answer to 2024 Q10 should cite the Connect Central Asia Policy (2012), the proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement, SCO membership, and the energy/connectivity constraint (Afghanistan/Pakistan access problem) as concrete evidence of both the relationship's evolution and its structural limits.

- ANALYSIS: The first India-Central Asia Summit (27 January 2022, held virtually) and

the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue (New Delhi, 6 June 2025) illustrate the "increasing significance" the question asks about - ANALYSIS: but a second leader-level summit had not been recorded as held by 3 August 2026, which is itself an honest indicator of the pace of institutionalisation.

6. Must-Know Facts for Prelims

- FACT: The Connect Central Asia Policy was launched in 2012.
- FACT: The five Central Asian Republics are Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan.
- FACT: India has proposed a Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement to integrate with the Eurasian economic space; this is pursued as the India-EAEU free-trade negotiation, formally begun 3 June 2017 and still under negotiation.
- CURRENT: The SCO has 10 full members, 2 observers (Afghanistan, Mongolia) and 15 dialogue partners; Pakistan and Iran are now full members, not observers, and Belarus joined in 2024.
- CURRENT: The 2025 SCO summit met at Tianjin (31 August-1 September 2025) and adopted the Tianjin Declaration; Kyrgyzstan chairs for 2025-26.
- CURRENT: The first India-Central Asia Summit was held virtually on 27 January 2022; the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue met in New Delhi on 6 June 2025.
- CURRENT: The 10-year Chabahar port contract between India Ports Global Limited and Iran's Ports and Maritime Organisation was signed on 13 May 2024; the US sanctions waiver for Chabahar was revoked effective 29 September 2025.
- FACT: Any Eurasia-to-India energy pipeline avoiding Afghanistan/Pakistan would need to route via Xinjiang and across the Karakoram/Himalayan ranges.
- CURRENT: The India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief is current as on April 2026.

7. UPSC traps

- WRONG: Central Asia is directly accessible to India by land. -> India has no direct land access to the CARs; Pakistan and Afghanistan sit between India and the region, which is the central connectivity constraint.
- WRONG: SCO membership alone resolves India's connectivity constraint with Central Asia. -> SCO is a political-security-economic forum; it does not by itself create physical connectivity, which depends on separate corridor projects (INSTC, Chabahar).
- WRONG: The "New Great Game" implies India can determine regional outcomes unilaterally. -> Sikri's framing explicitly describes multi-actor competition for influence, not Indian determinism.
- WRONG: India's Central Asia engagement is purely economic/energy-driven. -> The Connect Central Asia Policy is explicitly "broad-based," including political, security and cultural dimensions alongside economic ones.
- WRONG: INSTC/Chabahar are completed, fully functioning corridors at full capacity.
-> Treat these as developing connectivity frameworks with operating segments; do not assert completed capacity without a specific, dated, verified claim.
- WRONG: Pakistan and Iran are SCO observers. -> Both are now full SCO members (Pakistan since 2017, Iran since 2023); Afghanistan and Mongolia are the observers, and Belarus joined as a full member in 2024. Sikri's observer list is period-specific.
- WRONG: The revocation of the US Chabahar sanctions waiver (effective 29 September 2025. is a legal bar on India. -> It is a change in another state's domestic sanctions posture creating exposure risk for entities; it is not an international legal obligation binding on India.

8. CURRENT: Current anchor

- **CURRENT:** The **India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief (as on April 2026)** is the current dated MEA reference for that relationship. Three further dated anchors carry this topic: the **fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue (New Delhi, 6 June 2025)**, the **SCO Tianjin Declaration (31 August-1 September 2025)**, and the **revocation of the US Chabahar sanctions waiver (effective 29 September 2025)** - the last being the clearest current illustration that India's alternative-connectivity route remains exposed to third-party sanctions dynamics.

9. PYQ application

- **FACT: 2024 Q10 (direct):** *Critically analyse India's evolving diplomatic, economic and strategic relations with the Central Asian Republics (CARs) highlighting their increasing significance in regional and global geopolitics.* Structure: (1) list the five CARs and the Connect Central Asia Policy (2012); (2) cite the proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement and SCO engagement as the "evolving" economic/diplomatic dimension; (3) name the Afghanistan/Pakistan connectivity constraint and the Xinjiang/Karakoram alternative-route problem as the "critical" analytical dimension; (4) place the relationship within the "New Great Game" great-power-competition context to address "increasing significance in regional and global geopolitics."

10. Mains angles

- **ANALYSIS:** Always pair "increasing significance" claims with the specific connectivity constraint - examiners reward acknowledging the structural difficulty, not only listing opportunities.
- **ANALYSIS:** Distinguish SCO (broad multilateral, includes China/Pakistan/Russia) from the India-Central Asia Dialogue (region-specific, India-CAR only), and distinguish SCO membership from observer and dialogue-partner status.
- **ANALYSIS:** Use "broad-based" framing (political + security + economic + cultural) for the Connect Central Asia Policy rather than reducing it to energy alone.
- **ANALYSIS:** Cite the dated India-Uzbekistan brief (April 2026) for any current-status claim, and the Chabahar waiver revocation (29 September 2025) when discussing third-party constraints on India's connectivity options.

Answer thesis: India's Central Asia engagement has evolved from a 2012 broad-based policy into deeper multilateral (SCO) and proposed economic (Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement) integration, but its "increasing significance in regional and global geopolitics" must be assessed against the structural connectivity constraint imposed by the absence of direct land access and the ongoing great-power competition for regional influence.

11. Probable questions

- **ANALYSIS: Prelims:** In which year was India's Connect Central Asia Policy launched, and which five countries does it cover?
- **FACT: Mains (10 marks, direct 2024 PYQ):** Critically analyse India's evolving diplomatic, economic and strategic relations with the Central Asian Republics (CARs) highlighting their increasing significance in regional and global geopolitics.
- **ANALYSIS: Mains (15 marks):** Discuss the geographic and security constraints on India's connectivity ambitions in Central Asia.

11A. Answer architecture (10/15/20-mark support)

The **2018 GS-II outside powers/Ashgabat Agreement** demand is owned here, superseding advanced/05.

- **Structure:** strategic geography -> access constraint -> connectivity instrument -> security/energy interest -> competing powers -> feasibility limit.
- **Evidence:** SCO, India-Central Asia Dialogue, Chabahar, INSTC, Ashgabat Agreement,

Afghanistan/Pakistan blockage and Russia-China influence.

10 marks: importance plus three constraints/instruments. **15 marks:** energy, connectivity, counter-terrorism, great-power competition and implementation. **20 marks:** compare continental corridors, sanctions, Afghanistan, local sovereignty, SCO limits and India's maritime alternatives.

Reasoned verdict: India's Central Asia problem is not absence of interest but the conversion of diplomatic goodwill into reliable access across contested transit space.

12. Study links

- FACT: Advanced companion: advanced/05_Central-Asia-Eurasia-and-Connectivity.md.

- FACT: Geography/basic/34_World-Regional-Geography-Continents-Countries.md -

physical and route geography of Central Asia (Geography owns this detail).

- FACT: World-History/basic/15_Cold-War-and-International-Relations.md - Soviet-era chronology of the region (World History owns chronology).

- ANALYSIS: **Cross-links within this folder:** topic 03 for India-China energy

competition in the region; topic 10 for SCO's full institutional profile; topic 06 for the Chabahar/energy-connectivity linkage to West Asia.

Recent PYQ Integration (2024-2025)

Status: 2024-2025 question-level PYQ demand is integrated into this owner. **Provenance:** Audited local official-paper routing ledgers: _PYQ-ROUTING-MAINS-GS1-GS2-ESSAY-2024-2025.md, _PYQ-ROUTING-PRELIMS-2024-2025.md. **Answer-key rule:** The official 2024-2025 Prelims Set-A keys are present in the repository and CSAT Set-A keys are supplied; even so, no option or answer is recorded or inferred in this integration.

- **Years represented:** 2024, 2025

- **Paper(s):** GS-II, Prelims GS-I

- **Routed question demands:** 2

Year	Paper	Q	PYQ demand (neutral rendering)	Directive / format	Source status	Owner requirement
2024	GS-II	10	India's relations with the Central Asian Republics	Critically analyse · 10 marks · 150 words	Routed to owning topic	Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
2025	Prelims GS-I	62	International North-South Transport Corridor (INSTC) connectivity	Objective question; official Set-A key available locally, answer not inferred	Key available locally (official Set-A answer key present); answer not recorded here	Cover the named fact/concept and its likely statement-level distinctions.

What this owner must now support

- India's relations with the Central Asian Republics
- International North-South Transport Corridor (INSTC) connectivity

This block integrates the 2024-2025 examinable demand and paper metadata. It is kept separate from the 2018-2023 block and does not convert an unkeyed/answer-free objective question into a solved answer.

Historical PYQ Integration (2018-2023)

Status: Question-level PYQ demand is integrated into this owner. **Provenance:** Audited local official-paper routing ledgers: _PYQ-ROUTING-MAINS-GS1-GS2-ESSAY-2018-2023.md.

- **Years represented:** 2018

- **Paper(s):** GS-II
- **Routed question demands:** 1

Year	Paper	Q	PYQ demand (neutral rendering)	Directive / format	Source status	Owner requirement
2018	GS-II	10	Outside powers in Central Asia and India joining the Ashgabat Agreement	Discuss the implications · 10 marks · 150 words	Core route supersedes older Advanced ownership	Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.

What this owner must now support

- Outside powers in Central Asia and India joining the Ashgabat Agreement

The table integrates the examinable demand and paper metadata. It does not turn an unkeyed objective question into a solved answer, and it does not claim that lexical presence alone proves full conceptual sufficiency.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CORE SYNTHESIS - HONEST QUESTION OWNERSHIP FOR THIS EURASIAN OWNER

START / CONCEPT: CORE SYNTHESIS - Honest question ownership for this Eurasian owner

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EXACT TERMS: CORE SYNTHESIS · Honest question ownership for this Eurasian owner · Evidence chain · Qualified use · Subject · Tier

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MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: (10 marks, 150 words) - this is the anchor PYQ for this topic. FACT: A strong answer to 2024 Q10 should cite the Connect Central Asia Policy (2012), the proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement, SCO membership, and the energy/connectivity constraint (Afghanistan/Pakistan access problem) as concrete evidence of both the relationship's evolution and its structural limits. ANALYSIS: The first India-Central Asia Summit (27 January 2022, held virtually) and the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue (New Delhi, 6 June 2025) illustrate the "increasing significance" the question asks about - ANALYSIS: but a second leader-level summit had not been recorded as held by 3 August 2026, which is itself an honest indicator of the pace of institutionalisation.

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CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: The audited ledgers route two General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, namely 2018 General Studies Paper II question 10 on outside powers in Central Asia and India joining the Ashgabat Agreement, a Discuss the implications demand of 10 marks and 150 words for which the ledger records that the printed word-limit tail was corrupted in the scan and that the Core route supersedes the older Advanced ownership, and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 10 on India's evolving relations with the Central Asian Republics, a Critically analyse demand of 10 marks and 150 words; one objective demand is also routed here and carried as a coverage requirement only, namely 2025 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 62 on International North-South Transport Corridor connectivity, for which the official Set-A key is present locally while no option or answer letter is recorded or inferred; the locally held OCR-searchable official papers were read only to confirm printed wording and no question, key or marking scheme was imported from them.

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UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: FACT: The Connect Central Asia Policy was launched in 2012. FACT: The five Central Asian Republics are Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan. FACT: India has proposed a Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement to integrate with the Eurasian economic space; this is pursued as the India-EAEU free-trade negotiation, formally begun 3 June 2017 and still under negotiation. CURRENT: The SCO has 10 full members, 2 observers (Afghanistan, Mongolia) and 15 dialogue partners; Pakistan and Iran are now full members, not observers, and Belarus joined in 2024. CURRENT: The 2025 SCO summit met at Tianjin (31 August-1 September 2025) and adopted the Tianjin Declaration; Kyrgyzstan chairs for 2025-26. CURRENT: The first India-Central Asia Summit was held virtually on 27 January 2022; the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue met in New Delhi on 6 June 2025. CURRENT: The 10-year Chabahar port contract between India Ports Global Limited and Iran's Ports and Maritime Organisation was signed on 13 May 2024; the US sanctions waiver for Chabahar was revoked effective 29 September 2025. FACT: Any Eurasia-to-India energy pipeline avoiding Afghanistan/Pakistan would need to route via Xinjiang and across the Karakoram/Himalayan ranges. CURRENT: The India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief is current as on April 2026.

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ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Evidence chain: Honest question ownership for this Eurasian owner
Qualified use: Close with an explicit ownership boundary that keeps the package honest about what the ledgers actually record.

INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS DEEP-REVIEW CORE CONTROL

- **Must remember:** Central Asia and Eurasia policy connects continental access, energy, security, Afghanistan, diaspora and civilisational links with transport corridors and regional institutions under severe geography and sanctions constraints.
- **Close distinction:** INSTC, Chabahar, Ashgabat Agreement, SCO and bilateral connectivity projects have distinct memberships, legal bases, routes and operating stages; corridor announcement, trial movement, infrastructure completion and regular commercial viability are not interchangeable.
- **Status / evidence / implementation limit:** Map India-Iran-Russia-Central Asia interests alongside partner autonomy, financing, customs, insurance, sanctions and security bottlenecks; qualify route-time or trade claims by source and date and present alternatives rather than implying one corridor solves continental access.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Q1. Which statement correctly identifies What this Eurasian owner holds and how its boundaries are routed?

A. This topic owns the five Central Asian Republics, the Connect Central Asia Policy, the India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue mechanisms, India's Central Asian use of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the connectivity instruments of the International North-South Transport Corridor, Chabahar port and the Ashgabat Agreement, the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation and the New Great Game framing, and its distinctive feature is that its examinable spine is a constraint rather than an opportunity, because two verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2018 and 2024 and one objective demand from 2025 are routed here; the full institutional profile of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation belongs to topic 10, the India-China strategic relationship belongs to topic 03, the West Asian and energy-security limb of Chabahar belongs to topic 06, physical and route geography belongs to the Geography owner, and Soviet-era regional chronology with the nineteenth-century Great Game belongs to the World History owner. B. India engages Central Asia partly through existing fora described in the sources as the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the Eurasian Economic Community and the Custom Union, and it has proposed a Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement to integrate its markets with the Eurasian space; the examinable discipline is that a proposal is an instrument of intent rather than an operating arrangement, so an answer must name the proposal by its exact title and then trace what actually happened to it rather than implying that market integration has already occurred. C. The five Central Asian Republics are Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan, and the Connect Central Asia Policy launched in 2012 aims at strengthening and expanding India's relations with those countries through a broad-based approach including political, security, economic and cultural connections; the owners insist on the word broad-based because reducing the policy to energy alone misdescribes its declared scope, and they treat the 2012 launch as the foundational Indian policy approach against which every later mechanism in this topic is measured. D. The proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement is now pursued as the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation, which formally began on 3 June 2017 at St Petersburg and remained under negotiation, with the second round held in Moscow on 22-25 June 2026; the owners fix the status precisely as under negotiation and neither signed nor in force, so an answer may cite the dated rounds as evidence of sustained economic engagement and may never assert conclusion, signature or entry into force.

Answer: A. Explanation: This topic owns the five Central Asian Republics, the Connect Central Asia Policy, the India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue mechanisms, India's Central Asian use of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the connectivity instruments of the International North-South Transport Corridor, Chabahar port and the Ashgabat Agreement, the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation and the New Great Game framing, and its distinctive feature is that its examinable spine is a constraint rather than an opportunity, because two verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2018 and 2024 and one objective demand from 2025 are routed here; the full institutional profile of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation belongs to topic 10, the India-China strategic relationship belongs to topic 03, the West Asian and energy-security limb of Chabahar belongs to topic 06, physical and route geography belongs to the Geography owner, and Soviet-era regional chronology with the nineteenth-century Great Game belongs to the World History owner. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q2. Which card should be filed under What this Eurasian owner holds and how its boundaries are routed in an International Relations answer?

A. India looks to Central Asia as a long-term partner in energy and natural resources, given the region's substantial hydrocarbon and mineral endowment, and this interest is what makes the connectivity question consequential rather than merely administrative; the owners keep the claim at the level of a stated policy interest and do not attach any volume, share, price or contract figure to it, because no such figure is carried by the sources and an invented number would convert a defensible interest claim into a fabricated one. B. This topic owns the five Central Asian Republics, the Connect Central Asia Policy, the India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue mechanisms, India's Central Asian use of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the connectivity instruments of the International North-South Transport Corridor, Chabahar port and the Ashgabat Agreement, the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation and the New Great Game framing, and its distinctive feature is that its examinable spine is a constraint rather than an opportunity, because two verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2018 and 2024 and one objective

demand from 2025 are routed here; the full institutional profile of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation belongs to topic 10, the India-China strategic relationship belongs to topic 03, the West Asian and energy-security limb of Chabahar belongs to topic 06, physical and route geography belongs to the Geography owner, and Soviet-era regional chronology with the nineteenth-century Great Game belongs to the World History owner. C. The proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement is now pursued as the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation, which formally began on 3 June 2017 at St Petersburg and remained under negotiation, with the second round held in Moscow on 22-25 June 2026; the owners fix the status precisely as under negotiation and neither signed nor in force, so an answer may cite the dated rounds as evidence of sustained economic engagement and may never assert conclusion, signature or entry into force. D. India engages Central Asia partly through existing fora described in the sources as the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the Eurasian Economic Community and the Custom Union, and it has proposed a Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement to integrate its markets with the Eurasian space; the examinable discipline is that a proposal is an instrument of intent rather than an operating arrangement, so an answer must name the proposal by its exact title and then trace what actually happened to it rather than implying that market integration has already occurred.

Answer: B. Explanation: This topic owns the five Central Asian Republics, the Connect Central Asia Policy, the India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue mechanisms, India's Central Asian use of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the connectivity instruments of the International North-South Transport Corridor, Chabahar port and the Ashgabat Agreement, the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation and the New Great Game framing, and its distinctive feature is that its examinable spine is a constraint rather than an opportunity, because two verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2018 and 2024 and one objective demand from 2025 are routed here; the full institutional profile of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation belongs to topic 10, the India-China strategic relationship belongs to topic 03, the West Asian and energy-security limb of Chabahar belongs to topic 06, physical and route geography belongs to the Geography owner, and Soviet-era regional chronology with the nineteenth-century Great Game belongs to the World History owner. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q3. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of What this Eurasian owner holds and how its boundaries are routed?

A. India has no direct land access to the Central Asian Republics because Pakistan and Afghanistan lie in between, so the first overland option is politically and security constrained, while Sikri records that any energy pipeline from Eurasia to India not crossing Afghanistan or Pakistan has to be routed via Xinjiang and then across the Karakoram and the Himalayan mountain ranges, which is geographically extreme and would require Chinese cooperation; the owners are categorical that this is a structural rather than a merely technical problem, so both plausible overland routes carry a serious political or geographic difficulty at the same time. B. India looks to Central Asia as a long-term partner in energy and natural resources, given the region's substantial hydrocarbon and mineral endowment, and this interest is what makes the connectivity question consequential rather than merely administrative; the owners keep the claim at the level of a stated policy interest and do not attach any volume, share, price or contract figure to it, because no such figure is carried by the sources and an invented number would convert a defensible interest claim into a fabricated one. C. This topic owns the five Central Asian Republics, the Connect Central Asia Policy, the India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue mechanisms, India's Central Asian use of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the connectivity instruments of the International North-South Transport Corridor, Chabahar port and the Ashgabat Agreement, the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation and the New Great Game framing, and its distinctive feature is that its examinable spine is a constraint rather than an opportunity, because two verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2018 and 2024 and one objective demand from 2025 are routed here; the full institutional profile of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation belongs to topic 10, the India-China strategic relationship belongs to topic 03, the West Asian and energy-security limb of Chabahar belongs to topic 06, physical and route geography belongs to the Geography owner, and Soviet-era regional chronology with the nineteenth-century Great Game belongs to the World History owner. D. The proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement is now pursued as the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation, which formally began on 3 June 2017 at St Petersburg and remained under negotiation, with the second round held in Moscow on 22-25 June 2026; the owners fix the status precisely as under negotiation and neither signed nor in force, so an answer may cite the dated rounds as evidence of sustained economic engagement and may never assert conclusion,

signature or entry into force.

Answer: C. Explanation: This topic owns the five Central Asian Republics, the Connect Central Asia Policy, the India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue mechanisms, India's Central Asian use of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the connectivity instruments of the International North-South Transport Corridor, Chabahar port and the Ashgabat Agreement, the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation and the New Great Game framing, and its distinctive feature is that its examinable spine is a constraint rather than an opportunity, because two verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2018 and 2024 and one objective demand from 2025 are routed here; the full institutional profile of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation belongs to topic 10, the India-China strategic relationship belongs to topic 03, the West Asian and energy-security limb of Chabahar belongs to topic 06, physical and route geography belongs to the Geography owner, and Soviet-era regional chronology with the nineteenth-century Great Game belongs to the World History owner. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q4. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about What this Eurasian owner holds and how its boundaries are routed?

A. As of 3 August 2026 the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation has ten full members, namely Belarus, China, India, Iran, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Pakistan, Russia, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan, two observers, namely Afghanistan and Mongolia, and fifteen dialogue partners, with Pakistan a member since 2017, Iran since 2023 and Belarus since 2024, while a decision of 1 September 2025 envisages consolidating the observer and dialogue-partner categories into a single SCO Partner status whose enabling amendments had not entered into force; the owners warn expressly that Sikri's book-period note placing Pakistan, Iran and Mongolia in observer status is period-specific and must be dated whenever it is quoted. B. India looks to Central Asia as a long-term partner in energy and natural resources, given the region's substantial hydrocarbon and mineral endowment, and this interest is what makes the connectivity question consequential rather than merely administrative; the owners keep the claim at the level of a stated policy interest and do not attach any volume, share, price or contract figure to it, because no such figure is carried by the sources and an invented number would convert a defensible interest claim into a fabricated one. C. India has no direct land access to the Central Asian Republics because Pakistan and Afghanistan lie in between, so the first overland option is politically and security constrained, while Sikri records that any energy pipeline from Eurasia to India not crossing Afghanistan or Pakistan has to be routed via Xinjiang and then across the Karakoram and the Himalayan mountain ranges, which is geographically extreme and would require Chinese cooperation; the owners are categorical that this is a structural rather than a merely technical problem, so both plausible overland routes carry a serious political or geographic difficulty at the same time. D. This topic owns the five Central Asian Republics, the Connect Central Asia Policy, the India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue mechanisms, India's Central Asian use of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the connectivity instruments of the International North-South Transport Corridor, Chabahar port and the Ashgabat Agreement, the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation and the New Great Game framing, and its distinctive feature is that its examinable spine is a constraint rather than an opportunity, because two verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2018 and 2024 and one objective demand from 2025 are routed here; the full institutional profile of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation belongs to topic 10, the India-China strategic relationship belongs to topic 03, the West Asian and energy-security limb of Chabahar belongs to topic 06, physical and route geography belongs to the Geography owner, and Soviet-era regional chronology with the nineteenth-century Great Game belongs to the World History owner.

Answer: D. Explanation: This topic owns the five Central Asian Republics, the Connect Central Asia Policy, the India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue mechanisms, India's Central Asian use of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the connectivity instruments of the International North-South Transport Corridor, Chabahar port and the Ashgabat Agreement, the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation and the New Great Game framing, and its distinctive feature is that its examinable spine is a constraint rather than an opportunity, because two verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2018 and 2024 and one objective demand from 2025 are routed here; the full institutional profile of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation belongs to topic 10, the India-China strategic relationship belongs to topic 03, the West Asian and energy-security limb of Chabahar belongs to topic 06, physical and route geography belongs to the Geography owner, and Soviet-era regional chronology with the nineteenth-century Great Game belongs to the World History owner. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or

Q5. Which statement correctly identifies The five Republics and the Connect Central Asia Policy?

A. The five Central Asian Republics are Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan, and the Connect Central Asia Policy launched in 2012 aims at strengthening and expanding India's relations with those countries through a broad-based approach including political, security, economic and cultural connections; the owners insist on the word broad-based because reducing the policy to energy alone misdescribes its declared scope, and they treat the 2012 launch as the foundational Indian policy approach against which every later mechanism in this topic is measured. B. India looks to Central Asia as a long-term partner in energy and natural resources, given the region's substantial hydrocarbon and mineral endowment, and this interest is what makes the connectivity question consequential rather than merely administrative; the owners keep the claim at the level of a stated policy interest and do not attach any volume, share, price or contract figure to it, because no such figure is carried by the sources and an invented number would convert a defensible interest claim into a fabricated one. C. India engages Central Asia partly through existing fora described in the sources as the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the Eurasian Economic Community and the Custom Union, and it has proposed a Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement to integrate its markets with the Eurasian space; the examinable discipline is that a proposal is an instrument of intent rather than an operating arrangement, so an answer must name the proposal by its exact title and then trace what actually happened to it rather than implying that market integration has already occurred. D. The proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement is now pursued as the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation, which formally began on 3 June 2017 at St Petersburg and remained under negotiation, with the second round held in Moscow on 22-25 June 2026; the owners fix the status precisely as under negotiation and neither signed nor in force, so an answer may cite the dated rounds as evidence of sustained economic engagement and may never assert conclusion, signature or entry into force.

Answer: A. Explanation: The five Central Asian Republics are Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan, and the Connect Central Asia Policy launched in 2012 aims at strengthening and expanding India's relations with those countries through a broad-based approach including political, security, economic and cultural connections; the owners insist on the word broad-based because reducing the policy to energy alone misdescribes its declared scope, and they treat the 2012 launch as the foundational Indian policy approach against which every later mechanism in this topic is measured. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q6. Which card should be filed under The five Republics and the Connect Central Asia Policy in an International Relations answer?

A. The proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement is now pursued as the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation, which formally began on 3 June 2017 at St Petersburg and remained under negotiation, with the second round held in Moscow on 22-25 June 2026; the owners fix the status precisely as under negotiation and neither signed nor in force, so an answer may cite the dated rounds as evidence of sustained economic engagement and may never assert conclusion, signature or entry into force. B. The five Central Asian Republics are Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan, and the Connect Central Asia Policy launched in 2012 aims at strengthening and expanding India's relations with those countries through a broad-based approach including political, security, economic and cultural connections; the owners insist on the word broad-based because reducing the policy to energy alone misdescribes its declared scope, and they treat the 2012 launch as the foundational Indian policy approach against which every later mechanism in this topic is measured. C. India has no direct land access to the Central Asian Republics because Pakistan and Afghanistan lie in between, so the first overland option is politically and security constrained, while Sikri records that any energy pipeline from Eurasia to India not crossing Afghanistan or Pakistan has to be routed via Xinjiang and then across the Karakoram and the Himalayan mountain ranges, which is geographically extreme and would require Chinese cooperation; the owners are categorical that this is a structural rather than a merely technical problem, so both plausible overland routes carry a serious political or geographic difficulty at the same time. D. India looks to Central Asia as a long-term partner in energy and natural resources, given the region's substantial hydrocarbon and mineral endowment, and this interest is what makes the connectivity question consequential rather than merely administrative; the owners keep the claim at the level of a stated policy interest and do not attach any volume, share, price or contract figure to it, because no such figure is carried by the sources and an invented number would convert a defensible interest claim into a fabricated

one.

Answer: B. Explanation: The five Central Asian Republics are Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan, and the Connect Central Asia Policy launched in 2012 aims at strengthening and expanding India's relations with those countries through a broad-based approach including political, security, economic and cultural connections; the owners insist on the word broad-based because reducing the policy to energy alone misdescribes its declared scope, and they treat the 2012 launch as the foundational Indian policy approach against which every later mechanism in this topic is measured. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q7. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of The five Republics and the Connect Central Asia Policy?

A. As of 3 August 2026 the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation has ten full members, namely Belarus, China, India, Iran, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Pakistan, Russia, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan, two observers, namely Afghanistan and Mongolia, and fifteen dialogue partners, with Pakistan a member since 2017, Iran since 2023 and Belarus since 2024, while a decision of 1 September 2025 envisages consolidating the observer and dialogue-partner categories into a single SCO Partner status whose enabling amendments had not entered into force; the owners warn expressly that Sikri's book-period note placing Pakistan, Iran and Mongolia in observer status is period-specific and must be dated whenever it is quoted. B. India has no direct land access to the Central Asian Republics because Pakistan and Afghanistan lie in between, so the first overland option is politically and security constrained, while Sikri records that any energy pipeline from Eurasia to India not crossing Afghanistan or Pakistan has to be routed via Xinjiang and then across the Karakoram and the Himalayan mountain ranges, which is geographically extreme and would require Chinese cooperation; the owners are categorical that this is a structural rather than a merely technical problem, so both plausible overland routes carry a serious political or geographic difficulty at the same time. C. The five Central Asian Republics are Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan, and the Connect Central Asia Policy launched in 2012 aims at strengthening and expanding India's relations with those countries through a broad-based approach including political, security, economic and cultural connections; the owners insist on the word broad-based because reducing the policy to energy alone misdescribes its declared scope, and they treat the 2012 launch as the foundational Indian policy approach against which every later mechanism in this topic is measured. D. India looks to Central Asia as a long-term partner in energy and natural resources, given the region's substantial hydrocarbon and mineral endowment, and this interest is what makes the connectivity question consequential rather than merely administrative; the owners keep the claim at the level of a stated policy interest and do not attach any volume, share, price or contract figure to it, because no such figure is carried by the sources and an invented number would convert a defensible interest claim into a fabricated one.

Answer: C. Explanation: The five Central Asian Republics are Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan, and the Connect Central Asia Policy launched in 2012 aims at strengthening and expanding India's relations with those countries through a broad-based approach including political, security, economic and cultural connections; the owners insist on the word broad-based because reducing the policy to energy alone misdescribes its declared scope, and they treat the 2012 launch as the foundational Indian policy approach against which every later mechanism in this topic is measured. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q8. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about The five Republics and the Connect Central Asia Policy?

A. India has no direct land access to the Central Asian Republics because Pakistan and Afghanistan lie in between, so the first overland option is politically and security constrained, while Sikri records that any energy pipeline from Eurasia to India not crossing Afghanistan or Pakistan has to be routed via Xinjiang and then across the Karakoram and the Himalayan mountain ranges, which is geographically extreme and would require Chinese cooperation; the owners are categorical that this is a structural rather than a merely technical problem, so both plausible overland routes carry a serious political or geographic difficulty at the same time. B. The 2025 Heads of State Council summit of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation met at Tianjin on 31 August and 1 September 2025 and adopted the Tianjin Declaration, Kyrgyzstan holds the 2025-26 chairmanship and the next summit is scheduled for Bishkek, while India's own accession to full membership in 2017 is treated as chronology owned by the World History and Polity owners; the owners permit the summit and declaration to be cited as dated evidence of India's continued multilateral engagement

and permit no claim about the declaration's contents beyond its adoption at that meeting. C. As of 3 August 2026 the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation has ten full members, namely Belarus, China, India, Iran, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Pakistan, Russia, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan, two observers, namely Afghanistan and Mongolia, and fifteen dialogue partners, with Pakistan a member since 2017, Iran since 2023 and Belarus since 2024, while a decision of 1 September 2025 envisages consolidating the observer and dialogue-partner categories into a single SCO Partner status whose enabling amendments had not entered into force; the owners warn expressly that Sikri's book-period note placing Pakistan, Iran and Mongolia in observer status is period-specific and must be dated whenever it is quoted. D. The five Central Asian Republics are Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan, and the Connect Central Asia Policy launched in 2012 aims at strengthening and expanding India's relations with those countries through a broad-based approach including political, security, economic and cultural connections; the owners insist on the word broad-based because reducing the policy to energy alone misdescribes its declared scope, and they treat the 2012 launch as the foundational Indian policy approach against which every later mechanism in this topic is measured.

Answer: D. Explanation: The five Central Asian Republics are Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan, and the Connect Central Asia Policy launched in 2012 aims at strengthening and expanding India's relations with those countries through a broad-based approach including political, security, economic and cultural connections; the owners insist on the word broad-based because reducing the policy to energy alone misdescribes its declared scope, and they treat the 2012 launch as the foundational Indian policy approach against which every later mechanism in this topic is measured. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q9. Which statement correctly identifies Multilateral channel use and the proposed economic-integration instrument?

A. India engages Central Asia partly through existing fora described in the sources as the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the Eurasian Economic Community and the Custom Union, and it has proposed a Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement to integrate its markets with the Eurasian space; the examinable discipline is that a proposal is an instrument of intent rather than an operating arrangement, so an answer must name the proposal by its exact title and then trace what actually happened to it rather than implying that market integration has already occurred. B. India looks to Central Asia as a long-term partner in energy and natural resources, given the region's substantial hydrocarbon and mineral endowment, and this interest is what makes the connectivity question consequential rather than merely administrative; the owners keep the claim at the level of a stated policy interest and do not attach any volume, share, price or contract figure to it, because no such figure is carried by the sources and an invented number would convert a defensible interest claim into a fabricated one. C. The proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement is now pursued as the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation, which formally began on 3 June 2017 at St Petersburg and remained under negotiation, with the second round held in Moscow on 22-25 June 2026; the owners fix the status precisely as under negotiation and neither signed nor in force, so an answer may cite the dated rounds as evidence of sustained economic engagement and may never assert conclusion, signature or entry into force. D. India has no direct land access to the Central Asian Republics because Pakistan and Afghanistan lie in between, so the first overland option is politically and security constrained, while Sikri records that any energy pipeline from Eurasia to India not crossing Afghanistan or Pakistan has to be routed via Xinjiang and then across the Karakoram and the Himalayan mountain ranges, which is geographically extreme and would require Chinese cooperation; the owners are categorical that this is a structural rather than a merely technical problem, so both plausible overland routes carry a serious political or geographic difficulty at the same time.

Answer: A. Explanation: India engages Central Asia partly through existing fora described in the sources as the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the Eurasian Economic Community and the Custom Union, and it has proposed a Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement to integrate its markets with the Eurasian space; the examinable discipline is that a proposal is an instrument of intent rather than an operating arrangement, so an answer must name the proposal by its exact title and then trace what actually happened to it rather than implying that market integration has already occurred. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q10. Which card should be filed under Multilateral channel use and the proposed economic-integration instrument in an International Relations answer?

A. India looks to Central Asia as a long-term partner in energy and natural resources, given the region's substantial hydrocarbon and mineral endowment, and this interest is what makes the connectivity question consequential rather than merely administrative; the owners keep the claim at the level of a stated policy interest and do not attach any volume, share, price or contract figure to it, because no such figure is carried by the sources and an invented number would convert a defensible interest claim into a fabricated one. B. India engages Central Asia partly through existing fora described in the sources as the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the Eurasian Economic Community and the Custom Union, and it has proposed a Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement to integrate its markets with the Eurasian space; the examinable discipline is that a proposal is an instrument of intent rather than an operating arrangement, so an answer must name the proposal by its exact title and then trace what actually happened to it rather than implying that market integration has already occurred. C. As of 3 August 2026 the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation has ten full members, namely Belarus, China, India, Iran, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Pakistan, Russia, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan, two observers, namely Afghanistan and Mongolia, and fifteen dialogue partners, with Pakistan a member since 2017, Iran since 2023 and Belarus since 2024, while a decision of 1 September 2025 envisages consolidating the observer and dialogue-partner categories into a single SCO Partner status whose enabling amendments had not entered into force; the owners warn expressly that Sikri's book-period note placing Pakistan, Iran and Mongolia in observer status is period-specific and must be dated whenever it is quoted. D. India has no direct land access to the Central Asian Republics because Pakistan and Afghanistan lie in between, so the first overland option is politically and security constrained, while Sikri records that any energy pipeline from Eurasia to India not crossing Afghanistan or Pakistan has to be routed via Xinjiang and then across the Karakoram and the Himalayan mountain ranges, which is geographically extreme and would require Chinese cooperation; the owners are categorical that this is a structural rather than a merely technical problem, so both plausible overland routes carry a serious political or geographic difficulty at the same time.

Answer: B. Explanation: India engages Central Asia partly through existing fora described in the sources as the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the Eurasian Economic Community and the Custom Union, and it has proposed a Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement to integrate its markets with the Eurasian space; the examinable discipline is that a proposal is an instrument of intent rather than an operating arrangement, so an answer must name the proposal by its exact title and then trace what actually happened to it rather than implying that market integration has already occurred. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q11. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Multilateral channel use and the proposed economic-integration instrument?

A. The 2025 Heads of State Council summit of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation met at Tianjin on 31 August and 1 September 2025 and adopted the Tianjin Declaration, Kyrgyzstan holds the 2025-26 chairmanship and the next summit is scheduled for Bishkek, while India's own accession to full membership in 2017 is treated as chronology owned by the World History and Polity owners; the owners permit the summit and declaration to be cited as dated evidence of India's continued multilateral engagement and permit no claim about the declaration's contents beyond its adoption at that meeting. B. As of 3 August 2026 the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation has ten full members, namely Belarus, China, India, Iran, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Pakistan, Russia, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan, two observers, namely Afghanistan and Mongolia, and fifteen dialogue partners, with Pakistan a member since 2017, Iran since 2023 and Belarus since 2024, while a decision of 1 September 2025 envisages consolidating the observer and dialogue-partner categories into a single SCO Partner status whose enabling amendments had not entered into force; the owners warn expressly that Sikri's book-period note placing Pakistan, Iran and Mongolia in observer status is period-specific and must be dated whenever it is quoted. C. India engages Central Asia partly through existing fora described in the sources as the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the Eurasian Economic Community and the Custom Union, and it has proposed a Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement to integrate its markets with the Eurasian space; the examinable discipline is that a proposal is an instrument of intent rather than an operating arrangement, so an answer must name the proposal by its exact title and then trace what actually happened to it rather than implying that market integration has already occurred. D. India has no direct land access to the Central Asian Republics because Pakistan and Afghanistan lie in between, so the first overland option is politically and security constrained, while Sikri records that any energy pipeline from Eurasia to India not crossing Afghanistan or

Pakistan has to be routed via Xinjiang and then across the Karakoram and the Himalayan mountain ranges, which is geographically extreme and would require Chinese cooperation; the owners are categorical that this is a structural rather than a merely technical problem, so both plausible overland routes carry a serious political or geographic difficulty at the same time.

Answer: C. Explanation: India engages Central Asia partly through existing fora described in the sources as the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the Eurasian Economic Community and the Custom Union, and it has proposed a Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement to integrate its markets with the Eurasian space; the examinable discipline is that a proposal is an instrument of intent rather than an operating arrangement, so an answer must name the proposal by its exact title and then trace what actually happened to it rather than implying that market integration has already occurred. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q12. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Multilateral channel use and the proposed economic-integration instrument?

A. The first India-Central Asia Summit was held virtually on 27 January 2022, the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue at foreign-minister level met in New Delhi on 6 June 2025 and envisaged preparing the ground for a second summit, and the third meeting of Secretaries of Security Councils and National Security Advisers met at Bishkek on 16 October 2025, while no second leader-level summit had been recorded as held by 3 August 2026; the owners treat that absence as a candid indicator that the dedicated format has not yet institutionalised at leader level, and they require the gap to be stated rather than glossed over when a demand asks about increasing significance. B. The 2025 Heads of State Council summit of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation met at Tianjin on 31 August and 1 September 2025 and adopted the Tianjin Declaration, Kyrgyzstan holds the 2025-26 chairmanship and the next summit is scheduled for Bishkek, while India's own accession to full membership in 2017 is treated as chronology owned by the World History and Polity owners; the owners permit the summit and declaration to be cited as dated evidence of India's continued multilateral engagement and permit no claim about the declaration's contents beyond its adoption at that meeting. C. As of 3 August 2026 the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation has ten full members, namely Belarus, China, India, Iran, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Pakistan, Russia, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan, two observers, namely Afghanistan and Mongolia, and fifteen dialogue partners, with Pakistan a member since 2017, Iran since 2023 and Belarus since 2024, while a decision of 1 September 2025 envisages consolidating the observer and dialogue-partner categories into a single SCO Partner status whose enabling amendments had not entered into force; the owners warn expressly that Sikri's book-period note placing Pakistan, Iran and Mongolia in observer status is period-specific and must be dated whenever it is quoted. D. India engages Central Asia partly through existing fora described in the sources as the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the Eurasian Economic Community and the Custom Union, and it has proposed a Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement to integrate its markets with the Eurasian space; the examinable discipline is that a proposal is an instrument of intent rather than an operating arrangement, so an answer must name the proposal by its exact title and then trace what actually happened to it rather than implying that market integration has already occurred.

Answer: D. Explanation: India engages Central Asia partly through existing fora described in the sources as the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the Eurasian Economic Community and the Custom Union, and it has proposed a Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement to integrate its markets with the Eurasian space; the examinable discipline is that a proposal is an instrument of intent rather than an operating arrangement, so an answer must name the proposal by its exact title and then trace what actually happened to it rather than implying that market integration has already occurred. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q13. Which statement correctly identifies The India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation and its exact status?

A. The proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement is now pursued as the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation, which formally began on 3 June 2017 at St Petersburg and remained under negotiation, with the second round held in Moscow on 22-25 June 2026; the owners fix the status precisely as under negotiation and neither signed nor in force, so an answer may cite the dated rounds as evidence of sustained economic engagement and may never assert conclusion, signature or entry into force. B. As of 3 August 2026 the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation has ten full members, namely Belarus, China, India, Iran, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Pakistan, Russia, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan, two observers, namely Afghanistan and Mongolia, and fifteen dialogue partners, with Pakistan a member since 2017, Iran since 2023 and Belarus since 2024, while a decision of 1 September 2025 envisages consolidating the observer and dialogue-partner categories into a single SCO Partner status whose enabling amendments had not entered into force; the owners warn expressly that Sikri's book-period note placing Pakistan, Iran and Mongolia in observer status is period-specific and must be dated whenever it is quoted. C. India looks to Central Asia as a long-term partner in energy and natural resources, given the region's substantial hydrocarbon and mineral endowment, and this interest is what makes the connectivity question consequential rather than merely administrative; the owners keep the claim at the level of a stated policy interest and do not attach any volume, share, price or contract figure to it, because no such figure is carried by the sources and an invented number would convert a defensible interest claim into a fabricated one. D. India has no direct land access to the Central Asian Republics because Pakistan and Afghanistan lie in between, so the first overland option is politically and security constrained, while Sikri records that any energy pipeline from Eurasia to India not crossing Afghanistan or Pakistan has to be routed via Xinjiang and then across the Karakoram and the Himalayan mountain ranges, which is geographically extreme and would require Chinese cooperation; the owners are categorical that this is a structural rather than a merely technical problem, so both plausible overland routes carry a serious political or geographic difficulty at the same time.

Answer: A. Explanation: The proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement is now pursued as the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation, which formally began on 3 June 2017 at St Petersburg and remained under negotiation, with the second round held in Moscow on 22-25 June 2026; the owners fix the status precisely as under negotiation and neither signed nor in force, so an answer may cite the dated rounds as evidence of sustained economic engagement and may never assert conclusion, signature or entry into force. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q14. Which card should be filed under The India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation and its exact status in an International Relations answer?

A. India has no direct land access to the Central Asian Republics because Pakistan and Afghanistan lie in between, so the first overland option is politically and security constrained, while Sikri records that any energy pipeline from Eurasia to India not crossing Afghanistan or Pakistan has to be routed via Xinjiang and then across the Karakoram and the Himalayan mountain ranges, which is geographically extreme and would require Chinese cooperation; the owners are categorical that this is a structural rather than a merely technical problem, so both plausible overland routes carry a serious political or geographic difficulty at the same time. B. The proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement is now pursued as the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation, which formally began on 3 June 2017 at St Petersburg and remained under negotiation, with the second round held in Moscow on 22-25 June 2026; the owners fix the status precisely as under negotiation and neither signed nor in force, so an answer may cite the dated rounds as evidence of sustained economic engagement and may never assert conclusion, signature or entry into force. C. As of 3 August 2026 the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation has ten full members, namely Belarus, China, India, Iran, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Pakistan, Russia, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan, two observers, namely Afghanistan and Mongolia, and fifteen dialogue partners, with Pakistan a member since 2017, Iran since 2023 and Belarus since 2024, while a decision of 1 September 2025 envisages consolidating the observer and dialogue-partner categories into a single SCO Partner status whose enabling amendments had not entered into force; the owners warn expressly that Sikri's book-period note placing Pakistan, Iran and Mongolia in observer status is period-specific and must be dated whenever it is quoted. D. The 2025 Heads of State Council summit of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation met at Tianjin on 31 August and 1 September 2025 and adopted the Tianjin Declaration, Kyrgyzstan holds the 2025-26 chairmanship and the next summit is scheduled for Bishkek, while India's own

accession to full membership in 2017 is treated as chronology owned by the World History and Polity owners; the owners permit the summit and declaration to be cited as dated evidence of India's continued multilateral engagement and permit no claim about the declaration's contents beyond its adoption at that meeting.

Answer: B. Explanation: The proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement is now pursued as the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation, which formally began on 3 June 2017 at St Petersburg and remained under negotiation, with the second round held in Moscow on 22-25 June 2026; the owners fix the status precisely as under negotiation and neither signed nor in force, so an answer may cite the dated rounds as evidence of sustained economic engagement and may never assert conclusion, signature or entry into force. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q15. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of The India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation and its exact status?

A. The first India-Central Asia Summit was held virtually on 27 January 2022, the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue at foreign-minister level met in New Delhi on 6 June 2025 and envisaged preparing the ground for a second summit, and the third meeting of Secretaries of Security Councils and National Security Advisers met at Bishkek on 16 October 2025, while no second leader-level summit had been recorded as held by 3 August 2026; the owners treat that absence as a candid indicator that the dedicated format has not yet institutionalised at leader level, and they require the gap to be stated rather than glossed over when a demand asks about increasing significance. B. The 2025 Heads of State Council summit of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation met at Tianjin on 31 August and 1 September 2025 and adopted the Tianjin Declaration, Kyrgyzstan holds the 2025-26 chairmanship and the next summit is scheduled for Bishkek, while India's own accession to full membership in 2017 is treated as chronology owned by the World History and Polity owners; the owners permit the summit and declaration to be cited as dated evidence of India's continued multilateral engagement and permit no claim about the declaration's contents beyond its adoption at that meeting. C. The proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement is now pursued as the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation, which formally began on 3 June 2017 at St Petersburg and remained under negotiation, with the second round held in Moscow on 22-25 June 2026; the owners fix the status precisely as under negotiation and neither signed nor in force, so an answer may cite the dated rounds as evidence of sustained economic engagement and may never assert conclusion, signature or entry into force. D. As of 3 August 2026 the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation has ten full members, namely Belarus, China, India, Iran, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Pakistan, Russia, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan, two observers, namely Afghanistan and Mongolia, and fifteen dialogue partners, with Pakistan a member since 2017, Iran since 2023 and Belarus since 2024, while a decision of 1 September 2025 envisages consolidating the observer and dialogue-partner categories into a single SCO Partner status whose enabling amendments had not entered into force; the owners warn expressly that Sikri's book-period note placing Pakistan, Iran and Mongolia in observer status is period-specific and must be dated whenever it is quoted.

Answer: C. Explanation: The proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement is now pursued as the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation, which formally began on 3 June 2017 at St Petersburg and remained under negotiation, with the second round held in Moscow on 22-25 June 2026; the owners fix the status precisely as under negotiation and neither signed nor in force, so an answer may cite the dated rounds as evidence of sustained economic engagement and may never assert conclusion, signature or entry into force. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q16. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about The India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation and its exact status?

A. The first India-Central Asia Summit was held virtually on 27 January 2022, the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue at foreign-minister level met in New Delhi on 6 June 2025 and envisaged preparing the ground for a second summit, and the third meeting of Secretaries of Security Councils and National Security Advisers met at Bishkek on 16 October 2025, while no second leader-level summit had been recorded as held by 3 August 2026; the owners treat that absence as a candid indicator that the dedicated format has not yet institutionalised at leader level, and they require the gap to be stated rather than glossed over when a demand asks about increasing significance. B. India Ports Global Limited and Iran's Ports and Maritime Organisation signed a ten-year long-term contract for Chabahar port on 13 May 2024, with India announcing roughly one hundred and twenty million United States dollars in equipment investment and a two hundred and fifty million United States dollar credit window for mutually identified infrastructure; the owners require these to be cited as announced investment and an announced credit window rather than as delivered equipment or disbursed finance, because an announcement and a delivery are different evidentiary levels and the difference is exactly what a critical demand tests. C. The 2025 Heads of State Council summit of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation met at Tianjin on 31 August and 1 September 2025 and adopted the Tianjin Declaration, Kyrgyzstan holds the 2025-26 chairmanship and the next summit is scheduled for Bishkek, while India's own accession to full membership in 2017 is treated as chronology owned by the World History and Polity owners; the owners permit the summit and declaration to be cited as dated evidence of India's continued multilateral engagement and permit no claim about the declaration's contents beyond its adoption at that meeting. D. The proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement is now pursued as the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation, which formally began on 3 June 2017 at St Petersburg and remained under negotiation, with the second round held in Moscow on 22-25 June 2026; the owners fix the status precisely as under negotiation and neither signed nor in force, so an answer may cite the dated rounds as evidence of sustained economic engagement and may never assert conclusion, signature or entry into force.

Answer: D. Explanation: The proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement is now pursued as the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation, which formally began on 3 June 2017 at St Petersburg and remained under negotiation, with the second round held in Moscow on 22-25 June 2026; the owners fix the status precisely as under negotiation and neither signed nor in force, so an answer may cite the dated rounds as evidence of sustained economic engagement and may never assert conclusion, signature or entry into force. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q17. Which statement correctly identifies Energy and resources as the substantive interest?

A. India looks to Central Asia as a long-term partner in energy and natural resources, given the region's substantial hydrocarbon and mineral endowment, and this interest is what makes the connectivity question consequential rather than merely administrative; the owners keep the claim at the level of a stated policy interest and do not attach any volume, share, price or contract figure to it, because no such figure is carried by the sources and an invented number would convert a defensible interest claim into a fabricated one. B. India has no direct land access to the Central Asian Republics because Pakistan and Afghanistan lie in between, so the first overland option is politically and security constrained, while Sikri records that any energy pipeline from Eurasia to India not crossing Afghanistan or Pakistan has to be routed via Xinjiang and then across the Karakoram and the Himalayan mountain ranges, which is geographically extreme and would require Chinese cooperation; the owners are categorical that this is a structural rather than a merely technical problem, so both plausible overland routes carry a serious political or geographic difficulty at the same time. C. As of 3 August 2026 the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation has ten full members, namely Belarus, China, India, Iran, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Pakistan, Russia, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan, two observers, namely Afghanistan and Mongolia, and fifteen dialogue partners, with Pakistan a member since 2017, Iran since 2023 and Belarus since 2024, while a decision of 1 September 2025 envisages consolidating the observer and dialogue-partner categories into a single SCO Partner status whose enabling amendments had not entered into force; the owners warn expressly that Sikri's book-period note placing Pakistan, Iran and Mongolia in observer status is period-specific and must be dated whenever it is quoted. D. The 2025 Heads of State Council summit of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation met at Tianjin on 31 August and 1 September 2025 and adopted the Tianjin Declaration, Kyrgyzstan holds the 2025-26 chairmanship and the next summit is scheduled for Bishkek, while India's own accession to full membership in 2017 is treated as chronology owned by the World History and Polity owners; the

owners permit the summit and declaration to be cited as dated evidence of India's continued multilateral engagement and permit no claim about the declaration's contents beyond its adoption at that meeting.

Answer: A. Explanation: India looks to Central Asia as a long-term partner in energy and natural resources, given the region's substantial hydrocarbon and mineral endowment, and this interest is what makes the connectivity question consequential rather than merely administrative; the owners keep the claim at the level of a stated policy interest and do not attach any volume, share, price or contract figure to it, because no such figure is carried by the sources and an invented number would convert a defensible interest claim into a fabricated one. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q18. Which card should be filed under Energy and resources as the substantive interest in an International Relations answer?

A. The first India-Central Asia Summit was held virtually on 27 January 2022, the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue at foreign-minister level met in New Delhi on 6 June 2025 and envisaged preparing the ground for a second summit, and the third meeting of Secretaries of Security Councils and National Security Advisers met at Bishkek on 16 October 2025, while no second leader-level summit had been recorded as held by 3 August 2026; the owners treat that absence as a candid indicator that the dedicated format has not yet institutionalised at leader level, and they require the gap to be stated rather than glossed over when a demand asks about increasing significance. B. India looks to Central Asia as a long-term partner in energy and natural resources, given the region's substantial hydrocarbon and mineral endowment, and this interest is what makes the connectivity question consequential rather than merely administrative; the owners keep the claim at the level of a stated policy interest and do not attach any volume, share, price or contract figure to it, because no such figure is carried by the sources and an invented number would convert a defensible interest claim into a fabricated one. C. As of 3 August 2026 the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation has ten full members, namely Belarus, China, India, Iran, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Pakistan, Russia, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan, two observers, namely Afghanistan and Mongolia, and fifteen dialogue partners, with Pakistan a member since 2017, Iran since 2023 and Belarus since 2024, while a decision of 1 September 2025 envisages consolidating the observer and dialogue-partner categories into a single SCO Partner status whose enabling amendments had not entered into force; the owners warn expressly that Sikri's book-period note placing Pakistan, Iran and Mongolia in observer status is period-specific and must be dated whenever it is quoted. D. The 2025 Heads of State Council summit of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation met at Tianjin on 31 August and 1 September 2025 and adopted the Tianjin Declaration, Kyrgyzstan holds the 2025-26 chairmanship and the next summit is scheduled for Bishkek, while India's own accession to full membership in 2017 is treated as chronology owned by the World History and Polity owners; the owners permit the summit and declaration to be cited as dated evidence of India's continued multilateral engagement and permit no claim about the declaration's contents beyond its adoption at that meeting.

Answer: B. Explanation: India looks to Central Asia as a long-term partner in energy and natural resources, given the region's substantial hydrocarbon and mineral endowment, and this interest is what makes the connectivity question consequential rather than merely administrative; the owners keep the claim at the level of a stated policy interest and do not attach any volume, share, price or contract figure to it, because no such figure is carried by the sources and an invented number would convert a defensible interest claim into a fabricated one. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q19. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Energy and resources as the substantive interest?

A. India Ports Global Limited and Iran's Ports and Maritime Organisation signed a ten-year long-term contract for Chabahar port on 13 May 2024, with India announcing roughly one hundred and twenty million United States dollars in equipment investment and a two hundred and fifty million United States dollar credit window for mutually identified infrastructure; the owners require these to be cited as announced investment and an announced credit window rather than as delivered equipment or disbursed finance, because an announcement and a delivery are different evidentiary levels and the difference is exactly what a critical demand tests. B. The first India-Central Asia Summit was held virtually on 27 January 2022, the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue at foreign-minister level met in New Delhi on 6 June 2025 and envisaged preparing the ground for a second summit, and the third meeting of Secretaries of Security Councils and National Security Advisers met at Bishkek on 16 October 2025, while no second leader-level summit had

been recorded as held by 3 August 2026; the owners treat that absence as a candid indicator that the dedicated format has not yet institutionalised at leader level, and they require the gap to be stated rather than glossed over when a demand asks about increasing significance. C. India looks to Central Asia as a long-term partner in energy and natural resources, given the region's substantial hydrocarbon and mineral endowment, and this interest is what makes the connectivity question consequential rather than merely administrative; the owners keep the claim at the level of a stated policy interest and do not attach any volume, share, price or contract figure to it, because no such figure is carried by the sources and an invented number would convert a defensible interest claim into a fabricated one. D. The 2025 Heads of State Council summit of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation met at Tianjin on 31 August and 1 September 2025 and adopted the Tianjin Declaration, Kyrgyzstan holds the 2025-26 chairmanship and the next summit is scheduled for Bishkek, while India's own accession to full membership in 2017 is treated as chronology owned by the World History and Polity owners; the owners permit the summit and declaration to be cited as dated evidence of India's continued multilateral engagement and permit no claim about the declaration's contents beyond its adoption at that meeting.

Answer: C. Explanation: India looks to Central Asia as a long-term partner in energy and natural resources, given the region's substantial hydrocarbon and mineral endowment, and this interest is what makes the connectivity question consequential rather than merely administrative; the owners keep the claim at the level of a stated policy interest and do not attach any volume, share, price or contract figure to it, because no such figure is carried by the sources and an invented number would convert a defensible interest claim into a fabricated one. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q20. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Energy and resources as the substantive interest?

A. The United States State Department revoked the 2018 Chabahar sanctions waiver on 16 September 2025 with effect from 29 September 2025, and a subsequent assurance of non-exposure ran only to 26 April 2026, so any status beyond that date requires fresh verification; the owners state the legal character precisely, because this is a change in another state's domestic sanctions posture that creates exposure risk for entities rather than an international legal obligation binding on India, and its practical effect is to convert the Iran work-around from a geographic question into a financing and sanctions-exposure question. B. India Ports Global Limited and Iran's Ports and Maritime Organisation signed a ten-year long-term contract for Chabahar port on 13 May 2024, with India announcing roughly one hundred and twenty million United States dollars in equipment investment and a two hundred and fifty million United States dollar credit window for mutually identified infrastructure; the owners require these to be cited as announced investment and an announced credit window rather than as delivered equipment or disbursed finance, because an announcement and a delivery are different evidentiary levels and the difference is exactly what a critical demand tests. C. The first India-Central Asia Summit was held virtually on 27 January 2022, the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue at foreign-minister level met in New Delhi on 6 June 2025 and envisaged preparing the ground for a second summit, and the third meeting of Secretaries of Security Councils and National Security Advisers met at Bishkek on 16 October 2025, while no second leader-level summit had been recorded as held by 3 August 2026; the owners treat that absence as a candid indicator that the dedicated format has not yet institutionalised at leader level, and they require the gap to be stated rather than glossed over when a demand asks about increasing significance. D. India looks to Central Asia as a long-term partner in energy and natural resources, given the region's substantial hydrocarbon and mineral endowment, and this interest is what makes the connectivity question consequential rather than merely administrative; the owners keep the claim at the level of a stated policy interest and do not attach any volume, share, price or contract figure to it, because no such figure is carried by the sources and an invented number would convert a defensible interest claim into a fabricated one.

Answer: D. Explanation: India looks to Central Asia as a long-term partner in energy and natural resources, given the region's substantial hydrocarbon and mineral endowment, and this interest is what makes the connectivity question consequential rather than merely administrative; the owners keep the claim at the level of a stated policy interest and do not attach any volume, share, price or contract figure to it, because no such figure is carried by the sources and an invented number would convert a defensible interest claim into a fabricated one. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q21. Which statement correctly identifies The two-route geography problem as a binding structural constraint?

A. India has no direct land access to the Central Asian Republics because Pakistan and Afghanistan lie in between, so the first overland option is politically and security constrained, while Sikri records that any energy pipeline from Eurasia to India not crossing Afghanistan or Pakistan has to be routed via Xinjiang and then across the Karakoram and the Himalayan mountain ranges, which is geographically extreme and would require Chinese cooperation; the owners are categorical that this is a structural rather than a merely technical problem, so both plausible overland routes carry a serious political or geographic difficulty at the same time. B. As of 3 August 2026 the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation has ten full members, namely Belarus, China, India, Iran, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Pakistan, Russia, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan, two observers, namely Afghanistan and Mongolia, and fifteen dialogue partners, with Pakistan a member since 2017, Iran since 2023 and Belarus since 2024, while a decision of 1 September 2025 envisages consolidating the observer and dialogue-partner categories into a single SCO Partner status whose enabling amendments had not entered into force; the owners warn expressly that Sikri's book-period note placing Pakistan, Iran and Mongolia in observer status is period-specific and must be dated whenever it is quoted. C. The first India-Central Asia Summit was held virtually on 27 January 2022, the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue at foreign-minister level met in New Delhi on 6 June 2025 and envisaged preparing the ground for a second summit, and the third meeting of Secretaries of Security Councils and National Security Advisers met at Bishkek on 16 October 2025, while no second leader-level summit had been recorded as held by 3 August 2026; the owners treat that absence as a candid indicator that the dedicated format has not yet institutionalised at leader level, and they require the gap to be stated rather than glossed over when a demand asks about increasing significance. D. The 2025 Heads of State Council summit of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation met at Tianjin on 31 August and 1 September 2025 and adopted the Tianjin Declaration, Kyrgyzstan holds the 2025-26 chairmanship and the next summit is scheduled for Bishkek, while India's own accession to full membership in 2017 is treated as chronology owned by the World History and Polity owners; the owners permit the summit and declaration to be cited as dated evidence of India's continued multilateral engagement and permit no claim about the declaration's contents beyond its adoption at that meeting.

Answer: A. Explanation: India has no direct land access to the Central Asian Republics because Pakistan and Afghanistan lie in between, so the first overland option is politically and security constrained, while Sikri records that any energy pipeline from Eurasia to India not crossing Afghanistan or Pakistan has to be routed via Xinjiang and then across the Karakoram and the Himalayan mountain ranges, which is geographically extreme and would require Chinese cooperation; the owners are categorical that this is a structural rather than a merely technical problem, so both plausible overland routes carry a serious political or geographic difficulty at the same time. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q22. Which card should be filed under The two-route geography problem as a binding structural constraint in an International Relations answer?

A. India Ports Global Limited and Iran's Ports and Maritime Organisation signed a ten-year long-term contract for Chabahar port on 13 May 2024, with India announcing roughly one hundred and twenty million United States dollars in equipment investment and a two hundred and fifty million United States dollar credit window for mutually identified infrastructure; the owners require these to be cited as announced investment and an announced credit window rather than as delivered equipment or disbursed finance, because an announcement and a delivery are different evidentiary levels and the difference is exactly what a critical demand tests. B. India has no direct land access to the Central Asian Republics because Pakistan and Afghanistan lie in between, so the first overland option is politically and security constrained, while Sikri records that any energy pipeline from Eurasia to India not crossing Afghanistan or Pakistan has to be routed via Xinjiang and then across the Karakoram and the Himalayan mountain ranges, which is geographically extreme and would require Chinese cooperation; the owners are categorical that this is a structural rather than a merely technical problem, so both plausible overland routes carry a serious political or geographic difficulty at the same time. C. The 2025 Heads of State Council summit of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation met at Tianjin on 31 August and 1 September 2025 and adopted the Tianjin Declaration, Kyrgyzstan holds the 2025-26 chairmanship and the next summit is scheduled for Bishkek, while India's own accession to full membership in 2017 is treated as chronology owned by the World History and Polity owners; the owners permit the summit and declaration to be cited as dated evidence of India's continued multilateral engagement and permit no claim about the declaration's

contents beyond its adoption at that meeting. D. The first India-Central Asia Summit was held virtually on 27 January 2022, the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue at foreign-minister level met in New Delhi on 6 June 2025 and envisaged preparing the ground for a second summit, and the third meeting of Secretaries of Security Councils and National Security Advisers met at Bishkek on 16 October 2025, while no second leader-level summit had been recorded as held by 3 August 2026; the owners treat that absence as a candid indicator that the dedicated format has not yet institutionalised at leader level, and they require the gap to be stated rather than glossed over when a demand asks about increasing significance.

Answer: B. Explanation: India has no direct land access to the Central Asian Republics because Pakistan and Afghanistan lie in between, so the first overland option is politically and security constrained, while Sikri records that any energy pipeline from Eurasia to India not crossing Afghanistan or Pakistan has to be routed via Xinjiang and then across the Karakoram and the Himalayan mountain ranges, which is geographically extreme and would require Chinese cooperation; the owners are categorical that this is a structural rather than a merely technical problem, so both plausible overland routes carry a serious political or geographic difficulty at the same time. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q23. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of The two-route geography problem as a binding structural constraint?

A. India Ports Global Limited and Iran's Ports and Maritime Organisation signed a ten-year long-term contract for Chabahar port on 13 May 2024, with India announcing roughly one hundred and twenty million United States dollars in equipment investment and a two hundred and fifty million United States dollar credit window for mutually identified infrastructure; the owners require these to be cited as announced investment and an announced credit window rather than as delivered equipment or disbursed finance, because an announcement and a delivery are different evidentiary levels and the difference is exactly what a critical demand tests. B. The first India-Central Asia Summit was held virtually on 27 January 2022, the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue at foreign-minister level met in New Delhi on 6 June 2025 and envisaged preparing the ground for a second summit, and the third meeting of Secretaries of Security Councils and National Security Advisers met at Bishkek on 16 October 2025, while no second leader-level summit had been recorded as held by 3 August 2026; the owners treat that absence as a candid indicator that the dedicated format has not yet institutionalised at leader level, and they require the gap to be stated rather than glossed over when a demand asks about increasing significance. C. India has no direct land access to the Central Asian Republics because Pakistan and Afghanistan lie in between, so the first overland option is politically and security constrained, while Sikri records that any energy pipeline from Eurasia to India not crossing Afghanistan or Pakistan has to be routed via Xinjiang and then across the Karakoram and the Himalayan mountain ranges, which is geographically extreme and would require Chinese cooperation; the owners are categorical that this is a structural rather than a merely technical problem, so both plausible overland routes carry a serious political or geographic difficulty at the same time. D. The United States State Department revoked the 2018 Chabahar sanctions waiver on 16 September 2025 with effect from 29 September 2025, and a subsequent assurance of non-exposure ran only to 26 April 2026, so any status beyond that date requires fresh verification; the owners state the legal character precisely, because this is a change in another state's domestic sanctions posture that creates exposure risk for entities rather than an international legal obligation binding on India, and its practical effect is to convert the Iran work-around from a geographic question into a financing and sanctions-exposure question.

Answer: C. Explanation: India has no direct land access to the Central Asian Republics because Pakistan and Afghanistan lie in between, so the first overland option is politically and security constrained, while Sikri records that any energy pipeline from Eurasia to India not crossing Afghanistan or Pakistan has to be routed via Xinjiang and then across the Karakoram and the Himalayan mountain ranges, which is geographically extreme and would require Chinese cooperation; the owners are categorical that this is a structural rather than a merely technical problem, so both plausible overland routes carry a serious political or geographic difficulty at the same time. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q24. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about The two-route geography problem as a binding structural constraint?

A. India Ports Global Limited and Iran's Ports and Maritime Organisation signed a ten-year long-term contract for Chabahar port on 13 May 2024, with India announcing roughly one hundred and twenty million United States dollars in equipment investment and a two hundred and fifty million United States dollar credit window for mutually identified infrastructure; the owners require these to be cited as announced investment and an announced credit window rather than as delivered equipment or disbursed finance, because an announcement and a delivery are different evidentiary levels and the difference is exactly what a critical demand tests. B. The United States State Department revoked the 2018 Chabahar sanctions waiver on 16 September 2025 with effect from 29 September 2025, and a subsequent assurance of non-exposure ran only to 26 April 2026, so any status beyond that date requires fresh verification; the owners state the legal character precisely, because this is a change in another state's domestic sanctions posture that creates exposure risk for entities rather than an international legal obligation binding on India, and its practical effect is to convert the Iran work-around from a geographic question into a financing and sanctions-exposure question. C. The International North-South Transport Corridor is a connectivity framework intended to open a maritime-linked route to Central Asia and Eurasia bypassing Pakistan, and the owners require it to be treated as an announced and developing corridor with operating segments rather than a completed, full-capacity corridor; the same discipline extends to Chabahar, because connectivity-project timelines routinely lag announcements, so any specific capacity, throughput or completion claim requires independent dated verification instead of being assumed to match the original announcement. D. India has no direct land access to the Central Asian Republics because Pakistan and Afghanistan lie in between, so the first overland option is politically and security constrained, while Sikri records that any energy pipeline from Eurasia to India not crossing Afghanistan or Pakistan has to be routed via Xinjiang and then across the Karakoram and the Himalayan mountain ranges, which is geographically extreme and would require Chinese cooperation; the owners are categorical that this is a structural rather than a merely technical problem, so both plausible overland routes carry a serious political or geographic difficulty at the same time.

Answer: D. Explanation: India has no direct land access to the Central Asian Republics because Pakistan and Afghanistan lie in between, so the first overland option is politically and security constrained, while Sikri records that any energy pipeline from Eurasia to India not crossing Afghanistan or Pakistan has to be routed via Xinjiang and then across the Karakoram and the Himalayan mountain ranges, which is geographically extreme and would require Chinese cooperation; the owners are categorical that this is a structural rather than a merely technical problem, so both plausible overland routes carry a serious political or geographic difficulty at the same time. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q25. Which statement correctly identifies Shanghai Cooperation Organisation membership tiers as they now stand?

A. As of 3 August 2026 the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation has ten full members, namely Belarus, China, India, Iran, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Pakistan, Russia, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan, two observers, namely Afghanistan and Mongolia, and fifteen dialogue partners, with Pakistan a member since 2017, Iran since 2023 and Belarus since 2024, while a decision of 1 September 2025 envisages consolidating the observer and dialogue-partner categories into a single SCO Partner status whose enabling amendments had not entered into force; the owners warn expressly that Sikri's book-period note placing Pakistan, Iran and Mongolia in observer status is period-specific and must be dated whenever it is quoted. B. The first India-Central Asia Summit was held virtually on 27 January 2022, the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue at foreign-minister level met in New Delhi on 6 June 2025 and envisaged preparing the ground for a second summit, and the third meeting of Secretaries of Security Councils and National Security Advisers met at Bishkek on 16 October 2025, while no second leader-level summit had been recorded as held by 3 August 2026; the owners treat that absence as a candid indicator that the dedicated format has not yet institutionalised at leader level, and they require the gap to be stated rather than glossed over when a demand asks about increasing significance. C. India Ports Global Limited and Iran's Ports and Maritime Organisation signed a ten-year long-term contract for Chabahar port on 13 May 2024, with India announcing roughly one hundred and twenty million United States dollars in equipment investment and a two hundred and fifty million United States dollar credit window for mutually identified infrastructure; the owners require these to be cited as announced investment and an announced credit window rather than as delivered equipment or disbursed finance, because an announcement and a delivery are different evidentiary levels and the difference is exactly what a critical demand tests. D. The 2025 Heads of State

Council summit of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation met at Tianjin on 31 August and 1 September 2025 and adopted the Tianjin Declaration, Kyrgyzstan holds the 2025-26 chairmanship and the next summit is scheduled for Bishkek, while India's own accession to full membership in 2017 is treated as chronology owned by the World History and Polity owners; the owners permit the summit and declaration to be cited as dated evidence of India's continued multilateral engagement and permit no claim about the declaration's contents beyond its adoption at that meeting.

Answer: A. Explanation: As of 3 August 2026 the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation has ten full members, namely Belarus, China, India, Iran, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Pakistan, Russia, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan, two observers, namely Afghanistan and Mongolia, and fifteen dialogue partners, with Pakistan a member since 2017, Iran since 2023 and Belarus since 2024, while a decision of 1 September 2025 envisages consolidating the observer and dialogue-partner categories into a single SCO Partner status whose enabling amendments had not entered into force; the owners warn expressly that Sikri's book-period note placing Pakistan, Iran and Mongolia in observer status is period-specific and must be dated whenever it is quoted. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q26. Which card should be filed under Shanghai Cooperation Organisation membership tiers as they now stand in an International Relations answer?

A. The first India-Central Asia Summit was held virtually on 27 January 2022, the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue at foreign-minister level met in New Delhi on 6 June 2025 and envisaged preparing the ground for a second summit, and the third meeting of Secretaries of Security Councils and National Security Advisers met at Bishkek on 16 October 2025, while no second leader-level summit had been recorded as held by 3 August 2026; the owners treat that absence as a candid indicator that the dedicated format has not yet institutionalised at leader level, and they require the gap to be stated rather than glossed over when a demand asks about increasing significance. B. As of 3 August 2026 the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation has ten full members, namely Belarus, China, India, Iran, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Pakistan, Russia, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan, two observers, namely Afghanistan and Mongolia, and fifteen dialogue partners, with Pakistan a member since 2017, Iran since 2023 and Belarus since 2024, while a decision of 1 September 2025 envisages consolidating the observer and dialogue-partner categories into a single SCO Partner status whose enabling amendments had not entered into force; the owners warn expressly that Sikri's book-period note placing Pakistan, Iran and Mongolia in observer status is period-specific and must be dated whenever it is quoted. C. India Ports Global Limited and Iran's Ports and Maritime Organisation signed a ten-year long-term contract for Chabahar port on 13 May 2024, with India announcing roughly one hundred and twenty million United States dollars in equipment investment and a two hundred and fifty million United States dollar credit window for mutually identified infrastructure; the owners require these to be cited as announced investment and an announced credit window rather than as delivered equipment or disbursed finance, because an announcement and a delivery are different evidentiary levels and the difference is exactly what a critical demand tests. D. The United States State Department revoked the 2018 Chabahar sanctions waiver on 16 September 2025 with effect from 29 September 2025, and a subsequent assurance of non-exposure ran only to 26 April 2026, so any status beyond that date requires fresh verification; the owners state the legal character precisely, because this is a change in another state's domestic sanctions posture that creates exposure risk for entities rather than an international legal obligation binding on India, and its practical effect is to convert the Iran work-around from a geographic question into a financing and sanctions-exposure question.

Answer: B. Explanation: As of 3 August 2026 the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation has ten full members, namely Belarus, China, India, Iran, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Pakistan, Russia, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan, two observers, namely Afghanistan and Mongolia, and fifteen dialogue partners, with Pakistan a member since 2017, Iran since 2023 and Belarus since 2024, while a decision of 1 September 2025 envisages consolidating the observer and dialogue-partner categories into a single SCO Partner status whose enabling amendments had not entered into force; the owners warn expressly that Sikri's book-period note placing Pakistan, Iran and Mongolia in observer status is period-specific and must be dated whenever it is quoted. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q27. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Shanghai Cooperation Organisation membership tiers as they now stand?

A. The United States State Department revoked the 2018 Chabahar sanctions waiver on 16 September 2025 with effect from 29 September 2025, and a subsequent assurance of non-exposure ran only to 26 April 2026, so any status beyond that date requires fresh verification; the owners state the legal character precisely, because this is a change in another state's domestic sanctions posture that creates exposure risk for entities rather than an international legal obligation binding on India, and its practical effect is to convert the Iran work-around from a geographic question into a financing and sanctions-exposure question. B. The International North-South Transport Corridor is a connectivity framework intended to open a maritime-linked route to Central Asia and Eurasia bypassing Pakistan, and the owners require it to be treated as an announced and developing corridor with operating segments rather than a completed, full-capacity corridor; the same discipline extends to Chabahar, because connectivity-project timelines routinely lag announcements, so any specific capacity, throughput or completion claim requires independent dated verification instead of being assumed to match the original announcement. C. As of 3 August 2026 the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation has ten full members, namely Belarus, China, India, Iran, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Pakistan, Russia, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan, two observers, namely Afghanistan and Mongolia, and fifteen dialogue partners, with Pakistan a member since 2017, Iran since 2023 and Belarus since 2024, while a decision of 1 September 2025 envisages consolidating the observer and dialogue-partner categories into a single SCO Partner status whose enabling amendments had not entered into force; the owners warn expressly that Sikri's book-period note placing Pakistan, Iran and Mongolia in observer status is period-specific and must be dated whenever it is quoted. D. India Ports Global Limited and Iran's Ports and Maritime Organisation signed a ten-year long-term contract for Chabahar port on 13 May 2024, with India announcing roughly one hundred and twenty million United States dollars in equipment investment and a two hundred and fifty million United States dollar credit window for mutually identified infrastructure; the owners require these to be cited as announced investment and an announced credit window rather than as delivered equipment or disbursed finance, because an announcement and a delivery are different evidentiary levels and the difference is exactly what a critical demand tests.

Answer: C. Explanation: As of 3 August 2026 the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation has ten full members, namely Belarus, China, India, Iran, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Pakistan, Russia, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan, two observers, namely Afghanistan and Mongolia, and fifteen dialogue partners, with Pakistan a member since 2017, Iran since 2023 and Belarus since 2024, while a decision of 1 September 2025 envisages consolidating the observer and dialogue-partner categories into a single SCO Partner status whose enabling amendments had not entered into force; the owners warn expressly that Sikri's book-period note placing Pakistan, Iran and Mongolia in observer status is period-specific and must be dated whenever it is quoted. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q28. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Shanghai Cooperation Organisation membership tiers as they now stand?

A. The International North-South Transport Corridor is a connectivity framework intended to open a maritime-linked route to Central Asia and Eurasia bypassing Pakistan, and the owners require it to be treated as an announced and developing corridor with operating segments rather than a completed, full-capacity corridor; the same discipline extends to Chabahar, because connectivity-project timelines routinely lag announcements, so any specific capacity, throughput or completion claim requires independent dated verification instead of being assumed to match the original announcement. B. The Ashgabat Agreement was signed at Ashgabat on 25 April 2011 to establish an international multimodal transport and transit corridor between Central Asia and the Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman, and India joined with effect from 3 February 2018, which adds a rules-and-transit framework to India's Chabahar and corridor strategy and reduces dependence on direct territorial access through Pakistan; the owners attach the limitation directly, because it is a facilitation framework rather than an infrastructure-finance mechanism, so its value depends on connected ports, rail and road segments, customs coordination and Iran-related sanctions exposure. C. The United States State Department revoked the 2018 Chabahar sanctions waiver on 16 September 2025 with effect from 29 September 2025, and a subsequent assurance of non-exposure ran only to 26 April 2026, so any status beyond that date requires fresh verification; the owners state the legal character precisely, because this is a change in another state's domestic sanctions posture that creates exposure risk for entities rather than an international legal obligation binding on India, and its practical effect is to convert the Iran work-around from a geographic question into a financing and sanctions-exposure question. D. As of 3 August 2026 the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation has ten full

members, namely Belarus, China, India, Iran, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Pakistan, Russia, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan, two observers, namely Afghanistan and Mongolia, and fifteen dialogue partners, with Pakistan a member since 2017, Iran since 2023 and Belarus since 2024, while a decision of 1 September 2025 envisages consolidating the observer and dialogue-partner categories into a single SCO Partner status whose enabling amendments had not entered into force; the owners warn expressly that Sikri's book-period note placing Pakistan, Iran and Mongolia in observer status is period-specific and must be dated whenever it is quoted.

Answer: D. Explanation: As of 3 August 2026 the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation has ten full members, namely Belarus, China, India, Iran, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Pakistan, Russia, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan, two observers, namely Afghanistan and Mongolia, and fifteen dialogue partners, with Pakistan a member since 2017, Iran since 2023 and Belarus since 2024, while a decision of 1 September 2025 envisages consolidating the observer and dialogue-partner categories into a single SCO Partner status whose enabling amendments had not entered into force; the owners warn expressly that Sikri's book-period note placing Pakistan, Iran and Mongolia in observer status is period-specific and must be dated whenever it is quoted. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q29. Which statement correctly identifies The Tianjin summit and the current chairmanship?

A. The 2025 Heads of State Council summit of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation met at Tianjin on 31 August and 1 September 2025 and adopted the Tianjin Declaration, Kyrgyzstan holds the 2025-26 chairmanship and the next summit is scheduled for Bishkek, while India's own accession to full membership in 2017 is treated as chronology owned by the World History and Polity owners; the owners permit the summit and declaration to be cited as dated evidence of India's continued multilateral engagement and permit no claim about the declaration's contents beyond its adoption at that meeting. B. The first India-Central Asia Summit was held virtually on 27 January 2022, the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue at foreign-minister level met in New Delhi on 6 June 2025 and envisaged preparing the ground for a second summit, and the third meeting of Secretaries of Security Councils and National Security Advisers met at Bishkek on 16 October 2025, while no second leader-level summit had been recorded as held by 3 August 2026; the owners treat that absence as a candid indicator that the dedicated format has not yet institutionalised at leader level, and they require the gap to be stated rather than glossed over when a demand asks about increasing significance. C. The United States State Department revoked the 2018 Chabahar sanctions waiver on 16 September 2025 with effect from 29 September 2025, and a subsequent assurance of non-exposure ran only to 26 April 2026, so any status beyond that date requires fresh verification; the owners state the legal character precisely, because this is a change in another state's domestic sanctions posture that creates exposure risk for entities rather than an international legal obligation binding on India, and its practical effect is to convert the Iran work-around from a geographic question into a financing and sanctions-exposure question. D. India Ports Global Limited and Iran's Ports and Maritime Organisation signed a ten-year long-term contract for Chabahar port on 13 May 2024, with India announcing roughly one hundred and twenty million United States dollars in equipment investment and a two hundred and fifty million United States dollar credit window for mutually identified infrastructure; the owners require these to be cited as announced investment and an announced credit window rather than as delivered equipment or disbursed finance, because an announcement and a delivery are different evidentiary levels and the difference is exactly what a critical demand tests.

Answer: A. Explanation: The 2025 Heads of State Council summit of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation met at Tianjin on 31 August and 1 September 2025 and adopted the Tianjin Declaration, Kyrgyzstan holds the 2025-26 chairmanship and the next summit is scheduled for Bishkek, while India's own accession to full membership in 2017 is treated as chronology owned by the World History and Polity owners; the owners permit the summit and declaration to be cited as dated evidence of India's continued multilateral engagement and permit no claim about the declaration's contents beyond its adoption at that meeting. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q30. Which card should be filed under The Tianjin summit and the current chairmanship in an International Relations answer?

A. India Ports Global Limited and Iran's Ports and Maritime Organisation signed a ten-year long-term contract for Chabahar port on 13 May 2024, with India announcing roughly one hundred and twenty million United States dollars in equipment investment and a two hundred and fifty million United States dollar credit window for mutually identified infrastructure; the owners require these to be cited as announced investment and an announced credit window rather than as delivered equipment or disbursed finance, because an announcement and a delivery are different evidentiary levels and the difference is exactly what a critical demand tests. B. The 2025 Heads of State Council summit of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation met at Tianjin on 31 August and 1 September 2025 and adopted the Tianjin Declaration, Kyrgyzstan holds the 2025-26 chairmanship and the next summit is scheduled for Bishkek, while India's own accession to full membership in 2017 is treated as chronology owned by the World History and Polity owners; the owners permit the summit and declaration to be cited as dated evidence of India's continued multilateral engagement and permit no claim about the declaration's contents beyond its adoption at that meeting. C. The United States State Department revoked the 2018 Chabahar sanctions waiver on 16 September 2025 with effect from 29 September 2025, and a subsequent assurance of non-exposure ran only to 26 April 2026, so any status beyond that date requires fresh verification; the owners state the legal character precisely, because this is a change in another state's domestic sanctions posture that creates exposure risk for entities rather than an international legal obligation binding on India, and its practical effect is to convert the Iran work-around from a geographic question into a financing and sanctions-exposure question. D. The International North-South Transport Corridor is a connectivity framework intended to open a maritime-linked route to Central Asia and Eurasia bypassing Pakistan, and the owners require it to be treated as an announced and developing corridor with operating segments rather than a completed, full-capacity corridor; the same discipline extends to Chabahar, because connectivity-project timelines routinely lag announcements, so any specific capacity, throughput or completion claim requires independent dated verification instead of being assumed to match the original announcement.

Answer: B. Explanation: The 2025 Heads of State Council summit of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation met at Tianjin on 31 August and 1 September 2025 and adopted the Tianjin Declaration, Kyrgyzstan holds the 2025-26 chairmanship and the next summit is scheduled for Bishkek, while India's own accession to full membership in 2017 is treated as chronology owned by the World History and Polity owners; the owners permit the summit and declaration to be cited as dated evidence of India's continued multilateral engagement and permit no claim about the declaration's contents beyond its adoption at that meeting. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q31. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of The Tianjin summit and the current chairmanship?

A. The United States State Department revoked the 2018 Chabahar sanctions waiver on 16 September 2025 with effect from 29 September 2025, and a subsequent assurance of non-exposure ran only to 26 April 2026, so any status beyond that date requires fresh verification; the owners state the legal character precisely, because this is a change in another state's domestic sanctions posture that creates exposure risk for entities rather than an international legal obligation binding on India, and its practical effect is to convert the Iran work-around from a geographic question into a financing and sanctions-exposure question. B. The Ashgabat Agreement was signed at Ashgabat on 25 April 2011 to establish an international multimodal transport and transit corridor between Central Asia and the Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman, and India joined with effect from 3 February 2018, which adds a rules-and-transit framework to India's Chabahar and corridor strategy and reduces dependence on direct territorial access through Pakistan; the owners attach the limitation directly, because it is a facilitation framework rather than an infrastructure-finance mechanism, so its value depends on connected ports, rail and road segments, customs coordination and Iran-related sanctions exposure. C. The 2025 Heads of State Council summit of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation met at Tianjin on 31 August and 1 September 2025 and adopted the Tianjin Declaration, Kyrgyzstan holds the 2025-26 chairmanship and the next summit is scheduled for Bishkek, while India's own accession to full membership in 2017 is treated as chronology owned by the World History and Polity owners; the owners permit the summit and declaration to be cited as dated evidence of India's continued multilateral engagement and permit no claim about the declaration's contents beyond its adoption at that meeting. D. The International North-South Transport Corridor is a connectivity framework intended to open a maritime-linked route to Central Asia and Eurasia bypassing Pakistan, and the owners require it to be treated as an announced and developing corridor with operating segments rather than a completed, full-capacity

corridor; the same discipline extends to Chabahar, because connectivity-project timelines routinely lag announcements, so any specific capacity, throughput or completion claim requires independent dated verification instead of being assumed to match the original announcement.

Answer: C. Explanation: The 2025 Heads of State Council summit of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation met at Tianjin on 31 August and 1 September 2025 and adopted the Tianjin Declaration, Kyrgyzstan holds the 2025-26 chairmanship and the next summit is scheduled for Bishkek, while India's own accession to full membership in 2017 is treated as chronology owned by the World History and Polity owners; the owners permit the summit and declaration to be cited as dated evidence of India's continued multilateral engagement and permit no claim about the declaration's contents beyond its adoption at that meeting. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q32. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about The Tianjin summit and the current chairmanship?

A. The Ministry of External Affairs India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief is current as on April 2026 and is the authoritative dated record for that relationship, and the owners instruct that this brief be cited for any specific current claim about it rather than a general assertion of warm ties; the wider methodological point is that a region-level policy claim and a country-level status claim require different evidence, so a candidate should name the dated brief when the demand turns on the present state of a particular bilateral relationship. B. The International North-South Transport Corridor is a connectivity framework intended to open a maritime-linked route to Central Asia and Eurasia bypassing Pakistan, and the owners require it to be treated as an announced and developing corridor with operating segments rather than a completed, full-capacity corridor; the same discipline extends to Chabahar, because connectivity-project timelines routinely lag announcements, so any specific capacity, throughput or completion claim requires independent dated verification instead of being assumed to match the original announcement. C. The Ashgabat Agreement was signed at Ashgabat on 25 April 2011 to establish an international multimodal transport and transit corridor between Central Asia and the Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman, and India joined with effect from 3 February 2018, which adds a rules-and-transit framework to India's Chabahar and corridor strategy and reduces dependence on direct territorial access through Pakistan; the owners attach the limitation directly, because it is a facilitation framework rather than an infrastructure-finance mechanism, so its value depends on connected ports, rail and road segments, customs coordination and Iran-related sanctions exposure. D. The 2025 Heads of State Council summit of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation met at Tianjin on 31 August and 1 September 2025 and adopted the Tianjin Declaration, Kyrgyzstan holds the 2025-26 chairmanship and the next summit is scheduled for Bishkek, while India's own accession to full membership in 2017 is treated as chronology owned by the World History and Polity owners; the owners permit the summit and declaration to be cited as dated evidence of India's continued multilateral engagement and permit no claim about the declaration's contents beyond its adoption at that meeting.

Answer: D. Explanation: The 2025 Heads of State Council summit of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation met at Tianjin on 31 August and 1 September 2025 and adopted the Tianjin Declaration, Kyrgyzstan holds the 2025-26 chairmanship and the next summit is scheduled for Bishkek, while India's own accession to full membership in 2017 is treated as chronology owned by the World History and Polity owners; the owners permit the summit and declaration to be cited as dated evidence of India's continued multilateral engagement and permit no claim about the declaration's contents beyond its adoption at that meeting. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q33. Which statement correctly identifies The dedicated India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue format?

A. The first India-Central Asia Summit was held virtually on 27 January 2022, the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue at foreign-minister level met in New Delhi on 6 June 2025 and envisaged preparing the ground for a second summit, and the third meeting of Secretaries of Security Councils and National Security Advisers met at Bishkek on 16 October 2025, while no second leader-level summit had been recorded as held by 3 August 2026; the owners treat that absence as a candid indicator that the dedicated format has not yet institutionalised at leader level, and they require the gap to be stated rather than glossed over when a demand asks about increasing significance. B. The International North-South Transport Corridor is a connectivity framework intended to open a maritime-linked route to Central Asia and Eurasia bypassing Pakistan, and the owners require it to be treated as an announced and developing corridor with operating segments rather than a completed, full-capacity corridor; the same discipline extends to Chabahar,

because connectivity-project timelines routinely lag announcements, so any specific capacity, throughput or completion claim requires independent dated verification instead of being assumed to match the original announcement. C. The United States State Department revoked the 2018 Chabahar sanctions waiver on 16 September 2025 with effect from 29 September 2025, and a subsequent assurance of non-exposure ran only to 26 April 2026, so any status beyond that date requires fresh verification; the owners state the legal character precisely, because this is a change in another state's domestic sanctions posture that creates exposure risk for entities rather than an international legal obligation binding on India, and its practical effect is to convert the Iran work-around from a geographic question into a financing and sanctions-exposure question. D. India Ports Global Limited and Iran's Ports and Maritime Organisation signed a ten-year long-term contract for Chabahar port on 13 May 2024, with India announcing roughly one hundred and twenty million United States dollars in equipment investment and a two hundred and fifty million United States dollar credit window for mutually identified infrastructure; the owners require these to be cited as announced investment and an announced credit window rather than as delivered equipment or disbursed finance, because an announcement and a delivery are different evidentiary levels and the difference is exactly what a critical demand tests.

Answer: A. Explanation: The first India-Central Asia Summit was held virtually on 27 January 2022, the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue at foreign-minister level met in New Delhi on 6 June 2025 and envisaged preparing the ground for a second summit, and the third meeting of Secretaries of Security Councils and National Security Advisers met at Bishkek on 16 October 2025, while no second leader-level summit had been recorded as held by 3 August 2026; the owners treat that absence as a candid indicator that the dedicated format has not yet institutionalised at leader level, and they require the gap to be stated rather than glossed over when a demand asks about increasing significance. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q34. Which card should be filed under The dedicated India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue format in an International Relations answer?

A. The International North-South Transport Corridor is a connectivity framework intended to open a maritime-linked route to Central Asia and Eurasia bypassing Pakistan, and the owners require it to be treated as an announced and developing corridor with operating segments rather than a completed, full-capacity corridor; the same discipline extends to Chabahar, because connectivity-project timelines routinely lag announcements, so any specific capacity, throughput or completion claim requires independent dated verification instead of being assumed to match the original announcement. B. The first India-Central Asia Summit was held virtually on 27 January 2022, the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue at foreign-minister level met in New Delhi on 6 June 2025 and envisaged preparing the ground for a second summit, and the third meeting of Secretaries of Security Councils and National Security Advisers met at Bishkek on 16 October 2025, while no second leader-level summit had been recorded as held by 3 August 2026; the owners treat that absence as a candid indicator that the dedicated format has not yet institutionalised at leader level, and they require the gap to be stated rather than glossed over when a demand asks about increasing significance. C. The Ashgabat Agreement was signed at Ashgabat on 25 April 2011 to establish an international multimodal transport and transit corridor between Central Asia and the Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman, and India joined with effect from 3 February 2018, which adds a rules-and-transit framework to India's Chabahar and corridor strategy and reduces dependence on direct territorial access through Pakistan; the owners attach the limitation directly, because it is a facilitation framework rather than an infrastructure-finance mechanism, so its value depends on connected ports, rail and road segments, customs coordination and Iran-related sanctions exposure. D. The United States State Department revoked the 2018 Chabahar sanctions waiver on 16 September 2025 with effect from 29 September 2025, and a subsequent assurance of non-exposure ran only to 26 April 2026, so any status beyond that date requires fresh verification; the owners state the legal character precisely, because this is a change in another state's domestic sanctions posture that creates exposure risk for entities rather than an international legal obligation binding on India, and its practical effect is to convert the Iran work-around from a geographic question into a financing and sanctions-exposure question.

Answer: B. Explanation: The first India-Central Asia Summit was held virtually on 27 January 2022, the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue at foreign-minister level met in New Delhi on 6 June 2025 and envisaged preparing the ground for a second summit, and the third meeting of Secretaries of Security Councils and National Security Advisers met at Bishkek on 16 October 2025, while no second leader-level summit had been recorded as held by 3 August 2026; the owners treat that absence as a candid indicator that the dedicated

format has not yet institutionalised at leader level, and they require the gap to be stated rather than glossed over when a demand asks about increasing significance. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q35. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of The dedicated India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue format?

A. The Ministry of External Affairs India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief is current as on April 2026 and is the authoritative dated record for that relationship, and the owners instruct that this brief be cited for any specific current claim about it rather than a general assertion of warm ties; the wider methodological point is that a region-level policy claim and a country-level status claim require different evidence, so a candidate should name the dated brief when the demand turns on the present state of a particular bilateral relationship. B. The International North-South Transport Corridor is a connectivity framework intended to open a maritime-linked route to Central Asia and Eurasia bypassing Pakistan, and the owners require it to be treated as an announced and developing corridor with operating segments rather than a completed, full-capacity corridor; the same discipline extends to Chabahar, because connectivity-project timelines routinely lag announcements, so any specific capacity, throughput or completion claim requires independent dated verification instead of being assumed to match the original announcement. C. The first India-Central Asia Summit was held virtually on 27 January 2022, the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue at foreign-minister level met in New Delhi on 6 June 2025 and envisaged preparing the ground for a second summit, and the third meeting of Secretaries of Security Councils and National Security Advisers met at Bishkek on 16 October 2025, while no second leader-level summit had been recorded as held by 3 August 2026; the owners treat that absence as a candid indicator that the dedicated format has not yet institutionalised at leader level, and they require the gap to be stated rather than glossed over when a demand asks about increasing significance. D. The Ashgabat Agreement was signed at Ashgabat on 25 April 2011 to establish an international multimodal transport and transit corridor between Central Asia and the Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman, and India joined with effect from 3 February 2018, which adds a rules-and-transit framework to India's Chabahar and corridor strategy and reduces dependence on direct territorial access through Pakistan; the owners attach the limitation directly, because it is a facilitation framework rather than an infrastructure-finance mechanism, so its value depends on connected ports, rail and road segments, customs coordination and Iran-related sanctions exposure.

Answer: C. Explanation: The first India-Central Asia Summit was held virtually on 27 January 2022, the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue at foreign-minister level met in New Delhi on 6 June 2025 and envisaged preparing the ground for a second summit, and the third meeting of Secretaries of Security Councils and National Security Advisers met at Bishkek on 16 October 2025, while no second leader-level summit had been recorded as held by 3 August 2026; the owners treat that absence as a candid indicator that the dedicated format has not yet institutionalised at leader level, and they require the gap to be stated rather than glossed over when a demand asks about increasing significance. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q36. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about The dedicated India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue format?

A. The Ministry of External Affairs India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief is current as on April 2026 and is the authoritative dated record for that relationship, and the owners instruct that this brief be cited for any specific current claim about it rather than a general assertion of warm ties; the wider methodological point is that a region-level policy claim and a country-level status claim require different evidence, so a candidate should name the dated brief when the demand turns on the present state of a particular bilateral relationship. B. Sikri frames Central Asia as a geographical area that abuts on the borders of major powers in Asia and will always attract foreign presences, which describes ongoing great-power competition for influence rather than any Indian ability to determine regional outcomes, and the owners add that Russia's and China's greater historical and geographic proximity constrains how much relative influence India can realistically build however effective its own diplomacy; the examinable consequence is that outcomes in this region are co-determined by Russian, Chinese and Western engagement, so an answer must place India's effort inside a competitive field rather than presenting it as the decisive variable. C. The Ashgabat Agreement was signed at Ashgabat on 25 April 2011 to establish an international multimodal transport and transit corridor between Central Asia and the Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman, and India joined with effect from 3 February 2018, which adds a rules-and-transit framework to India's Chabahar and corridor strategy and reduces dependence on direct territorial

access through Pakistan; the owners attach the limitation directly, because it is a facilitation framework rather than an infrastructure-finance mechanism, so its value depends on connected ports, rail and road segments, customs coordination and Iran-related sanctions exposure. D. The first India-Central Asia Summit was held virtually on 27 January 2022, the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue at foreign-minister level met in New Delhi on 6 June 2025 and envisaged preparing the ground for a second summit, and the third meeting of Secretaries of Security Councils and National Security Advisers met at Bishkek on 16 October 2025, while no second leader-level summit had been recorded as held by 3 August 2026; the owners treat that absence as a candid indicator that the dedicated format has not yet institutionalised at leader level, and they require the gap to be stated rather than glossed over when a demand asks about increasing significance.

Answer: D. Explanation: The first India-Central Asia Summit was held virtually on 27 January 2022, the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue at foreign-minister level met in New Delhi on 6 June 2025 and envisaged preparing the ground for a second summit, and the third meeting of Secretaries of Security Councils and National Security Advisers met at Bishkek on 16 October 2025, while no second leader-level summit had been recorded as held by 3 August 2026; the owners treat that absence as a candid indicator that the dedicated format has not yet institutionalised at leader level, and they require the gap to be stated rather than glossed over when a demand asks about increasing significance. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q37. Which statement correctly identifies The Chabahar contract as the concrete connectivity instrument?

A. India Ports Global Limited and Iran's Ports and Maritime Organisation signed a ten-year long-term contract for Chabahar port on 13 May 2024, with India announcing roughly one hundred and twenty million United States dollars in equipment investment and a two hundred and fifty million United States dollar credit window for mutually identified infrastructure; the owners require these to be cited as announced investment and an announced credit window rather than as delivered equipment or disbursed finance, because an announcement and a delivery are different evidentiary levels and the difference is exactly what a critical demand tests. B. The United States State Department revoked the 2018 Chabahar sanctions waiver on 16 September 2025 with effect from 29 September 2025, and a subsequent assurance of non-exposure ran only to 26 April 2026, so any status beyond that date requires fresh verification; the owners state the legal character precisely, because this is a change in another state's domestic sanctions posture that creates exposure risk for entities rather than an international legal obligation binding on India, and its practical effect is to convert the Iran work-around from a geographic question into a financing and sanctions-exposure question. C. The Ashgabat Agreement was signed at Ashgabat on 25 April 2011 to establish an international multimodal transport and transit corridor between Central Asia and the Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman, and India joined with effect from 3 February 2018, which adds a rules-and-transit framework to India's Chabahar and corridor strategy and reduces dependence on direct territorial access through Pakistan; the owners attach the limitation directly, because it is a facilitation framework rather than an infrastructure-finance mechanism, so its value depends on connected ports, rail and road segments, customs coordination and Iran-related sanctions exposure. D. The International North-South Transport Corridor is a connectivity framework intended to open a maritime-linked route to Central Asia and Eurasia bypassing Pakistan, and the owners require it to be treated as an announced and developing corridor with operating segments rather than a completed, full-capacity corridor; the same discipline extends to Chabahar, because connectivity-project timelines routinely lag announcements, so any specific capacity, throughput or completion claim requires independent dated verification instead of being assumed to match the original announcement.

Answer: A. Explanation: India Ports Global Limited and Iran's Ports and Maritime Organisation signed a ten-year long-term contract for Chabahar port on 13 May 2024, with India announcing roughly one hundred and twenty million United States dollars in equipment investment and a two hundred and fifty million United States dollar credit window for mutually identified infrastructure; the owners require these to be cited as announced investment and an announced credit window rather than as delivered equipment or disbursed finance, because an announcement and a delivery are different evidentiary levels and the difference is exactly what a critical demand tests. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q38. Which card should be filed under The Chabahar contract as the concrete connectivity instrument in an International Relations answer?

A. The International North-South Transport Corridor is a connectivity framework intended to open a maritime-linked route to Central Asia and Eurasia bypassing Pakistan, and the owners require it to be treated as an announced and developing corridor with operating segments rather than a completed, full-capacity corridor; the same discipline extends to Chabahar, because connectivity-project timelines routinely lag announcements, so any specific capacity, throughput or completion claim requires independent dated verification instead of being assumed to match the original announcement. B. India Ports Global Limited and Iran's Ports and Maritime Organisation signed a ten-year long-term contract for Chabahar port on 13 May 2024, with India announcing roughly one hundred and twenty million United States dollars in equipment investment and a two hundred and fifty million United States dollar credit window for mutually identified infrastructure; the owners require these to be cited as announced investment and an announced credit window rather than as delivered equipment or disbursed finance, because an announcement and a delivery are different evidentiary levels and the difference is exactly what a critical demand tests. C. The Ashgabat Agreement was signed at Ashgabat on 25 April 2011 to establish an international multimodal transport and transit corridor between Central Asia and the Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman, and India joined with effect from 3 February 2018, which adds a rules-and-transit framework to India's Chabahar and corridor strategy and reduces dependence on direct territorial access through Pakistan; the owners attach the limitation directly, because it is a facilitation framework rather than an infrastructure-finance mechanism, so its value depends on connected ports, rail and road segments, customs coordination and Iran-related sanctions exposure. D. The Ministry of External Affairs India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief is current as on April 2026 and is the authoritative dated record for that relationship, and the owners instruct that this brief be cited for any specific current claim about it rather than a general assertion of warm ties; the wider methodological point is that a region-level policy claim and a country-level status claim require different evidence, so a candidate should name the dated brief when the demand turns on the present state of a particular bilateral relationship.

Answer: B. Explanation: India Ports Global Limited and Iran's Ports and Maritime Organisation signed a ten-year long-term contract for Chabahar port on 13 May 2024, with India announcing roughly one hundred and twenty million United States dollars in equipment investment and a two hundred and fifty million United States dollar credit window for mutually identified infrastructure; the owners require these to be cited as announced investment and an announced credit window rather than as delivered equipment or disbursed finance, because an announcement and a delivery are different evidentiary levels and the difference is exactly what a critical demand tests. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q39. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of The Chabahar contract as the concrete connectivity instrument?

A. The Ashgabat Agreement was signed at Ashgabat on 25 April 2011 to establish an international multimodal transport and transit corridor between Central Asia and the Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman, and India joined with effect from 3 February 2018, which adds a rules-and-transit framework to India's Chabahar and corridor strategy and reduces dependence on direct territorial access through Pakistan; the owners attach the limitation directly, because it is a facilitation framework rather than an infrastructure-finance mechanism, so its value depends on connected ports, rail and road segments, customs coordination and Iran-related sanctions exposure. B. Sikri frames Central Asia as a geographical area that abuts on the borders of major powers in Asia and will always attract foreign presences, which describes ongoing great-power competition for influence rather than any Indian ability to determine regional outcomes, and the owners add that Russia's and China's greater historical and geographic proximity constrains how much relative influence India can realistically build however effective its own diplomacy; the examinable consequence is that outcomes in this region are co-determined by Russian, Chinese and Western engagement, so an answer must place India's effort inside a competitive field rather than presenting it as the decisive variable. C. India Ports Global Limited and Iran's Ports and Maritime Organisation signed a ten-year long-term contract for Chabahar port on 13 May 2024, with India announcing roughly one hundred and twenty million United States dollars in equipment investment and a two hundred and fifty million United States dollar credit window for mutually identified infrastructure; the owners require these to be cited as announced investment and an announced credit window rather than as delivered equipment or disbursed finance, because an announcement and a delivery are different evidentiary levels and the difference is exactly what a critical demand tests. D. The Ministry of External Affairs India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief is

current as on April 2026 and is the authoritative dated record for that relationship, and the owners instruct that this brief be cited for any specific current claim about it rather than a general assertion of warm ties; the wider methodological point is that a region-level policy claim and a country-level status claim require different evidence, so a candidate should name the dated brief when the demand turns on the present state of a particular bilateral relationship.

Answer: C. Explanation: India Ports Global Limited and Iran's Ports and Maritime Organisation signed a ten-year long-term contract for Chabahar port on 13 May 2024, with India announcing roughly one hundred and twenty million United States dollars in equipment investment and a two hundred and fifty million United States dollar credit window for mutually identified infrastructure; the owners require these to be cited as announced investment and an announced credit window rather than as delivered equipment or disbursed finance, because an announcement and a delivery are different evidentiary levels and the difference is exactly what a critical demand tests. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q40. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about The Chabahar contract as the concrete connectivity instrument?

A. The Ministry of External Affairs India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief is current as on April 2026 and is the authoritative dated record for that relationship, and the owners instruct that this brief be cited for any specific current claim about it rather than a general assertion of warm ties; the wider methodological point is that a region-level policy claim and a country-level status claim require different evidence, so a candidate should name the dated brief when the demand turns on the present state of a particular bilateral relationship. B. India's full membership of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation provides a seat and a platform but not privileged influence, because the same forum includes China, Russia and Pakistan, so its outputs reflect compromise among competing major-power interests rather than an India-centred agenda, and Pakistan's own membership means the forum cannot itself resolve the transit-access problem; the owners therefore separate two claims that answers routinely merge, namely that membership sustains political, security and economic engagement, and that membership does not by itself create physical connectivity, which depends on separate corridor projects. C. Sikri frames Central Asia as a geographical area that abuts on the borders of major powers in Asia and will always attract foreign presences, which describes ongoing great-power competition for influence rather than any Indian ability to determine regional outcomes, and the owners add that Russia's and China's greater historical and geographic proximity constrains how much relative influence India can realistically build however effective its own diplomacy; the examinable consequence is that outcomes in this region are co-determined by Russian, Chinese and Western engagement, so an answer must place India's effort inside a competitive field rather than presenting it as the decisive variable. D. India Ports Global Limited and Iran's Ports and Maritime Organisation signed a ten-year long-term contract for Chabahar port on 13 May 2024, with India announcing roughly one hundred and twenty million United States dollars in equipment investment and a two hundred and fifty million United States dollar credit window for mutually identified infrastructure; the owners require these to be cited as announced investment and an announced credit window rather than as delivered equipment or disbursed finance, because an announcement and a delivery are different evidentiary levels and the difference is exactly what a critical demand tests.

Answer: D. Explanation: India Ports Global Limited and Iran's Ports and Maritime Organisation signed a ten-year long-term contract for Chabahar port on 13 May 2024, with India announcing roughly one hundred and twenty million United States dollars in equipment investment and a two hundred and fifty million United States dollar credit window for mutually identified infrastructure; the owners require these to be cited as announced investment and an announced credit window rather than as delivered equipment or disbursed finance, because an announcement and a delivery are different evidentiary levels and the difference is exactly what a critical demand tests. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q41. Which statement correctly identifies The revoked Chabahar waiver as third-party sanctions exposure?

A. The United States State Department revoked the 2018 Chabahar sanctions waiver on 16 September 2025 with effect from 29 September 2025, and a subsequent assurance of non-exposure ran only to 26 April 2026, so any status beyond that date requires fresh verification; the owners state the legal character precisely, because this is a change in another state's domestic sanctions posture that creates exposure risk for entities rather than an international legal obligation binding on India, and its practical effect is to convert the Iran work-around from a geographic question into a financing and sanctions-exposure question. B. The International North-South Transport Corridor is a connectivity framework intended to open a maritime-linked route to Central Asia and Eurasia bypassing Pakistan, and the owners require it to be treated as an announced and developing corridor with operating segments rather than a completed, full-capacity corridor; the same discipline extends to Chabahar, because connectivity-project timelines routinely lag announcements, so any specific capacity, throughput or completion claim requires independent dated verification instead of being assumed to match the original announcement. C. The Ministry of External Affairs India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief is current as on April 2026 and is the authoritative dated record for that relationship, and the owners instruct that this brief be cited for any specific current claim about it rather than a general assertion of warm ties; the wider methodological point is that a region-level policy claim and a country-level status claim require different evidence, so a candidate should name the dated brief when the demand turns on the present state of a particular bilateral relationship. D. The Ashgabat Agreement was signed at Ashgabat on 25 April 2011 to establish an international multimodal transport and transit corridor between Central Asia and the Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman, and India joined with effect from 3 February 2018, which adds a rules-and-transit framework to India's Chabahar and corridor strategy and reduces dependence on direct territorial access through Pakistan; the owners attach the limitation directly, because it is a facilitation framework rather than an infrastructure-finance mechanism, so its value depends on connected ports, rail and road segments, customs coordination and Iran-related sanctions exposure.

Answer: A. Explanation: The United States State Department revoked the 2018 Chabahar sanctions waiver on 16 September 2025 with effect from 29 September 2025, and a subsequent assurance of non-exposure ran only to 26 April 2026, so any status beyond that date requires fresh verification; the owners state the legal character precisely, because this is a change in another state's domestic sanctions posture that creates exposure risk for entities rather than an international legal obligation binding on India, and its practical effect is to convert the Iran work-around from a geographic question into a financing and sanctions-exposure question. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q42. Which card should be filed under The revoked Chabahar waiver as third-party sanctions exposure in an International Relations answer?

A. The Ashgabat Agreement was signed at Ashgabat on 25 April 2011 to establish an international multimodal transport and transit corridor between Central Asia and the Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman, and India joined with effect from 3 February 2018, which adds a rules-and-transit framework to India's Chabahar and corridor strategy and reduces dependence on direct territorial access through Pakistan; the owners attach the limitation directly, because it is a facilitation framework rather than an infrastructure-finance mechanism, so its value depends on connected ports, rail and road segments, customs coordination and Iran-related sanctions exposure. B. The United States State Department revoked the 2018 Chabahar sanctions waiver on 16 September 2025 with effect from 29 September 2025, and a subsequent assurance of non-exposure ran only to 26 April 2026, so any status beyond that date requires fresh verification; the owners state the legal character precisely, because this is a change in another state's domestic sanctions posture that creates exposure risk for entities rather than an international legal obligation binding on India, and its practical effect is to convert the Iran work-around from a geographic question into a financing and sanctions-exposure question. C. Sikri frames Central Asia as a geographical area that abuts on the borders of major powers in Asia and will always attract foreign presences, which describes ongoing great-power competition for influence rather than any Indian ability to determine regional outcomes, and the owners add that Russia's and China's greater historical and geographic proximity constrains how much relative influence India can realistically build however effective its own diplomacy; the examinable consequence is that outcomes in this region are co-determined by Russian, Chinese and Western engagement, so an answer must place India's effort inside a competitive field rather than presenting it as the decisive variable. D. The Ministry of External Affairs India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief is current as on April 2026 and is the authoritative dated record for that relationship, and the owners instruct that this brief be

cited for any specific current claim about it rather than a general assertion of warm ties; the wider methodological point is that a region-level policy claim and a country-level status claim require different evidence, so a candidate should name the dated brief when the demand turns on the present state of a particular bilateral relationship.

Answer: B. Explanation: The United States State Department revoked the 2018 Chabahar sanctions waiver on 16 September 2025 with effect from 29 September 2025, and a subsequent assurance of non-exposure ran only to 26 April 2026, so any status beyond that date requires fresh verification; the owners state the legal character precisely, because this is a change in another state's domestic sanctions posture that creates exposure risk for entities rather than an international legal obligation binding on India, and its practical effect is to convert the Iran work-around from a geographic question into a financing and sanctions-exposure question. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q43. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of The revoked Chabahar waiver as third-party sanctions exposure?

A. India's full membership of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation provides a seat and a platform but not privileged influence, because the same forum includes China, Russia and Pakistan, so its outputs reflect compromise among competing major-power interests rather than an India-centred agenda, and Pakistan's own membership means the forum cannot itself resolve the transit-access problem; the owners therefore separate two claims that answers routinely merge, namely that membership sustains political, security and economic engagement, and that membership does not by itself create physical connectivity, which depends on separate corridor projects. B. Sikri frames Central Asia as a geographical area that abuts on the borders of major powers in Asia and will always attract foreign presences, which describes ongoing great-power competition for influence rather than any Indian ability to determine regional outcomes, and the owners add that Russia's and China's greater historical and geographic proximity constrains how much relative influence India can realistically build however effective its own diplomacy; the examinable consequence is that outcomes in this region are co-determined by Russian, Chinese and Western engagement, so an answer must place India's effort inside a competitive field rather than presenting it as the decisive variable. C. The United States State Department revoked the 2018 Chabahar sanctions waiver on 16 September 2025 with effect from 29 September 2025, and a subsequent assurance of non-exposure ran only to 26 April 2026, so any status beyond that date requires fresh verification; the owners state the legal character precisely, because this is a change in another state's domestic sanctions posture that creates exposure risk for entities rather than an international legal obligation binding on India, and its practical effect is to convert the Iran work-around from a geographic question into a financing and sanctions-exposure question. D. The Ministry of External Affairs India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief is current as on April 2026 and is the authoritative dated record for that relationship, and the owners instruct that this brief be cited for any specific current claim about it rather than a general assertion of warm ties; the wider methodological point is that a region-level policy claim and a country-level status claim require different evidence, so a candidate should name the dated brief when the demand turns on the present state of a particular bilateral relationship.

Answer: C. Explanation: The United States State Department revoked the 2018 Chabahar sanctions waiver on 16 September 2025 with effect from 29 September 2025, and a subsequent assurance of non-exposure ran only to 26 April 2026, so any status beyond that date requires fresh verification; the owners state the legal character precisely, because this is a change in another state's domestic sanctions posture that creates exposure risk for entities rather than an international legal obligation binding on India, and its practical effect is to convert the Iran work-around from a geographic question into a financing and sanctions-exposure question. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q44. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about The revoked Chabahar waiver as third-party sanctions exposure?

A. Sikri frames Central Asia as a geographical area that abuts on the borders of major powers in Asia and will always attract foreign presences, which describes ongoing great-power competition for influence rather than any Indian ability to determine regional outcomes, and the owners add that Russia's and China's greater historical and geographic proximity constrains how much relative influence India can realistically build however effective its own diplomacy; the examinable consequence is that outcomes in this region are co-determined by Russian, Chinese and Western engagement, so an answer must place India's effort inside a competitive field rather than presenting it as the decisive variable. B. Sikri argues that India must try to develop an understanding on energy with China because both are major energy consumers often seeking energy from the same sources and their competition is only benefiting the energy producers, which the owners treat as a rare explicit call for cooperative management of a shared dependency despite broader strategic mistrust; the analytical value of this anchor is that it shows competition and cooperation coexisting on a specific functional issue, so a critical answer can avoid the crude choice between pure rivalry and naive partnership. C. India's full membership of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation provides a seat and a platform but not privileged influence, because the same forum includes China, Russia and Pakistan, so its outputs reflect compromise among competing major-power interests rather than an India-centred agenda, and Pakistan's own membership means the forum cannot itself resolve the transit-access problem; the owners therefore separate two claims that answers routinely merge, namely that membership sustains political, security and economic engagement, and that membership does not by itself create physical connectivity, which depends on separate corridor projects. D. The United States State Department revoked the 2018 Chabahar sanctions waiver on 16 September 2025 with effect from 29 September 2025, and a subsequent assurance of non-exposure ran only to 26 April 2026, so any status beyond that date requires fresh verification; the owners state the legal character precisely, because this is a change in another state's domestic sanctions posture that creates exposure risk for entities rather than an international legal obligation binding on India, and its practical effect is to convert the Iran work-around from a geographic question into a financing and sanctions-exposure question.

Answer: D. Explanation: The United States State Department revoked the 2018 Chabahar sanctions waiver on 16 September 2025 with effect from 29 September 2025, and a subsequent assurance of non-exposure ran only to 26 April 2026, so any status beyond that date requires fresh verification; the owners state the legal character precisely, because this is a change in another state's domestic sanctions posture that creates exposure risk for entities rather than an international legal obligation binding on India, and its practical effect is to convert the Iran work-around from a geographic question into a financing and sanctions-exposure question. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q45. Which statement correctly identifies The corridor instruments and their exact completion status?

A. The International North-South Transport Corridor is a connectivity framework intended to open a maritime-linked route to Central Asia and Eurasia bypassing Pakistan, and the owners require it to be treated as an announced and developing corridor with operating segments rather than a completed, full-capacity corridor; the same discipline extends to Chabahar, because connectivity-project timelines routinely lag announcements, so any specific capacity, throughput or completion claim requires independent dated verification instead of being assumed to match the original announcement. B. The Ashgabat Agreement was signed at Ashgabat on 25 April 2011 to establish an international multimodal transport and transit corridor between Central Asia and the Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman, and India joined with effect from 3 February 2018, which adds a rules-and-transit framework to India's Chabahar and corridor strategy and reduces dependence on direct territorial access through Pakistan; the owners attach the limitation directly, because it is a facilitation framework rather than an infrastructure-finance mechanism, so its value depends on connected ports, rail and road segments, customs coordination and Iran-related sanctions exposure. C. The Ministry of External Affairs India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief is current as on April 2026 and is the authoritative dated record for that relationship, and the owners instruct that this brief be cited for any specific current claim about it rather than a general assertion of warm ties; the wider methodological point is that a region-level policy claim and a country-level status claim require different evidence, so a candidate should name the dated brief when the demand turns on the present state of a particular bilateral relationship. D. Sikri frames Central Asia as a geographical area that abuts on the borders of major powers in Asia and will always attract foreign presences, which describes ongoing

great-power competition for influence rather than any Indian ability to determine regional outcomes, and the owners add that Russia's and China's greater historical and geographic proximity constrains how much relative influence India can realistically build however effective its own diplomacy; the examinable consequence is that outcomes in this region are co-determined by Russian, Chinese and Western engagement, so an answer must place India's effort inside a competitive field rather than presenting it as the decisive variable.

Answer: A. Explanation: The International North-South Transport Corridor is a connectivity framework intended to open a maritime-linked route to Central Asia and Eurasia bypassing Pakistan, and the owners require it to be treated as an announced and developing corridor with operating segments rather than a completed, full-capacity corridor; the same discipline extends to Chabahar, because connectivity-project timelines routinely lag announcements, so any specific capacity, throughput or completion claim requires independent dated verification instead of being assumed to match the original announcement. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q46. Which card should be filed under The corridor instruments and their exact completion status in an International Relations answer?

A. Sikri frames Central Asia as a geographical area that abuts on the borders of major powers in Asia and will always attract foreign presences, which describes ongoing great-power competition for influence rather than any Indian ability to determine regional outcomes, and the owners add that Russia's and China's greater historical and geographic proximity constrains how much relative influence India can realistically build however effective its own diplomacy; the examinable consequence is that outcomes in this region are co-determined by Russian, Chinese and Western engagement, so an answer must place India's effort inside a competitive field rather than presenting it as the decisive variable. B. The International North-South Transport Corridor is a connectivity framework intended to open a maritime-linked route to Central Asia and Eurasia bypassing Pakistan, and the owners require it to be treated as an announced and developing corridor with operating segments rather than a completed, full-capacity corridor; the same discipline extends to Chabahar, because connectivity-project timelines routinely lag announcements, so any specific capacity, throughput or completion claim requires independent dated verification instead of being assumed to match the original announcement. C. The Ministry of External Affairs India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief is current as on April 2026 and is the authoritative dated record for that relationship, and the owners instruct that this brief be cited for any specific current claim about it rather than a general assertion of warm ties; the wider methodological point is that a region-level policy claim and a country-level status claim require different evidence, so a candidate should name the dated brief when the demand turns on the present state of a particular bilateral relationship. D. India's full membership of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation provides a seat and a platform but not privileged influence, because the same forum includes China, Russia and Pakistan, so its outputs reflect compromise among competing major-power interests rather than an India-centred agenda, and Pakistan's own membership means the forum cannot itself resolve the transit-access problem; the owners therefore separate two claims that answers routinely merge, namely that membership sustains political, security and economic engagement, and that membership does not by itself create physical connectivity, which depends on separate corridor projects.

Answer: B. Explanation: The International North-South Transport Corridor is a connectivity framework intended to open a maritime-linked route to Central Asia and Eurasia bypassing Pakistan, and the owners require it to be treated as an announced and developing corridor with operating segments rather than a completed, full-capacity corridor; the same discipline extends to Chabahar, because connectivity-project timelines routinely lag announcements, so any specific capacity, throughput or completion claim requires independent dated verification instead of being assumed to match the original announcement. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q47. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of The corridor instruments and their exact completion status?

A. Sikri argues that India must try to develop an understanding on energy with China because both are major energy consumers often seeking energy from the same sources and their competition is only benefiting the energy producers, which the owners treat as a rare explicit call for cooperative management of a shared dependency despite broader strategic mistrust; the analytical value of this anchor is that it shows competition and cooperation coexisting on a specific functional issue, so a critical answer can avoid the crude choice between pure rivalry and naive partnership. B. Sikri frames Central Asia as a geographical area that abuts on the borders of major powers in Asia and will always attract foreign presences, which describes ongoing great-power competition for influence rather than any Indian ability to determine regional outcomes, and the owners add that Russia's and China's greater historical and geographic proximity constrains how much relative influence India can realistically build however effective its own diplomacy; the examinable consequence is that outcomes in this region are co-determined by Russian, Chinese and Western engagement, so an answer must place India's effort inside a competitive field rather than presenting it as the decisive variable. C. The International North-South Transport Corridor is a connectivity framework intended to open a maritime-linked route to Central Asia and Eurasia bypassing Pakistan, and the owners require it to be treated as an announced and developing corridor with operating segments rather than a completed, full-capacity corridor; the same discipline extends to Chabahar, because connectivity-project timelines routinely lag announcements, so any specific capacity, throughput or completion claim requires independent dated verification instead of being assumed to match the original announcement. D. India's full membership of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation provides a seat and a platform but not privileged influence, because the same forum includes China, Russia and Pakistan, so its outputs reflect compromise among competing major-power interests rather than an India-centred agenda, and Pakistan's own membership means the forum cannot itself resolve the transit-access problem; the owners therefore separate two claims that answers routinely merge, namely that membership sustains political, security and economic engagement, and that membership does not by itself create physical connectivity, which depends on separate corridor projects.

Answer: C. Explanation: The International North-South Transport Corridor is a connectivity framework intended to open a maritime-linked route to Central Asia and Eurasia bypassing Pakistan, and the owners require it to be treated as an announced and developing corridor with operating segments rather than a completed, full-capacity corridor; the same discipline extends to Chabahar, because connectivity-project timelines routinely lag announcements, so any specific capacity, throughput or completion claim requires independent dated verification instead of being assumed to match the original announcement. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q48. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about The corridor instruments and their exact completion status?

A. India's full membership of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation provides a seat and a platform but not privileged influence, because the same forum includes China, Russia and Pakistan, so its outputs reflect compromise among competing major-power interests rather than an India-centred agenda, and Pakistan's own membership means the forum cannot itself resolve the transit-access problem; the owners therefore separate two claims that answers routinely merge, namely that membership sustains political, security and economic engagement, and that membership does not by itself create physical connectivity, which depends on separate corridor projects. B. Afghanistan sits at the centre of the connectivity problem because it is the potential land-bridge to Central Asia while being itself a source of instability that currently forecloses that option, and the owners record this as a genuine unresolved tension rather than a solved problem; the consequence for answer writing is that Afghanistan cannot be treated either as a ready corridor or as an irrelevant space, and any recommendation must be calibrated to a situation in which the shortest route is the least available one. C. Sikri argues that India must try to develop an understanding on energy with China because both are major energy consumers often seeking energy from the same sources and their competition is only benefiting the energy producers, which the owners treat as a rare explicit call for cooperative management of a shared dependency despite broader strategic mistrust; the analytical value of this anchor is that it shows competition and cooperation coexisting on a specific functional issue, so a critical answer can avoid the crude choice between pure rivalry and naive partnership. D. The International North-South Transport Corridor is a connectivity framework intended to open a maritime-linked route to Central Asia and Eurasia bypassing Pakistan, and the owners require it to be treated as an announced and developing corridor with operating segments rather than a completed, full-capacity corridor; the same discipline extends to Chabahar, because connectivity-project timelines routinely lag

announcements, so any specific capacity, throughput or completion claim requires independent dated verification instead of being assumed to match the original announcement.

Answer: D. Explanation: The International North-South Transport Corridor is a connectivity framework intended to open a maritime-linked route to Central Asia and Eurasia bypassing Pakistan, and the owners require it to be treated as an announced and developing corridor with operating segments rather than a completed, full-capacity corridor; the same discipline extends to Chabahar, because connectivity-project timelines routinely lag announcements, so any specific capacity, throughput or completion claim requires independent dated verification instead of being assumed to match the original announcement. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q49. Which statement correctly identifies The Ashgabat Agreement as a transit-rules framework?

A. The Ashgabat Agreement was signed at Ashgabat on 25 April 2011 to establish an international multimodal transport and transit corridor between Central Asia and the Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman, and India joined with effect from 3 February 2018, which adds a rules-and-transit framework to India's Chabahar and corridor strategy and reduces dependence on direct territorial access through Pakistan; the owners attach the limitation directly, because it is a facilitation framework rather than an infrastructure-finance mechanism, so its value depends on connected ports, rail and road segments, customs coordination and Iran-related sanctions exposure. B. India's full membership of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation provides a seat and a platform but not privileged influence, because the same forum includes China, Russia and Pakistan, so its outputs reflect compromise among competing major-power interests rather than an India-centred agenda, and Pakistan's own membership means the forum cannot itself resolve the transit-access problem; the owners therefore separate two claims that answers routinely merge, namely that membership sustains political, security and economic engagement, and that membership does not by itself create physical connectivity, which depends on separate corridor projects. C. Sikri frames Central Asia as a geographical area that abuts on the borders of major powers in Asia and will always attract foreign presences, which describes ongoing great-power competition for influence rather than any Indian ability to determine regional outcomes, and the owners add that Russia's and China's greater historical and geographic proximity constrains how much relative influence India can realistically build however effective its own diplomacy; the examinable consequence is that outcomes in this region are co-determined by Russian, Chinese and Western engagement, so an answer must place India's effort inside a competitive field rather than presenting it as the decisive variable. D. The Ministry of External Affairs India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief is current as on April 2026 and is the authoritative dated record for that relationship, and the owners instruct that this brief be cited for any specific current claim about it rather than a general assertion of warm ties; the wider methodological point is that a region-level policy claim and a country-level status claim require different evidence, so a candidate should name the dated brief when the demand turns on the present state of a particular bilateral relationship.

Answer: A. Explanation: The Ashgabat Agreement was signed at Ashgabat on 25 April 2011 to establish an international multimodal transport and transit corridor between Central Asia and the Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman, and India joined with effect from 3 February 2018, which adds a rules-and-transit framework to India's Chabahar and corridor strategy and reduces dependence on direct territorial access through Pakistan; the owners attach the limitation directly, because it is a facilitation framework rather than an infrastructure-finance mechanism, so its value depends on connected ports, rail and road segments, customs coordination and Iran-related sanctions exposure. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q50. Which card should be filed under The Ashgabat Agreement as a transit-rules framework in an International Relations answer?

A. India's full membership of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation provides a seat and a platform but not privileged influence, because the same forum includes China, Russia and Pakistan, so its outputs reflect compromise among competing major-power interests rather than an India-centred agenda, and Pakistan's own membership means the forum cannot itself resolve the transit-access problem; the owners therefore separate two claims that answers routinely merge, namely that membership sustains political, security and economic engagement, and that membership does not by itself create physical connectivity, which depends on separate corridor projects. B. The Ashgabat Agreement was signed at Ashgabat on 25 April 2011 to establish an international multimodal transport and transit corridor between Central Asia and the Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman, and India joined with effect from 3 February

2018, which adds a rules-and-transit framework to India's Chabahar and corridor strategy and reduces dependence on direct territorial access through Pakistan; the owners attach the limitation directly, because it is a facilitation framework rather than an infrastructure-finance mechanism, so its value depends on connected ports, rail and road segments, customs coordination and Iran-related sanctions exposure. C. Sikri argues that India must try to develop an understanding on energy with China because both are major energy consumers often seeking energy from the same sources and their competition is only benefiting the energy producers, which the owners treat as a rare explicit call for cooperative management of a shared dependency despite broader strategic mistrust; the analytical value of this anchor is that it shows competition and cooperation coexisting on a specific functional issue, so a critical answer can avoid the crude choice between pure rivalry and naive partnership. D. Sikri frames Central Asia as a geographical area that abuts on the borders of major powers in Asia and will always attract foreign presences, which describes ongoing great-power competition for influence rather than any Indian ability to determine regional outcomes, and the owners add that Russia's and China's greater historical and geographic proximity constrains how much relative influence India can realistically build however effective its own diplomacy; the examinable consequence is that outcomes in this region are co-determined by Russian, Chinese and Western engagement, so an answer must place India's effort inside a competitive field rather than presenting it as the decisive variable.

Answer: B. Explanation: The Ashgabat Agreement was signed at Ashgabat on 25 April 2011 to establish an international multimodal transport and transit corridor between Central Asia and the Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman, and India joined with effect from 3 February 2018, which adds a rules-and-transit framework to India's Chabahar and corridor strategy and reduces dependence on direct territorial access through Pakistan; the owners attach the limitation directly, because it is a facilitation framework rather than an infrastructure-finance mechanism, so its value depends on connected ports, rail and road segments, customs coordination and Iran-related sanctions exposure. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q51. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of The Ashgabat Agreement as a transit-rules framework?

A. India's full membership of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation provides a seat and a platform but not privileged influence, because the same forum includes China, Russia and Pakistan, so its outputs reflect compromise among competing major-power interests rather than an India-centred agenda, and Pakistan's own membership means the forum cannot itself resolve the transit-access problem; the owners therefore separate two claims that answers routinely merge, namely that membership sustains political, security and economic engagement, and that membership does not by itself create physical connectivity, which depends on separate corridor projects. B. Sikri argues that India must try to develop an understanding on energy with China because both are major energy consumers often seeking energy from the same sources and their competition is only benefiting the energy producers, which the owners treat as a rare explicit call for cooperative management of a shared dependency despite broader strategic mistrust; the analytical value of this anchor is that it shows competition and cooperation coexisting on a specific functional issue, so a critical answer can avoid the crude choice between pure rivalry and naive partnership. C. The Ashgabat Agreement was signed at Ashgabat on 25 April 2011 to establish an international multimodal transport and transit corridor between Central Asia and the Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman, and India joined with effect from 3 February 2018, which adds a rules-and-transit framework to India's Chabahar and corridor strategy and reduces dependence on direct territorial access through Pakistan; the owners attach the limitation directly, because it is a facilitation framework rather than an infrastructure-finance mechanism, so its value depends on connected ports, rail and road segments, customs coordination and Iran-related sanctions exposure. D. Afghanistan sits at the centre of the connectivity problem because it is the potential land-bridge to Central Asia while being itself a source of instability that currently forecloses that option, and the owners record this as a genuine unresolved tension rather than a solved problem; the consequence for answer writing is that Afghanistan cannot be treated either as a ready corridor or as an irrelevant space, and any recommendation must be calibrated to a situation in which the shortest route is the least available one.

Answer: C. Explanation: The Ashgabat Agreement was signed at Ashgabat on 25 April 2011 to establish an international multimodal transport and transit corridor between Central Asia and the Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman, and India joined with effect from 3 February 2018, which adds a rules-and-transit framework to India's Chabahar and corridor strategy and reduces dependence on direct territorial access through Pakistan; the owners attach the limitation directly, because it is a facilitation framework rather than an

infrastructure-finance mechanism, so its value depends on connected ports, rail and road segments, customs coordination and Iran-related sanctions exposure. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q52. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about The Ashgabat Agreement as a transit-rules framework?

A. Sikri argues that India must try to develop an understanding on energy with China because both are major energy consumers often seeking energy from the same sources and their competition is only benefiting the energy producers, which the owners treat as a rare explicit call for cooperative management of a shared dependency despite broader strategic mistrust; the analytical value of this anchor is that it shows competition and cooperation coexisting on a specific functional issue, so a critical answer can avoid the crude choice between pure rivalry and naive partnership. B. The maritime-linked work-around through Iran bypasses the Pakistan land constraint but substitutes one set of external dependencies, namely Iran-linked geopolitics and sanctions risk, for another, so no unilateral connectivity solution exists and the dependency problem is managed rather than removed; the owners pair this with the timeline warning that announcements outrun delivery in this sector, which together give the honest verdict that India's Central Asia problem is not an absence of interest but the conversion of diplomatic goodwill into reliable access across contested transit space. C. Afghanistan sits at the centre of the connectivity problem because it is the potential land-bridge to Central Asia while being itself a source of instability that currently forecloses that option, and the owners record this as a genuine unresolved tension rather than a solved problem; the consequence for answer writing is that Afghanistan cannot be treated either as a ready corridor or as an irrelevant space, and any recommendation must be calibrated to a situation in which the shortest route is the least available one. D. The Ashgabat Agreement was signed at Ashgabat on 25 April 2011 to establish an international multimodal transport and transit corridor between Central Asia and the Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman, and India joined with effect from 3 February 2018, which adds a rules-and-transit framework to India's Chabahar and corridor strategy and reduces dependence on direct territorial access through Pakistan; the owners attach the limitation directly, because it is a facilitation framework rather than an infrastructure-finance mechanism, so its value depends on connected ports, rail and road segments, customs coordination and Iran-related sanctions exposure.

Answer: D. Explanation: The Ashgabat Agreement was signed at Ashgabat on 25 April 2011 to establish an international multimodal transport and transit corridor between Central Asia and the Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman, and India joined with effect from 3 February 2018, which adds a rules-and-transit framework to India's Chabahar and corridor strategy and reduces dependence on direct territorial access through Pakistan; the owners attach the limitation directly, because it is a facilitation framework rather than an infrastructure-finance mechanism, so its value depends on connected ports, rail and road segments, customs coordination and Iran-related sanctions exposure. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q53. Which statement correctly identifies The dated bilateral record inside the region?

A. The Ministry of External Affairs India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief is current as on April 2026 and is the authoritative dated record for that relationship, and the owners instruct that this brief be cited for any specific current claim about it rather than a general assertion of warm ties; the wider methodological point is that a region-level policy claim and a country-level status claim require different evidence, so a candidate should name the dated brief when the demand turns on the present state of a particular bilateral relationship. B. Sikri frames Central Asia as a geographical area that abuts on the borders of major powers in Asia and will always attract foreign presences, which describes ongoing great-power competition for influence rather than any Indian ability to determine regional outcomes, and the owners add that Russia's and China's greater historical and geographic proximity constrains how much relative influence India can realistically build however effective its own diplomacy; the examinable consequence is that outcomes in this region are co-determined by Russian, Chinese and Western engagement, so an answer must place India's effort inside a competitive field rather than presenting it as the decisive variable. C. India's full membership of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation provides a seat and a platform but not privileged influence, because the same forum includes China, Russia and Pakistan, so its outputs reflect compromise among competing major-power interests rather than an India-centred agenda, and Pakistan's own membership means the forum cannot itself resolve the transit-access problem; the owners therefore separate two claims that answers routinely merge, namely that membership sustains political, security and economic engagement, and that membership does not by itself create

physical connectivity, which depends on separate corridor projects. D. Sikri argues that India must try to develop an understanding on energy with China because both are major energy consumers often seeking energy from the same sources and their competition is only benefiting the energy producers, which the owners treat as a rare explicit call for cooperative management of a shared dependency despite broader strategic mistrust; the analytical value of this anchor is that it shows competition and cooperation coexisting on a specific functional issue, so a critical answer can avoid the crude choice between pure rivalry and naive partnership.

Answer: A. Explanation: The Ministry of External Affairs India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief is current as on April 2026 and is the authoritative dated record for that relationship, and the owners instruct that this brief be cited for any specific current claim about it rather than a general assertion of warm ties; the wider methodological point is that a region-level policy claim and a country-level status claim require different evidence, so a candidate should name the dated brief when the demand turns on the present state of a particular bilateral relationship. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q54. Which card should be filed under The dated bilateral record inside the region in an International Relations answer?

A. Sikri argues that India must try to develop an understanding on energy with China because both are major energy consumers often seeking energy from the same sources and their competition is only benefiting the energy producers, which the owners treat as a rare explicit call for cooperative management of a shared dependency despite broader strategic mistrust; the analytical value of this anchor is that it shows competition and cooperation coexisting on a specific functional issue, so a critical answer can avoid the crude choice between pure rivalry and naive partnership. B. The Ministry of External Affairs India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief is current as on April 2026 and is the authoritative dated record for that relationship, and the owners instruct that this brief be cited for any specific current claim about it rather than a general assertion of warm ties; the wider methodological point is that a region-level policy claim and a country-level status claim require different evidence, so a candidate should name the dated brief when the demand turns on the present state of a particular bilateral relationship. C. Afghanistan sits at the centre of the connectivity problem because it is the potential land-bridge to Central Asia while being itself a source of instability that currently forecloses that option, and the owners record this as a genuine unresolved tension rather than a solved problem; the consequence for answer writing is that Afghanistan cannot be treated either as a ready corridor or as an irrelevant space, and any recommendation must be calibrated to a situation in which the shortest route is the least available one. D. India's full membership of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation provides a seat and a platform but not privileged influence, because the same forum includes China, Russia and Pakistan, so its outputs reflect compromise among competing major-power interests rather than an India-centred agenda, and Pakistan's own membership means the forum cannot itself resolve the transit-access problem; the owners therefore separate two claims that answers routinely merge, namely that membership sustains political, security and economic engagement, and that membership does not by itself create physical connectivity, which depends on separate corridor projects.

Answer: B. Explanation: The Ministry of External Affairs India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief is current as on April 2026 and is the authoritative dated record for that relationship, and the owners instruct that this brief be cited for any specific current claim about it rather than a general assertion of warm ties; the wider methodological point is that a region-level policy claim and a country-level status claim require different evidence, so a candidate should name the dated brief when the demand turns on the present state of a particular bilateral relationship. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q55. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of The dated bilateral record inside the region?

A. The maritime-linked work-around through Iran bypasses the Pakistan land constraint but substitutes one set of external dependencies, namely Iran-linked geopolitics and sanctions risk, for another, so no unilateral connectivity solution exists and the dependency problem is managed rather than removed; the owners pair this with the timeline warning that announcements outrun delivery in this sector, which together give the honest verdict that India's Central Asia problem is not an absence of interest but the conversion of diplomatic goodwill into reliable access across contested transit space. B. Sikri argues that India must try to develop an understanding on energy with China because both are major energy consumers often seeking energy from the same sources and their competition is only benefiting the energy producers, which the owners treat as a rare explicit call for cooperative management of a shared dependency despite broader strategic mistrust; the analytical value of this anchor is that it shows competition and cooperation coexisting on a specific functional issue, so a critical answer can avoid the crude choice between pure rivalry and naive partnership. C. The Ministry of External Affairs India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief is current as on April 2026 and is the authoritative dated record for that relationship, and the owners instruct that this brief be cited for any specific current claim about it rather than a general assertion of warm ties; the wider methodological point is that a region-level policy claim and a country-level status claim require different evidence, so a candidate should name the dated brief when the demand turns on the present state of a particular bilateral relationship. D. Afghanistan sits at the centre of the connectivity problem because it is the potential land-bridge to Central Asia while being itself a source of instability that currently forecloses that option, and the owners record this as a genuine unresolved tension rather than a solved problem; the consequence for answer writing is that Afghanistan cannot be treated either as a ready corridor or as an irrelevant space, and any recommendation must be calibrated to a situation in which the shortest route is the least available one.

Answer: C. Explanation: The Ministry of External Affairs India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief is current as on April 2026 and is the authoritative dated record for that relationship, and the owners instruct that this brief be cited for any specific current claim about it rather than a general assertion of warm ties; the wider methodological point is that a region-level policy claim and a country-level status claim require different evidence, so a candidate should name the dated brief when the demand turns on the present state of a particular bilateral relationship. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q56. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about The dated bilateral record inside the region?

A. The audited ledgers route two General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, namely 2018 General Studies Paper II question 10 on outside powers in Central Asia and India joining the Ashgabat Agreement, a Discuss the implications demand of 10 marks and 150 words for which the ledger records that the printed word-limit tail was corrupted in the scan and that the Core route supersedes the older Advanced ownership, and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 10 on India's evolving relations with the Central Asian Republics, a Critically analyse demand of 10 marks and 150 words; one objective demand is also routed here and carried as a coverage requirement only, namely 2025 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 62 on International North-South Transport Corridor connectivity, for which the official Set-A key is present locally while no option or answer letter is recorded or inferred; the locally held OCR-searchable official papers were read only to confirm printed wording and no question, key or marking scheme was imported from them. B. The maritime-linked work-around through Iran bypasses the Pakistan land constraint but substitutes one set of external dependencies, namely Iran-linked geopolitics and sanctions risk, for another, so no unilateral connectivity solution exists and the dependency problem is managed rather than removed; the owners pair this with the timeline warning that announcements outrun delivery in this sector, which together give the honest verdict that India's Central Asia problem is not an absence of interest but the conversion of diplomatic goodwill into reliable access across contested transit space. C. Afghanistan sits at the centre of the connectivity problem because it is the potential land-bridge to Central Asia while being itself a source of instability that currently forecloses that option, and the owners record this as a genuine unresolved tension rather than a solved problem; the consequence for answer writing is that Afghanistan cannot be treated either as a ready corridor or as an irrelevant space, and any recommendation must be calibrated to a situation in which the shortest route is the least available one. D. The Ministry of External Affairs India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief is current as on April 2026 and is the authoritative dated record for that relationship, and the owners instruct that this brief be cited for any specific current claim about it rather than a

general assertion of warm ties; the wider methodological point is that a region-level policy claim and a country-level status claim require different evidence, so a candidate should name the dated brief when the demand turns on the present state of a particular bilateral relationship.

Answer: D. Explanation: The Ministry of External Affairs India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief is current as on April 2026 and is the authoritative dated record for that relationship, and the owners instruct that this brief be cited for any specific current claim about it rather than a general assertion of warm ties; the wider methodological point is that a region-level policy claim and a country-level status claim require different evidence, so a candidate should name the dated brief when the demand turns on the present state of a particular bilateral relationship. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q57. Which statement correctly identifies The New Great Game as multi-actor competition without Indian determinism?

A. Sikri frames Central Asia as a geographical area that abuts on the borders of major powers in Asia and will always attract foreign presences, which describes ongoing great-power competition for influence rather than any Indian ability to determine regional outcomes, and the owners add that Russia's and China's greater historical and geographic proximity constrains how much relative influence India can realistically build however effective its own diplomacy; the examinable consequence is that outcomes in this region are co-determined by Russian, Chinese and Western engagement, so an answer must place India's effort inside a competitive field rather than presenting it as the decisive variable. B. Sikri argues that India must try to develop an understanding on energy with China because both are major energy consumers often seeking energy from the same sources and their competition is only benefiting the energy producers, which the owners treat as a rare explicit call for cooperative management of a shared dependency despite broader strategic mistrust; the analytical value of this anchor is that it shows competition and cooperation coexisting on a specific functional issue, so a critical answer can avoid the crude choice between pure rivalry and naive partnership. C. Afghanistan sits at the centre of the connectivity problem because it is the potential land-bridge to Central Asia while being itself a source of instability that currently forecloses that option, and the owners record this as a genuine unresolved tension rather than a solved problem; the consequence for answer writing is that Afghanistan cannot be treated either as a ready corridor or as an irrelevant space, and any recommendation must be calibrated to a situation in which the shortest route is the least available one. D. India's full membership of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation provides a seat and a platform but not privileged influence, because the same forum includes China, Russia and Pakistan, so its outputs reflect compromise among competing major-power interests rather than an India-centred agenda, and Pakistan's own membership means the forum cannot itself resolve the transit-access problem; the owners therefore separate two claims that answers routinely merge, namely that membership sustains political, security and economic engagement, and that membership does not by itself create physical connectivity, which depends on separate corridor projects.

Answer: A. Explanation: Sikri frames Central Asia as a geographical area that abuts on the borders of major powers in Asia and will always attract foreign presences, which describes ongoing great-power competition for influence rather than any Indian ability to determine regional outcomes, and the owners add that Russia's and China's greater historical and geographic proximity constrains how much relative influence India can realistically build however effective its own diplomacy; the examinable consequence is that outcomes in this region are co-determined by Russian, Chinese and Western engagement, so an answer must place India's effort inside a competitive field rather than presenting it as the decisive variable. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q58. Which card should be filed under The New Great Game as multi-actor competition without Indian determinism in an International Relations answer?

A. Afghanistan sits at the centre of the connectivity problem because it is the potential land-bridge to Central Asia while being itself a source of instability that currently forecloses that option, and the owners record this as a genuine unresolved tension rather than a solved problem; the consequence for answer writing is that Afghanistan cannot be treated either as a ready corridor or as an irrelevant space, and any recommendation must be calibrated to a situation in which the shortest route is the least available one. B. Sikri frames Central Asia as a geographical area that abuts on the borders of major powers in Asia and will always attract foreign presences, which describes ongoing great-power competition for influence rather than any Indian ability to determine regional outcomes, and the owners add that Russia's and China's greater historical and geographic proximity constrains how much relative influence India can realistically build however effective its own diplomacy; the examinable consequence is that outcomes in this region are co-determined by Russian, Chinese and Western engagement, so an answer must place India's effort inside a competitive field rather than presenting it as the decisive variable. C. Sikri argues that India must try to develop an understanding on energy with China because both are major energy consumers often seeking energy from the same sources and their competition is only benefiting the energy producers, which the owners treat as a rare explicit call for cooperative management of a shared dependency despite broader strategic mistrust; the analytical value of this anchor is that it shows competition and cooperation coexisting on a specific functional issue, so a critical answer can avoid the crude choice between pure rivalry and naive partnership. D. The maritime-linked work-around through Iran bypasses the Pakistan land constraint but substitutes one set of external dependencies, namely Iran-linked geopolitics and sanctions risk, for another, so no unilateral connectivity solution exists and the dependency problem is managed rather than removed; the owners pair this with the timeline warning that announcements outrun delivery in this sector, which together give the honest verdict that India's Central Asia problem is not an absence of interest but the conversion of diplomatic goodwill into reliable access across contested transit space.

Answer: B. Explanation: Sikri frames Central Asia as a geographical area that abuts on the borders of major powers in Asia and will always attract foreign presences, which describes ongoing great-power competition for influence rather than any Indian ability to determine regional outcomes, and the owners add that Russia's and China's greater historical and geographic proximity constrains how much relative influence India can realistically build however effective its own diplomacy; the examinable consequence is that outcomes in this region are co-determined by Russian, Chinese and Western engagement, so an answer must place India's effort inside a competitive field rather than presenting it as the decisive variable. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q59. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of The New Great Game as multi-actor competition without Indian determinism?

A. The audited ledgers route two General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, namely 2018 General Studies Paper II question 10 on outside powers in Central Asia and India joining the Ashgabat Agreement, a Discuss the implications demand of 10 marks and 150 words for which the ledger records that the printed word-limit tail was corrupted in the scan and that the Core route supersedes the older Advanced ownership, and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 10 on India's evolving relations with the Central Asian Republics, a Critically analyse demand of 10 marks and 150 words; one objective demand is also routed here and carried as a coverage requirement only, namely 2025 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 62 on International North-South Transport Corridor connectivity, for which the official Set-A key is present locally while no option or answer letter is recorded or inferred; the locally held OCR-searchable official papers were read only to confirm printed wording and no question, key or marking scheme was imported from them. B. The maritime-linked work-around through Iran bypasses the Pakistan land constraint but substitutes one set of external dependencies, namely Iran-linked geopolitics and sanctions risk, for another, so no unilateral connectivity solution exists and the dependency problem is managed rather than removed; the owners pair this with the timeline warning that announcements outrun delivery in this sector, which together give the honest verdict that India's Central Asia problem is not an absence of interest but the conversion of diplomatic goodwill into reliable access across contested transit space. C. Sikri frames Central Asia as a geographical area that abuts on the borders of major powers in Asia and will always attract foreign presences, which describes ongoing great-power competition for influence rather than any Indian ability to determine regional outcomes, and the owners add that Russia's and China's greater historical and geographic proximity constrains how much relative influence India can realistically build however effective its own diplomacy; the examinable consequence is that outcomes in this region are co-determined

by Russian, Chinese and Western engagement, so an answer must place India's effort inside a competitive field rather than presenting it as the decisive variable. D. Afghanistan sits at the centre of the connectivity problem because it is the potential land-bridge to Central Asia while being itself a source of instability that currently forecloses that option, and the owners record this as a genuine unresolved tension rather than a solved problem; the consequence for answer writing is that Afghanistan cannot be treated either as a ready corridor or as an irrelevant space, and any recommendation must be calibrated to a situation in which the shortest route is the least available one.

Answer: C. Explanation: Sikri frames Central Asia as a geographical area that abuts on the borders of major powers in Asia and will always attract foreign presences, which describes ongoing great-power competition for influence rather than any Indian ability to determine regional outcomes, and the owners add that Russia's and China's greater historical and geographic proximity constrains how much relative influence India can realistically build however effective its own diplomacy; the examinable consequence is that outcomes in this region are co-determined by Russian, Chinese and Western engagement, so an answer must place India's effort inside a competitive field rather than presenting it as the decisive variable. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q60. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about The New Great Game as multi-actor competition without Indian determinism?

A. The audited ledgers route two General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, namely 2018 General Studies Paper II question 10 on outside powers in Central Asia and India joining the Ashgabat Agreement, a Discuss the implications demand of 10 marks and 150 words for which the ledger records that the printed word-limit tail was corrupted in the scan and that the Core route supersedes the older Advanced ownership, and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 10 on India's evolving relations with the Central Asian Republics, a Critically analyse demand of 10 marks and 150 words; one objective demand is also routed here and carried as a coverage requirement only, namely 2025 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 62 on International North-South Transport Corridor connectivity, for which the official Set-A key is present locally while no option or answer letter is recorded or inferred; the locally held OCR-searchable official papers were read only to confirm printed wording and no question, key or marking scheme was imported from them. B. This topic owns the five Central Asian Republics, the Connect Central Asia Policy, the India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue mechanisms, India's Central Asian use of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the connectivity instruments of the International North-South Transport Corridor, Chabahar port and the Ashgabat Agreement, the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation and the New Great Game framing, and its distinctive feature is that its examinable spine is a constraint rather than an opportunity, because two verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2018 and 2024 and one objective demand from 2025 are routed here; the full institutional profile of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation belongs to topic 10, the India-China strategic relationship belongs to topic 03, the West Asian and energy-security limb of Chabahar belongs to topic 06, physical and route geography belongs to the Geography owner, and Soviet-era regional chronology with the nineteenth-century Great Game belongs to the World History owner. C. The maritime-linked work-around through Iran bypasses the Pakistan land constraint but substitutes one set of external dependencies, namely Iran-linked geopolitics and sanctions risk, for another, so no unilateral connectivity solution exists and the dependency problem is managed rather than removed; the owners pair this with the timeline warning that announcements outrun delivery in this sector, which together give the honest verdict that India's Central Asia problem is not an absence of interest but the conversion of diplomatic goodwill into reliable access across contested transit space. D. Sikri frames Central Asia as a geographical area that abuts on the borders of major powers in Asia and will always attract foreign presences, which describes ongoing great-power competition for influence rather than any Indian ability to determine regional outcomes, and the owners add that Russia's and China's greater historical and geographic proximity constrains how much relative influence India can realistically build however effective its own diplomacy; the examinable consequence is that outcomes in this region are co-determined by Russian, Chinese and Western engagement, so an answer must place India's effort inside a competitive field rather than presenting it as the decisive variable.

Answer: D. Explanation: Sikri frames Central Asia as a geographical area that abuts on the borders of major powers in Asia and will always attract foreign presences, which describes ongoing great-power competition for influence rather than any Indian ability to determine regional outcomes, and the owners add that Russia's and China's greater historical and geographic proximity constrains how much relative influence India can realistically build however effective its own diplomacy; the examinable consequence is that outcomes in this region are co-determined by Russian, Chinese and Western engagement, so an answer must place India's

effort inside a competitive field rather than presenting it as the decisive variable. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q61. Which statement correctly identifies Membership without privileged access?

A. India's full membership of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation provides a seat and a platform but not privileged influence, because the same forum includes China, Russia and Pakistan, so its outputs reflect compromise among competing major-power interests rather than an India-centred agenda, and Pakistan's own membership means the forum cannot itself resolve the transit-access problem; the owners therefore separate two claims that answers routinely merge, namely that membership sustains political, security and economic engagement, and that membership does not by itself create physical connectivity, which depends on separate corridor projects. B. Afghanistan sits at the centre of the connectivity problem because it is the potential land-bridge to Central Asia while being itself a source of instability that currently forecloses that option, and the owners record this as a genuine unresolved tension rather than a solved problem; the consequence for answer writing is that Afghanistan cannot be treated either as a ready corridor or as an irrelevant space, and any recommendation must be calibrated to a situation in which the shortest route is the least available one. C. The maritime-linked work-around through Iran bypasses the Pakistan land constraint but substitutes one set of external dependencies, namely Iran-linked geopolitics and sanctions risk, for another, so no unilateral connectivity solution exists and the dependency problem is managed rather than removed; the owners pair this with the timeline warning that announcements outrun delivery in this sector, which together give the honest verdict that India's Central Asia problem is not an absence of interest but the conversion of diplomatic goodwill into reliable access across contested transit space. D. Sikri argues that India must try to develop an understanding on energy with China because both are major energy consumers often seeking energy from the same sources and their competition is only benefiting the energy producers, which the owners treat as a rare explicit call for cooperative management of a shared dependency despite broader strategic mistrust; the analytical value of this anchor is that it shows competition and cooperation coexisting on a specific functional issue, so a critical answer can avoid the crude choice between pure rivalry and naive partnership.

Answer: A. Explanation: India's full membership of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation provides a seat and a platform but not privileged influence, because the same forum includes China, Russia and Pakistan, so its outputs reflect compromise among competing major-power interests rather than an India-centred agenda, and Pakistan's own membership means the forum cannot itself resolve the transit-access problem; the owners therefore separate two claims that answers routinely merge, namely that membership sustains political, security and economic engagement, and that membership does not by itself create physical connectivity, which depends on separate corridor projects. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q62. Which card should be filed under Membership without privileged access in an International Relations answer?

A. The maritime-linked work-around through Iran bypasses the Pakistan land constraint but substitutes one set of external dependencies, namely Iran-linked geopolitics and sanctions risk, for another, so no unilateral connectivity solution exists and the dependency problem is managed rather than removed; the owners pair this with the timeline warning that announcements outrun delivery in this sector, which together give the honest verdict that India's Central Asia problem is not an absence of interest but the conversion of diplomatic goodwill into reliable access across contested transit space. B. India's full membership of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation provides a seat and a platform but not privileged influence, because the same forum includes China, Russia and Pakistan, so its outputs reflect compromise among competing major-power interests rather than an India-centred agenda, and Pakistan's own membership means the forum cannot itself resolve the transit-access problem; the owners therefore separate two claims that answers routinely merge, namely that membership sustains political, security and economic engagement, and that membership does not by itself create physical connectivity, which depends on separate corridor projects. C. Afghanistan sits at the centre of the connectivity problem because it is the potential land-bridge to Central Asia while being itself a source of instability that currently forecloses that option, and the owners record this as a genuine unresolved tension rather than a solved problem; the consequence for answer writing is that Afghanistan cannot be treated either as a ready corridor or as an irrelevant space, and any recommendation must be calibrated to a situation in which the shortest route is the least available one. D. The audited ledgers route two General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, namely 2018 General Studies Paper II question 10 on outside powers in Central Asia and

India joining the Ashgabat Agreement, a Discuss the implications demand of 10 marks and 150 words for which the ledger records that the printed word-limit tail was corrupted in the scan and that the Core route supersedes the older Advanced ownership, and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 10 on India's evolving relations with the Central Asian Republics, a Critically analyse demand of 10 marks and 150 words; one objective demand is also routed here and carried as a coverage requirement only, namely 2025 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 62 on International North-South Transport Corridor connectivity, for which the official Set-A key is present locally while no option or answer letter is recorded or inferred; the locally held OCR-searchable official papers were read only to confirm printed wording and no question, key or marking scheme was imported from them.

Answer: B. Explanation: India's full membership of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation provides a seat and a platform but not privileged influence, because the same forum includes China, Russia and Pakistan, so its outputs reflect compromise among competing major-power interests rather than an India-centred agenda, and Pakistan's own membership means the forum cannot itself resolve the transit-access problem; the owners therefore separate two claims that answers routinely merge, namely that membership sustains political, security and economic engagement, and that membership does not by itself create physical connectivity, which depends on separate corridor projects. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q63. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Membership without privileged access?

A. The audited ledgers route two General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, namely 2018 General Studies Paper II question 10 on outside powers in Central Asia and India joining the Ashgabat Agreement, a Discuss the implications demand of 10 marks and 150 words for which the ledger records that the printed word-limit tail was corrupted in the scan and that the Core route supersedes the older Advanced ownership, and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 10 on India's evolving relations with the Central Asian Republics, a Critically analyse demand of 10 marks and 150 words; one objective demand is also routed here and carried as a coverage requirement only, namely 2025 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 62 on International North-South Transport Corridor connectivity, for which the official Set-A key is present locally while no option or answer letter is recorded or inferred; the locally held OCR-searchable official papers were read only to confirm printed wording and no question, key or marking scheme was imported from them. B. The maritime-linked work-around through Iran bypasses the Pakistan land constraint but substitutes one set of external dependencies, namely Iran-linked geopolitics and sanctions risk, for another, so no unilateral connectivity solution exists and the dependency problem is managed rather than removed; the owners pair this with the timeline warning that announcements outrun delivery in this sector, which together give the honest verdict that India's Central Asia problem is not an absence of interest but the conversion of diplomatic goodwill into reliable access across contested transit space. C. India's full membership of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation provides a seat and a platform but not privileged influence, because the same forum includes China, Russia and Pakistan, so its outputs reflect compromise among competing major-power interests rather than an India-centred agenda, and Pakistan's own membership means the forum cannot itself resolve the transit-access problem; the owners therefore separate two claims that answers routinely merge, namely that membership sustains political, security and economic engagement, and that membership does not by itself create physical connectivity, which depends on separate corridor projects. D. This topic owns the five Central Asian Republics, the Connect Central Asia Policy, the India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue mechanisms, India's Central Asian use of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the connectivity instruments of the International North-South Transport Corridor, Chabahar port and the Ashgabat Agreement, the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation and the New Great Game framing, and its distinctive feature is that its examinable spine is a constraint rather than an opportunity, because two verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2018 and 2024 and one objective demand from 2025 are routed here; the full institutional profile of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation belongs to topic 10, the India-China strategic relationship belongs to topic 03, the West Asian and energy-security limb of Chabahar belongs to topic 06, physical and route geography belongs to the Geography owner, and Soviet-era regional chronology with the nineteenth-century Great Game belongs to the World History owner.

Answer: C. Explanation: India's full membership of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation provides a seat and a platform but not privileged influence, because the same forum includes China, Russia and Pakistan, so its outputs reflect compromise among competing major-power interests rather than an India-centred agenda, and Pakistan's own membership means the forum cannot itself resolve the transit-access problem; the

owners therefore separate two claims that answers routinely merge, namely that membership sustains political, security and economic engagement, and that membership does not by itself create physical connectivity, which depends on separate corridor projects. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q64. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Membership without privileged access?

A. The audited ledgers route two General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, namely 2018 General Studies Paper II question 10 on outside powers in Central Asia and India joining the Ashgabat Agreement, a Discuss the implications demand of 10 marks and 150 words for which the ledger records that the printed word-limit tail was corrupted in the scan and that the Core route supersedes the older Advanced ownership, and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 10 on India's evolving relations with the Central Asian Republics, a Critically analyse demand of 10 marks and 150 words; one objective demand is also routed here and carried as a coverage requirement only, namely 2025 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 62 on International North-South Transport Corridor connectivity, for which the official Set-A key is present locally while no option or answer letter is recorded or inferred; the locally held OCR-searchable official papers were read only to confirm printed wording and no question, key or marking scheme was imported from them. B. The five Central Asian Republics are Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan, and the Connect Central Asia Policy launched in 2012 aims at strengthening and expanding India's relations with those countries through a broad-based approach including political, security, economic and cultural connections; the owners insist on the word broad-based because reducing the policy to energy alone misdescribes its declared scope, and they treat the 2012 launch as the foundational Indian policy approach against which every later mechanism in this topic is measured. C. This topic owns the five Central Asian Republics, the Connect Central Asia Policy, the India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue mechanisms, India's Central Asian use of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the connectivity instruments of the International North-South Transport Corridor, Chabahar port and the Ashgabat Agreement, the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation and the New Great Game framing, and its distinctive feature is that its examinable spine is a constraint rather than an opportunity, because two verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2018 and 2024 and one objective demand from 2025 are routed here; the full institutional profile of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation belongs to topic 10, the India-China strategic relationship belongs to topic 03, the West Asian and energy-security limb of Chabahar belongs to topic 06, physical and route geography belongs to the Geography owner, and Soviet-era regional chronology with the nineteenth-century Great Game belongs to the World History owner. D. India's full membership of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation provides a seat and a platform but not privileged influence, because the same forum includes China, Russia and Pakistan, so its outputs reflect compromise among competing major-power interests rather than an India-centred agenda, and Pakistan's own membership means the forum cannot itself resolve the transit-access problem; the owners therefore separate two claims that answers routinely merge, namely that membership sustains political, security and economic engagement, and that membership does not by itself create physical connectivity, which depends on separate corridor projects.

Answer: D. Explanation: India's full membership of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation provides a seat and a platform but not privileged influence, because the same forum includes China, Russia and Pakistan, so its outputs reflect compromise among competing major-power interests rather than an India-centred agenda, and Pakistan's own membership means the forum cannot itself resolve the transit-access problem; the owners therefore separate two claims that answers routinely merge, namely that membership sustains political, security and economic engagement, and that membership does not by itself create physical connectivity, which depends on separate corridor projects. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q65. Which statement correctly identifies Cooperative management of a shared external dependency?

A. Sikri argues that India must try to develop an understanding on energy with China because both are major energy consumers often seeking energy from the same sources and their competition is only benefiting the energy producers, which the owners treat as a rare explicit call for cooperative management of a shared dependency despite broader strategic mistrust; the analytical value of this anchor is that it shows competition and cooperation coexisting on a specific functional issue, so a critical answer can avoid the crude choice between pure rivalry and naive partnership.

B. The audited ledgers route two General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, namely 2018 General Studies Paper II question 10 on outside powers in Central Asia and India joining the Ashgabat Agreement, a Discuss the implications demand of 10 marks and 150 words for which the ledger records that the printed word-limit tail was corrupted in the scan and that the Core route supersedes the older Advanced ownership, and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 10 on India's evolving relations with the Central Asian Republics, a Critically analyse demand of 10 marks and 150 words; one objective demand is also routed here and carried as a coverage requirement only, namely 2025 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 62 on International North-South Transport Corridor connectivity, for which the official Set-A key is present locally while no option or answer letter is recorded or inferred; the locally held OCR-searchable official papers were read only to confirm printed wording and no question, key or marking scheme was imported from them.

C. The maritime-linked work-around through Iran bypasses the Pakistan land constraint but substitutes one set of external dependencies, namely Iran-linked geopolitics and sanctions risk, for another, so no unilateral connectivity solution exists and the dependency problem is managed rather than removed; the owners pair this with the timeline warning that announcements outrun delivery in this sector, which together give the honest verdict that India's Central Asia problem is not an absence of interest but the conversion of diplomatic goodwill into reliable access across contested transit space.

D. Afghanistan sits at the centre of the connectivity problem because it is the potential land-bridge to Central Asia while being itself a source of instability that currently forecloses that option, and the owners record this as a genuine unresolved tension rather than a solved problem; the consequence for answer writing is that Afghanistan cannot be treated either as a ready corridor or as an irrelevant space, and any recommendation must be calibrated to a situation in which the shortest route is the least available one.

Answer: A. Explanation: Sikri argues that India must try to develop an understanding on energy with China because both are major energy consumers often seeking energy from the same sources and their competition is only benefiting the energy producers, which the owners treat as a rare explicit call for cooperative management of a shared dependency despite broader strategic mistrust; the analytical value of this anchor is that it shows competition and cooperation coexisting on a specific functional issue, so a critical answer can avoid the crude choice between pure rivalry and naive partnership. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q66. Which card should be filed under Cooperative management of a shared external dependency in an International Relations answer?

A. This topic owns the five Central Asian Republics, the Connect Central Asia Policy, the India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue mechanisms, India's Central Asian use of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the connectivity instruments of the International North-South Transport Corridor, Chabahar port and the Ashgabat Agreement, the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation and the New Great Game framing, and its distinctive feature is that its examinable spine is a constraint rather than an opportunity, because two verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2018 and 2024 and one objective demand from 2025 are routed here; the full institutional profile of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation belongs to topic 10, the India-China strategic relationship belongs to topic 03, the West Asian and energy-security limb of Chabahar belongs to topic 06, physical and route geography belongs to the Geography owner, and Soviet-era regional chronology with the nineteenth-century Great Game belongs to the World History owner.

B. Sikri argues that India must try to develop an understanding on energy with China because both are major energy consumers often seeking energy from the same sources and their competition is only benefiting the energy producers, which the owners treat as a rare explicit call for cooperative management of a shared dependency despite broader strategic mistrust; the analytical value of this anchor is that it shows competition and cooperation coexisting on a specific functional issue, so a critical answer can avoid the crude choice between pure rivalry and naive partnership.

C. The maritime-linked work-around through Iran bypasses the Pakistan land constraint but substitutes one set of external dependencies, namely Iran-linked geopolitics and sanctions risk, for another, so no unilateral connectivity solution exists and the dependency problem is managed rather than removed; the owners pair

this with the timeline warning that announcements outrun delivery in this sector, which together give the honest verdict that India's Central Asia problem is not an absence of interest but the conversion of diplomatic goodwill into reliable access across contested transit space. D. The audited ledgers route two General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, namely 2018 General Studies Paper II question 10 on outside powers in Central Asia and India joining the Ashgabat Agreement, a Discuss the implications demand of 10 marks and 150 words for which the ledger records that the printed word-limit tail was corrupted in the scan and that the Core route supersedes the older Advanced ownership, and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 10 on India's evolving relations with the Central Asian Republics, a Critically analyse demand of 10 marks and 150 words; one objective demand is also routed here and carried as a coverage requirement only, namely 2025 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 62 on International North-South Transport Corridor connectivity, for which the official Set-A key is present locally while no option or answer letter is recorded or inferred; the locally held OCR-searchable official papers were read only to confirm printed wording and no question, key or marking scheme was imported from them.

Answer: B. Explanation: Sikri argues that India must try to develop an understanding on energy with China because both are major energy consumers often seeking energy from the same sources and their competition is only benefiting the energy producers, which the owners treat as a rare explicit call for cooperative management of a shared dependency despite broader strategic mistrust; the analytical value of this anchor is that it shows competition and cooperation coexisting on a specific functional issue, so a critical answer can avoid the crude choice between pure rivalry and naive partnership. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q67. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Cooperative management of a shared external dependency?

A. This topic owns the five Central Asian Republics, the Connect Central Asia Policy, the India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue mechanisms, India's Central Asian use of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the connectivity instruments of the International North-South Transport Corridor, Chabahar port and the Ashgabat Agreement, the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation and the New Great Game framing, and its distinctive feature is that its examinable spine is a constraint rather than an opportunity, because two verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2018 and 2024 and one objective demand from 2025 are routed here; the full institutional profile of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation belongs to topic 10, the India-China strategic relationship belongs to topic 03, the West Asian and energy-security limb of Chabahar belongs to topic 06, physical and route geography belongs to the Geography owner, and Soviet-era regional chronology with the nineteenth-century Great Game belongs to the World History owner. B. The audited ledgers route two General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, namely 2018 General Studies Paper II question 10 on outside powers in Central Asia and India joining the Ashgabat Agreement, a Discuss the implications demand of 10 marks and 150 words for which the ledger records that the printed word-limit tail was corrupted in the scan and that the Core route supersedes the older Advanced ownership, and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 10 on India's evolving relations with the Central Asian Republics, a Critically analyse demand of 10 marks and 150 words; one objective demand is also routed here and carried as a coverage requirement only, namely 2025 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 62 on International North-South Transport Corridor connectivity, for which the official Set-A key is present locally while no option or answer letter is recorded or inferred; the locally held OCR-searchable official papers were read only to confirm printed wording and no question, key or marking scheme was imported from them. C. Sikri argues that India must try to develop an understanding on energy with China because both are major energy consumers often seeking energy from the same sources and their competition is only benefiting the energy producers, which the owners treat as a rare explicit call for cooperative management of a shared dependency despite broader strategic mistrust; the analytical value of this anchor is that it shows competition and cooperation coexisting on a specific functional issue, so a critical answer can avoid the crude choice between pure rivalry and naive partnership. D. The five Central Asian Republics are Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan, and the Connect Central Asia Policy launched in 2012 aims at strengthening and expanding India's relations with those countries through a broad-based approach including political, security, economic and cultural connections; the owners insist on the word broad-based because reducing the policy to energy alone misdescribes its declared scope, and they treat the 2012 launch as the foundational Indian policy approach against which every later mechanism in this topic is measured.

Answer: C. Explanation: Sikri argues that India must try to develop an understanding on energy with China because both are major energy consumers often seeking energy from the same sources and their

competition is only benefiting the energy producers, which the owners treat as a rare explicit call for cooperative management of a shared dependency despite broader strategic mistrust; the analytical value of this anchor is that it shows competition and cooperation coexisting on a specific functional issue, so a critical answer can avoid the crude choice between pure rivalry and naive partnership. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q68. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Cooperative management of a shared external dependency?

A. The five Central Asian Republics are Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan, and the Connect Central Asia Policy launched in 2012 aims at strengthening and expanding India's relations with those countries through a broad-based approach including political, security, economic and cultural connections; the owners insist on the word broad-based because reducing the policy to energy alone misdescribes its declared scope, and they treat the 2012 launch as the foundational Indian policy approach against which every later mechanism in this topic is measured. B. India engages Central Asia partly through existing fora described in the sources as the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the Eurasian Economic Community and the Custom Union, and it has proposed a Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement to integrate its markets with the Eurasian space; the examinable discipline is that a proposal is an instrument of intent rather than an operating arrangement, so an answer must name the proposal by its exact title and then trace what actually happened to it rather than implying that market integration has already occurred. C. This topic owns the five Central Asian Republics, the Connect Central Asia Policy, the India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue mechanisms, India's Central Asian use of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the connectivity instruments of the International North-South Transport Corridor, Chabahar port and the Ashgabat Agreement, the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation and the New Great Game framing, and its distinctive feature is that its examinable spine is a constraint rather than an opportunity, because two verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2018 and 2024 and one objective demand from 2025 are routed here; the full institutional profile of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation belongs to topic 10, the India-China strategic relationship belongs to topic 03, the West Asian and energy-security limb of Chabahar belongs to topic 06, physical and route geography belongs to the Geography owner, and Soviet-era regional chronology with the nineteenth-century Great Game belongs to the World History owner. D. Sikri argues that India must try to develop an understanding on energy with China because both are major energy consumers often seeking energy from the same sources and their competition is only benefiting the energy producers, which the owners treat as a rare explicit call for cooperative management of a shared dependency despite broader strategic mistrust; the analytical value of this anchor is that it shows competition and cooperation coexisting on a specific functional issue, so a critical answer can avoid the crude choice between pure rivalry and naive partnership.

Answer: D. Explanation: Sikri argues that India must try to develop an understanding on energy with China because both are major energy consumers often seeking energy from the same sources and their competition is only benefiting the energy producers, which the owners treat as a rare explicit call for cooperative management of a shared dependency despite broader strategic mistrust; the analytical value of this anchor is that it shows competition and cooperation coexisting on a specific functional issue, so a critical answer can avoid the crude choice between pure rivalry and naive partnership. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q69. Which statement correctly identifies Afghanistan as simultaneously the bridge and the barrier?

A. Afghanistan sits at the centre of the connectivity problem because it is the potential land-bridge to Central Asia while being itself a source of instability that currently forecloses that option, and the owners record this as a genuine unresolved tension rather than a solved problem; the consequence for answer writing is that Afghanistan cannot be treated either as a ready corridor or as an irrelevant space, and any recommendation must be calibrated to a situation in which the shortest route is the least available one. B. The maritime-linked work-around through Iran bypasses the Pakistan land constraint but substitutes one set of external dependencies, namely Iran-linked geopolitics and sanctions risk, for another, so no unilateral connectivity solution exists and the dependency problem is managed rather than removed; the owners pair this with the timeline warning that announcements outrun delivery in this sector, which together give the honest verdict that India's Central Asia problem is not an absence of interest but the conversion of diplomatic goodwill into reliable access across contested transit space. C. The audited ledgers route two

General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, namely 2018 General Studies Paper II question 10 on outside powers in Central Asia and India joining the Ashgabat Agreement, a Discuss the implications demand of 10 marks and 150 words for which the ledger records that the printed word-limit tail was corrupted in the scan and that the Core route supersedes the older Advanced ownership, and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 10 on India's evolving relations with the Central Asian Republics, a Critically analyse demand of 10 marks and 150 words; one objective demand is also routed here and carried as a coverage requirement only, namely 2025 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 62 on International North-South Transport Corridor connectivity, for which the official Set-A key is present locally while no option or answer letter is recorded or inferred; the locally held OCR-searchable official papers were read only to confirm printed wording and no question, key or marking scheme was imported from them. D. This topic owns the five Central Asian Republics, the Connect Central Asia Policy, the India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue mechanisms, India's Central Asian use of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the connectivity instruments of the International North-South Transport Corridor, Chabahar port and the Ashgabat Agreement, the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation and the New Great Game framing, and its distinctive feature is that its examinable spine is a constraint rather than an opportunity, because two verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2018 and 2024 and one objective demand from 2025 are routed here; the full institutional profile of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation belongs to topic 10, the India-China strategic relationship belongs to topic 03, the West Asian and energy-security limb of Chabahar belongs to topic 06, physical and route geography belongs to the Geography owner, and Soviet-era regional chronology with the nineteenth-century Great Game belongs to the World History owner.

Answer: A. Explanation: Afghanistan sits at the centre of the connectivity problem because it is the potential land-bridge to Central Asia while being itself a source of instability that currently forecloses that option, and the owners record this as a genuine unresolved tension rather than a solved problem; the consequence for answer writing is that Afghanistan cannot be treated either as a ready corridor or as an irrelevant space, and any recommendation must be calibrated to a situation in which the shortest route is the least available one. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q70. Which card should be filed under Afghanistan as simultaneously the bridge and the barrier in an International Relations answer?

A. This topic owns the five Central Asian Republics, the Connect Central Asia Policy, the India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue mechanisms, India's Central Asian use of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the connectivity instruments of the International North-South Transport Corridor, Chabahar port and the Ashgabat Agreement, the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation and the New Great Game framing, and its distinctive feature is that its examinable spine is a constraint rather than an opportunity, because two verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2018 and 2024 and one objective demand from 2025 are routed here; the full institutional profile of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation belongs to topic 10, the India-China strategic relationship belongs to topic 03, the West Asian and energy-security limb of Chabahar belongs to topic 06, physical and route geography belongs to the Geography owner, and Soviet-era regional chronology with the nineteenth-century Great Game belongs to the World History owner. B. Afghanistan sits at the centre of the connectivity problem because it is the potential land-bridge to Central Asia while being itself a source of instability that currently forecloses that option, and the owners record this as a genuine unresolved tension rather than a solved problem; the consequence for answer writing is that Afghanistan cannot be treated either as a ready corridor or as an irrelevant space, and any recommendation must be calibrated to a situation in which the shortest route is the least available one. C. The audited ledgers route two General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, namely 2018 General Studies Paper II question 10 on outside powers in Central Asia and India joining the Ashgabat Agreement, a Discuss the implications demand of 10 marks and 150 words for which the ledger records that the printed word-limit tail was corrupted in the scan and that the Core route supersedes the older Advanced ownership, and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 10 on India's evolving relations with the Central Asian Republics, a Critically analyse demand of 10 marks and 150 words; one objective demand is also routed here and carried as a coverage requirement only, namely 2025 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 62 on International North-South Transport Corridor connectivity, for which the official Set-A key is present locally while no option or answer letter is recorded or inferred; the locally held OCR-searchable official papers were read only to confirm printed wording and no question, key or marking scheme was imported from them. D. The five Central Asian Republics are Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan, and the Connect Central Asia Policy launched in 2012 aims at strengthening and expanding India's relations with those countries

through a broad-based approach including political, security, economic and cultural connections; the owners insist on the word broad-based because reducing the policy to energy alone misdescribes its declared scope, and they treat the 2012 launch as the foundational Indian policy approach against which every later mechanism in this topic is measured.

Answer: B. Explanation: Afghanistan sits at the centre of the connectivity problem because it is the potential land-bridge to Central Asia while being itself a source of instability that currently forecloses that option, and the owners record this as a genuine unresolved tension rather than a solved problem; the consequence for answer writing is that Afghanistan cannot be treated either as a ready corridor or as an irrelevant space, and any recommendation must be calibrated to a situation in which the shortest route is the least available one. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q71. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Afghanistan as simultaneously the bridge and the barrier?

A. India engages Central Asia partly through existing fora described in the sources as the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the Eurasian Economic Community and the Custom Union, and it has proposed a Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement to integrate its markets with the Eurasian space; the examinable discipline is that a proposal is an instrument of intent rather than an operating arrangement, so an answer must name the proposal by its exact title and then trace what actually happened to it rather than implying that market integration has already occurred. B. This topic owns the five Central Asian Republics, the Connect Central Asia Policy, the India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue mechanisms, India's Central Asian use of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the connectivity instruments of the International North-South Transport Corridor, Chabahar port and the Ashgabat Agreement, the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation and the New Great Game framing, and its distinctive feature is that its examinable spine is a constraint rather than an opportunity, because two verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2018 and 2024 and one objective demand from 2025 are routed here; the full institutional profile of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation belongs to topic 10, the India-China strategic relationship belongs to topic 03, the West Asian and energy-security limb of Chabahar belongs to topic 06, physical and route geography belongs to the Geography owner, and Soviet-era regional chronology with the nineteenth-century Great Game belongs to the World History owner. C. Afghanistan sits at the centre of the connectivity problem because it is the potential land-bridge to Central Asia while being itself a source of instability that currently forecloses that option, and the owners record this as a genuine unresolved tension rather than a solved problem; the consequence for answer writing is that Afghanistan cannot be treated either as a ready corridor or as an irrelevant space, and any recommendation must be calibrated to a situation in which the shortest route is the least available one. D. The five Central Asian Republics are Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan, and the Connect Central Asia Policy launched in 2012 aims at strengthening and expanding India's relations with those countries through a broad-based approach including political, security, economic and cultural connections; the owners insist on the word broad-based because reducing the policy to energy alone misdescribes its declared scope, and they treat the 2012 launch as the foundational Indian policy approach against which every later mechanism in this topic is measured.

Answer: C. Explanation: Afghanistan sits at the centre of the connectivity problem because it is the potential land-bridge to Central Asia while being itself a source of instability that currently forecloses that option, and the owners record this as a genuine unresolved tension rather than a solved problem; the consequence for answer writing is that Afghanistan cannot be treated either as a ready corridor or as an irrelevant space, and any recommendation must be calibrated to a situation in which the shortest route is the least available one. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q72. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Afghanistan as simultaneously the bridge and the barrier?

A. The five Central Asian Republics are Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan, and the Connect Central Asia Policy launched in 2012 aims at strengthening and expanding India's relations with those countries through a broad-based approach including political, security, economic and cultural connections; the owners insist on the word broad-based because reducing the policy to energy alone misdescribes its declared scope, and they treat the 2012 launch as the foundational Indian policy approach against which every later mechanism in this topic is measured. B. The proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement is now pursued as the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation, which formally began on 3 June 2017 at St Petersburg and remained under negotiation, with the second round held in Moscow on 22-25 June 2026; the owners fix the status precisely as under negotiation and neither signed nor in force, so an answer may cite the dated rounds as evidence of sustained economic engagement and may never assert conclusion, signature or entry into force. C. India engages Central Asia partly through existing fora described in the sources as the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the Eurasian Economic Community and the Custom Union, and it has proposed a Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement to integrate its markets with the Eurasian space; the examinable discipline is that a proposal is an instrument of intent rather than an operating arrangement, so an answer must name the proposal by its exact title and then trace what actually happened to it rather than implying that market integration has already occurred. D. Afghanistan sits at the centre of the connectivity problem because it is the potential land-bridge to Central Asia while being itself a source of instability that currently forecloses that option, and the owners record this as a genuine unresolved tension rather than a solved problem; the consequence for answer writing is that Afghanistan cannot be treated either as a ready corridor or as an irrelevant space, and any recommendation must be calibrated to a situation in which the shortest route is the least available one.

Answer: D. Explanation: Afghanistan sits at the centre of the connectivity problem because it is the potential land-bridge to Central Asia while being itself a source of instability that currently forecloses that option, and the owners record this as a genuine unresolved tension rather than a solved problem; the consequence for answer writing is that Afghanistan cannot be treated either as a ready corridor or as an irrelevant space, and any recommendation must be calibrated to a situation in which the shortest route is the least available one. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q73. Which statement correctly identifies Substituted dependency rather than eliminated dependency?

A. The maritime-linked work-around through Iran bypasses the Pakistan land constraint but substitutes one set of external dependencies, namely Iran-linked geopolitics and sanctions risk, for another, so no unilateral connectivity solution exists and the dependency problem is managed rather than removed; the owners pair this with the timeline warning that announcements outrun delivery in this sector, which together give the honest verdict that India's Central Asia problem is not an absence of interest but the conversion of diplomatic goodwill into reliable access across contested transit space. B. The five Central Asian Republics are Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan, and the Connect Central Asia Policy launched in 2012 aims at strengthening and expanding India's relations with those countries through a broad-based approach including political, security, economic and cultural connections; the owners insist on the word broad-based because reducing the policy to energy alone misdescribes its declared scope, and they treat the 2012 launch as the foundational Indian policy approach against which every later mechanism in this topic is measured. C. The audited ledgers route two General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, namely 2018 General Studies Paper II question 10 on outside powers in Central Asia and India joining the Ashgabat Agreement, a Discuss the implications demand of 10 marks and 150 words for which the ledger records that the printed word-limit tail was corrupted in the scan and that the Core route supersedes the older Advanced ownership, and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 10 on India's evolving relations with the Central Asian Republics, a Critically analyse demand of 10 marks and 150 words; one objective demand is also routed here and carried as a coverage requirement only, namely 2025 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 62 on International North-South Transport Corridor connectivity, for which the official Set-A key is present locally while no option or answer letter is recorded or inferred; the locally held OCR-searchable official papers were read only to confirm printed wording and no question, key or marking scheme was imported from them. D. This topic owns the five Central Asian Republics, the Connect Central Asia Policy, the India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue mechanisms, India's Central Asian use of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the connectivity instruments of the International North-South

Transport Corridor, Chabahar port and the Ashgabat Agreement, the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation and the New Great Game framing, and its distinctive feature is that its examinable spine is a constraint rather than an opportunity, because two verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2018 and 2024 and one objective demand from 2025 are routed here; the full institutional profile of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation belongs to topic 10, the India-China strategic relationship belongs to topic 03, the West Asian and energy-security limb of Chabahar belongs to topic 06, physical and route geography belongs to the Geography owner, and Soviet-era regional chronology with the nineteenth-century Great Game belongs to the World History owner.

Answer: A. Explanation: The maritime-linked work-around through Iran bypasses the Pakistan land constraint but substitutes one set of external dependencies, namely Iran-linked geopolitics and sanctions risk, for another, so no unilateral connectivity solution exists and the dependency problem is managed rather than removed; the owners pair this with the timeline warning that announcements outrun delivery in this sector, which together give the honest verdict that India's Central Asia problem is not an absence of interest but the conversion of diplomatic goodwill into reliable access across contested transit space. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q74. Which card should be filed under Substituted dependency rather than eliminated dependency in an International Relations answer?

A. The five Central Asian Republics are Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan, and the Connect Central Asia Policy launched in 2012 aims at strengthening and expanding India's relations with those countries through a broad-based approach including political, security, economic and cultural connections; the owners insist on the word broad-based because reducing the policy to energy alone misdescribes its declared scope, and they treat the 2012 launch as the foundational Indian policy approach against which every later mechanism in this topic is measured. B. The maritime-linked work-around through Iran bypasses the Pakistan land constraint but substitutes one set of external dependencies, namely Iran-linked geopolitics and sanctions risk, for another, so no unilateral connectivity solution exists and the dependency problem is managed rather than removed; the owners pair this with the timeline warning that announcements outrun delivery in this sector, which together give the honest verdict that India's Central Asia problem is not an absence of interest but the conversion of diplomatic goodwill into reliable access across contested transit space. C. India engages Central Asia partly through existing fora described in the sources as the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the Eurasian Economic Community and the Custom Union, and it has proposed a Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement to integrate its markets with the Eurasian space; the examinable discipline is that a proposal is an instrument of intent rather than an operating arrangement, so an answer must name the proposal by its exact title and then trace what actually happened to it rather than implying that market integration has already occurred. D. This topic owns the five Central Asian Republics, the Connect Central Asia Policy, the India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue mechanisms, India's Central Asian use of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the connectivity instruments of the International North-South Transport Corridor, Chabahar port and the Ashgabat Agreement, the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation and the New Great Game framing, and its distinctive feature is that its examinable spine is a constraint rather than an opportunity, because two verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2018 and 2024 and one objective demand from 2025 are routed here; the full institutional profile of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation belongs to topic 10, the India-China strategic relationship belongs to topic 03, the West Asian and energy-security limb of Chabahar belongs to topic 06, physical and route geography belongs to the Geography owner, and Soviet-era regional chronology with the nineteenth-century Great Game belongs to the World History owner.

Answer: B. Explanation: The maritime-linked work-around through Iran bypasses the Pakistan land constraint but substitutes one set of external dependencies, namely Iran-linked geopolitics and sanctions risk, for another, so no unilateral connectivity solution exists and the dependency problem is managed rather than removed; the owners pair this with the timeline warning that announcements outrun delivery in this sector, which together give the honest verdict that India's Central Asia problem is not an absence of interest but the conversion of diplomatic goodwill into reliable access across contested transit space. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q75. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Substituted dependency rather than eliminated dependency?

A. India engages Central Asia partly through existing fora described in the sources as the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the Eurasian Economic Community and the Custom Union, and it has proposed a Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement to integrate its markets with the Eurasian space; the examinable discipline is that a proposal is an instrument of intent rather than an operating arrangement, so an answer must name the proposal by its exact title and then trace what actually happened to it rather than implying that market integration has already occurred. B. The proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement is now pursued as the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation, which formally began on 3 June 2017 at St Petersburg and remained under negotiation, with the second round held in Moscow on 22-25 June 2026; the owners fix the status precisely as under negotiation and neither signed nor in force, so an answer may cite the dated rounds as evidence of sustained economic engagement and may never assert conclusion, signature or entry into force. C. The maritime-linked work-around through Iran bypasses the Pakistan land constraint but substitutes one set of external dependencies, namely Iran-linked geopolitics and sanctions risk, for another, so no unilateral connectivity solution exists and the dependency problem is managed rather than removed; the owners pair this with the timeline warning that announcements outrun delivery in this sector, which together give the honest verdict that India's Central Asia problem is not an absence of interest but the conversion of diplomatic goodwill into reliable access across contested transit space. D. The five Central Asian Republics are Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan, and the Connect Central Asia Policy launched in 2012 aims at strengthening and expanding India's relations with those countries through a broad-based approach including political, security, economic and cultural connections; the owners insist on the word broad-based because reducing the policy to energy alone misdescribes its declared scope, and they treat the 2012 launch as the foundational Indian policy approach against which every later mechanism in this topic is measured.

Answer: C. Explanation: The maritime-linked work-around through Iran bypasses the Pakistan land constraint but substitutes one set of external dependencies, namely Iran-linked geopolitics and sanctions risk, for another, so no unilateral connectivity solution exists and the dependency problem is managed rather than removed; the owners pair this with the timeline warning that announcements outrun delivery in this sector, which together give the honest verdict that India's Central Asia problem is not an absence of interest but the conversion of diplomatic goodwill into reliable access across contested transit space. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q76. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Substituted dependency rather than eliminated dependency?

A. India engages Central Asia partly through existing fora described in the sources as the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the Eurasian Economic Community and the Custom Union, and it has proposed a Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement to integrate its markets with the Eurasian space; the examinable discipline is that a proposal is an instrument of intent rather than an operating arrangement, so an answer must name the proposal by its exact title and then trace what actually happened to it rather than implying that market integration has already occurred. B. The proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement is now pursued as the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation, which formally began on 3 June 2017 at St Petersburg and remained under negotiation, with the second round held in Moscow on 22-25 June 2026; the owners fix the status precisely as under negotiation and neither signed nor in force, so an answer may cite the dated rounds as evidence of sustained economic engagement and may never assert conclusion, signature or entry into force. C. India looks to Central Asia as a long-term partner in energy and natural resources, given the region's substantial hydrocarbon and mineral endowment, and this interest is what makes the connectivity question consequential rather than merely administrative; the owners keep the claim at the level of a stated policy interest and do not attach any volume, share, price or contract figure to it, because no such figure is carried by the sources and an invented number would convert a defensible interest claim into a fabricated one. D. The maritime-linked work-around through Iran bypasses the Pakistan land constraint but substitutes one set of external dependencies, namely Iran-linked geopolitics and sanctions risk, for another, so no unilateral connectivity solution exists and the dependency problem is managed rather than removed; the owners pair this with the timeline warning that announcements outrun delivery in this sector, which together give the honest verdict that India's Central Asia problem is not an absence of interest but the conversion of diplomatic goodwill into reliable access across contested transit space.

Answer: D. Explanation: The maritime-linked work-around through Iran bypasses the Pakistan land constraint but substitutes one set of external dependencies, namely Iran-linked geopolitics and sanctions risk, for another, so no unilateral connectivity solution exists and the dependency problem is managed rather than removed; the owners pair this with the timeline warning that announcements outrun delivery in this sector, which together give the honest verdict that India's Central Asia problem is not an absence of interest but the conversion of diplomatic goodwill into reliable access across contested transit space. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q77. Which statement correctly identifies Honest question ownership for this Eurasian owner?

A. The audited ledgers route two General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, namely 2018 General Studies Paper II question 10 on outside powers in Central Asia and India joining the Ashgabat Agreement, a Discuss the implications demand of 10 marks and 150 words for which the ledger records that the printed word-limit tail was corrupted in the scan and that the Core route supersedes the older Advanced ownership, and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 10 on India's evolving relations with the Central Asian Republics, a Critically analyse demand of 10 marks and 150 words; one objective demand is also routed here and carried as a coverage requirement only, namely 2025 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 62 on International North-South Transport Corridor connectivity, for which the official Set-A key is present locally while no option or answer letter is recorded or inferred; the locally held OCR-searchable official papers were read only to confirm printed wording and no question, key or marking scheme was imported from them. B. This topic owns the five Central Asian Republics, the Connect Central Asia Policy, the India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue mechanisms, India's Central Asian use of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the connectivity instruments of the International North-South Transport Corridor, Chabahar port and the Ashgabat Agreement, the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation and the New Great Game framing, and its distinctive feature is that its examinable spine is a constraint rather than an opportunity, because two verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2018 and 2024 and one objective demand from 2025 are routed here; the full institutional profile of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation belongs to topic 10, the India-China strategic relationship belongs to topic 03, the West Asian and energy-security limb of Chabahar belongs to topic 06, physical and route geography belongs to the Geography owner, and Soviet-era regional chronology with the nineteenth-century Great Game belongs to the World History owner. C. India engages Central Asia partly through existing fora described in the sources as the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the Eurasian Economic Community and the Custom Union, and it has proposed a Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement to integrate its markets with the Eurasian space; the examinable discipline is that a proposal is an instrument of intent rather than an operating arrangement, so an answer must name the proposal by its exact title and then trace what actually happened to it rather than implying that market integration has already occurred. D. The five Central Asian Republics are Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan, and the Connect Central Asia Policy launched in 2012 aims at strengthening and expanding India's relations with those countries through a broad-based approach including political, security, economic and cultural connections; the owners insist on the word broad-based because reducing the policy to energy alone misdescribes its declared scope, and they treat the 2012 launch as the foundational Indian policy approach against which every later mechanism in this topic is measured.

Answer: A. Explanation: The audited ledgers route two General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, namely 2018 General Studies Paper II question 10 on outside powers in Central Asia and India joining the Ashgabat Agreement, a Discuss the implications demand of 10 marks and 150 words for which the ledger records that the printed word-limit tail was corrupted in the scan and that the Core route supersedes the older Advanced ownership, and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 10 on India's evolving relations with the Central Asian Republics, a Critically analyse demand of 10 marks and 150 words; one objective demand is also routed here and carried as a coverage requirement only, namely 2025 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 62 on International North-South Transport Corridor connectivity, for which the official Set-A key is present locally while no option or answer letter is recorded or inferred; the locally held OCR-searchable official papers were read only to confirm printed wording and no question, key or marking scheme was imported from them. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q78. Which card should be filed under Honest question ownership for this Eurasian owner in an International Relations answer?

A. India engages Central Asia partly through existing fora described in the sources as the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the Eurasian Economic Community and the Custom Union, and it has proposed a Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement to integrate its markets with the Eurasian space; the examinable discipline is that a proposal is an instrument of intent rather than an operating arrangement, so an answer must name the proposal by its exact title and then trace what actually happened to it rather than implying that market integration has already occurred. B. The audited ledgers route two General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, namely 2018 General Studies Paper II question 10 on outside powers in Central Asia and India joining the Ashgabat Agreement, a Discuss the implications demand of 10 marks and 150 words for which the ledger records that the printed word-limit tail was corrupted in the scan and that the Core route supersedes the older Advanced ownership, and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 10 on India's evolving relations with the Central Asian Republics, a Critically analyse demand of 10 marks and 150 words; one objective demand is also routed here and carried as a coverage requirement only, namely 2025 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 62 on International North-South Transport Corridor connectivity, for which the official Set-A key is present locally while no option or answer letter is recorded or inferred; the locally held OCR-searchable official papers were read only to confirm printed wording and no question, key or marking scheme was imported from them. C. The proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement is now pursued as the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation, which formally began on 3 June 2017 at St Petersburg and remained under negotiation, with the second round held in Moscow on 22-25 June 2026; the owners fix the status precisely as under negotiation and neither signed nor in force, so an answer may cite the dated rounds as evidence of sustained economic engagement and may never assert conclusion, signature or entry into force. D. The five Central Asian Republics are Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan, and the Connect Central Asia Policy launched in 2012 aims at strengthening and expanding India's relations with those countries through a broad-based approach including political, security, economic and cultural connections; the owners insist on the word broad-based because reducing the policy to energy alone misdescribes its declared scope, and they treat the 2012 launch as the foundational Indian policy approach against which every later mechanism in this topic is measured.

Answer: B. Explanation: The audited ledgers route two General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, namely 2018 General Studies Paper II question 10 on outside powers in Central Asia and India joining the Ashgabat Agreement, a Discuss the implications demand of 10 marks and 150 words for which the ledger records that the printed word-limit tail was corrupted in the scan and that the Core route supersedes the older Advanced ownership, and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 10 on India's evolving relations with the Central Asian Republics, a Critically analyse demand of 10 marks and 150 words; one objective demand is also routed here and carried as a coverage requirement only, namely 2025 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 62 on International North-South Transport Corridor connectivity, for which the official Set-A key is present locally while no option or answer letter is recorded or inferred; the locally held OCR-searchable official papers were read only to confirm printed wording and no question, key or marking scheme was imported from them. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q79. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Honest question ownership for this Eurasian owner?

A. The proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement is now pursued as the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation, which formally began on 3 June 2017 at St Petersburg and remained under negotiation, with the second round held in Moscow on 22-25 June 2026; the owners fix the status precisely as under negotiation and neither signed nor in force, so an answer may cite the dated rounds as evidence of sustained economic engagement and may never assert conclusion, signature or entry into force. B. India engages Central Asia partly through existing fora described in the sources as the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the Eurasian Economic Community and the Custom Union, and it has proposed a Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement to integrate its markets with the Eurasian space; the examinable discipline is that a proposal is an instrument of intent rather than an operating arrangement, so an answer must name the proposal by its exact title and then trace what actually happened to it rather than implying that market integration has already occurred. C. The audited ledgers route two General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, namely 2018 General Studies Paper II question 10 on

outside powers in Central Asia and India joining the Ashgabat Agreement, a Discuss the implications demand of 10 marks and 150 words for which the ledger records that the printed word-limit tail was corrupted in the scan and that the Core route supersedes the older Advanced ownership, and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 10 on India's evolving relations with the Central Asian Republics, a Critically analyse demand of 10 marks and 150 words; one objective demand is also routed here and carried as a coverage requirement only, namely 2025 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 62 on International North-South Transport Corridor connectivity, for which the official Set-A key is present locally while no option or answer letter is recorded or inferred; the locally held OCR-searchable official papers were read only to confirm printed wording and no question, key or marking scheme was imported from them. D. India looks to Central Asia as a long-term partner in energy and natural resources, given the region's substantial hydrocarbon and mineral endowment, and this interest is what makes the connectivity question consequential rather than merely administrative; the owners keep the claim at the level of a stated policy interest and do not attach any volume, share, price or contract figure to it, because no such figure is carried by the sources and an invented number would convert a defensible interest claim into a fabricated one.

Answer: C. Explanation: The audited ledgers route two General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, namely 2018 General Studies Paper II question 10 on outside powers in Central Asia and India joining the Ashgabat Agreement, a Discuss the implications demand of 10 marks and 150 words for which the ledger records that the printed word-limit tail was corrupted in the scan and that the Core route supersedes the older Advanced ownership, and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 10 on India's evolving relations with the Central Asian Republics, a Critically analyse demand of 10 marks and 150 words; one objective demand is also routed here and carried as a coverage requirement only, namely 2025 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 62 on International North-South Transport Corridor connectivity, for which the official Set-A key is present locally while no option or answer letter is recorded or inferred; the locally held OCR-searchable official papers were read only to confirm printed wording and no question, key or marking scheme was imported from them. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q80. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Honest question ownership for this Eurasian owner?

A. The proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement is now pursued as the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation, which formally began on 3 June 2017 at St Petersburg and remained under negotiation, with the second round held in Moscow on 22-25 June 2026; the owners fix the status precisely as under negotiation and neither signed nor in force, so an answer may cite the dated rounds as evidence of sustained economic engagement and may never assert conclusion, signature or entry into force. B. India looks to Central Asia as a long-term partner in energy and natural resources, given the region's substantial hydrocarbon and mineral endowment, and this interest is what makes the connectivity question consequential rather than merely administrative; the owners keep the claim at the level of a stated policy interest and do not attach any volume, share, price or contract figure to it, because no such figure is carried by the sources and an invented number would convert a defensible interest claim into a fabricated one. C. India has no direct land access to the Central Asian Republics because Pakistan and Afghanistan lie in between, so the first overland option is politically and security constrained, while Sikri records that any energy pipeline from Eurasia to India not crossing Afghanistan or Pakistan has to be routed via Xinjiang and then across the Karakoram and the Himalayan mountain ranges, which is geographically extreme and would require Chinese cooperation; the owners are categorical that this is a structural rather than a merely technical problem, so both plausible overland routes carry a serious political or geographic difficulty at the same time. D. The audited ledgers route two General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, namely 2018 General Studies Paper II question 10 on outside powers in Central Asia and India joining the Ashgabat Agreement, a Discuss the implications demand of 10 marks and 150 words for which the ledger records that the printed word-limit tail was corrupted in the scan and that the Core route supersedes the older Advanced ownership, and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 10 on India's evolving relations with the Central Asian Republics, a Critically analyse demand of 10 marks and 150 words; one objective demand is also routed here and carried as a coverage requirement only, namely 2025 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 62 on International North-South Transport Corridor connectivity, for which the official Set-A key is present locally while no option or answer letter is recorded or inferred; the locally held OCR-searchable official papers were read only to confirm printed wording and no question, key or marking scheme was imported from them.

Answer: D. Explanation: The audited ledgers route two General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, namely 2018 General Studies Paper II question 10 on outside powers in Central Asia and India joining the Ashgabat Agreement, a Discuss the implications demand of 10 marks and 150 words for which the ledger records that the printed word-limit tail was corrupted in the scan and that the Core route supersedes the older Advanced ownership, and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 10 on India's evolving relations with the Central Asian Republics, a Critically analyse demand of 10 marks and 150 words; one objective demand is also routed here and carried as a coverage requirement only, namely 2025 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 62 on International North-South Transport Corridor connectivity, for which the official Set-A key is present locally while no option or answer letter is recorded or inferred; the locally held OCR-searchable official papers were read only to confirm printed wording and no question, key or marking scheme was imported from them. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

VERIFIED PYQ OWNERSHIP AUDIT

Two General Studies Paper II Mains demands are routed to this topic in the audited routing ledgers and each is reproduced below as a demand card with its printed year, paper, question number, directive, marks and word limit exactly as the ledger records them: 2018 General Studies Paper II question 10 on outside powers in Central Asia and India joining the Ashgabat Agreement, a Discuss the implications demand of 10 marks and 150 words, for which the ledger records that the printed word-limit tail was corrupted in the scan and that the Core route supersedes the older Advanced ownership; and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 10 on India's evolving diplomatic, economic and strategic relations with the Central Asian Republics, a Critically analyse demand of 10 marks and 150 words. One objective demand is also routed to this owner and is carried as a coverage requirement only: 2025 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 62 on International North-South Transport Corridor connectivity, for which the official Set-A key is present locally. No option or answer letter is recorded or inferred for that objective demand, and the presence of a locally held key is not treated as permission to publish one. Where a printed word limit or stem tail is recorded as corrupted in the scan, that defect is reported rather than silently repaired by invented wording. The locally held OCR-searchable official General Studies papers were read only to confirm the printed wording of the routed Mains demands; no question was invented from them, no stem was paraphrased into an apparent routing, and no marking scheme or official answer key was imported.

OWNER PYQ LEDGER EXTRACTS

9. PYQ application

- **FACT: 2024 Q10 (direct):** *Critically analyse India's evolving diplomatic, economic and strategic relations with the Central Asian Republics (CARs) highlighting their increasing significance in regional and global geopolitics.* **Structure:** (1) list the five CARs and the Connect Central Asia Policy (2012); (2) cite the proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement and SCO engagement as the "evolving" economic/diplomatic dimension; (3) name the Afghanistan/Pakistan connectivity constraint and the Xinjiang/Karakoram alternative-route problem as the "critical" analytical dimension; (4) place the relationship within the "New Great Game" great-power-competition context to address "increasing significance in regional and global geopolitics."

Recent PYQ Integration (2024-2025)

Status: 2024-2025 question-level PYQ demand is integrated into this owner. **Provenance:** Audited local official-paper routing ledgers: _PYQ-ROUTING-MAINS-GS1-GS2-ESSAY-2024-2025.md, _PYQ-ROUTING-PRELIMS-2024-2025.md. **Answer-key rule:** The official 2024-2025 Prelims Set-A keys are present in the repository and CSAT Set-A keys are supplied; even so, no option or answer is recorded or inferred in this integration.

- **Years represented:** 2024, 2025
- **Paper(s):** GS-II, Prelims GS-I

- Routed question demands: 2

Year	Paper	Q	PYQ demand (neutral rendering)	Directive / format	Source status	Owner requirement
2024	GS-II	10	India's relations with the Central Asian Republics	Critically analyse · 10 marks · 150 words	Routed to owning topic	Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
2025	Prelims GS-I	62	International North-South Transport Corridor (INSTC) connectivity	Objective question; official Set-A key available locally, answer not inferred	Key available locally (official Set-A answer key present); answer not recorded here	Cover the named fact/concept and its likely statement-level distinctions.

What this owner must now support

- India's relations with the Central Asian Republics
- International North-South Transport Corridor (INSTC) connectivity

This block integrates the 2024-2025 examinable demand and paper metadata. It is kept separate from the 2018-2023 block and does not convert an unkeyed/answer-free objective question into a solved answer.

Historical PYQ Integration (2018-2023)

Status: Question-level PYQ demand is integrated into this owner. **Provenance:** Audited local official-paper routing ledgers: _PYQ-ROUTING-MAINS-GS1-GS2-ESSAY-2018-2023.md.

- **Years represented:** 2018
- **Paper(s):** GS-II
- **Routed question demands:** 1

Year	Paper	Q	PYQ demand (neutral rendering)	Directive / format	Source status	Owner requirement
2018	GS-II	10	Outside powers in Central Asia and India joining the Ashgabat Agreement	Discuss the implications · 10 marks · 150 words	Core route supersedes older Advanced ownership	Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.

What this owner must now support

- Outside powers in Central Asia and India joining the Ashgabat Agreement

The table integrates the examinable demand and paper metadata. It does not turn an unkeyed objective question into a solved answer, and it does not claim that lexical presence alone proves full conceptual sufficiency.

10. PYQ-based analytical application

- **FACT: 2024 Q10 (direct):** *Critically analyse India's evolving diplomatic, economic and strategic relations with the Central Asian Republics (CARs) highlighting their increasing significance in regional and global geopolitics.* An advanced answer should:

1. Name the Connect Central Asia Policy (2012) and SCO engagement as the diplomatic/economic evolution.
2. Identify the structural connectivity constraint (no direct land access; Xinjiang/Karakoram alternative equally constrained) as the critical limiting factor.
3. Discuss INSTC/Chabahar as a partial, Iran-dependent work-around.
4. Place the analysis within the "New Great Game" competitive context, explicitly noting that outcomes are co-determined by Russia, China and Western engagement, not by India alone.

Historical PYQ Integration (2018-2023)

Status: Question-level PYQ demand is integrated into this owner. **Provenance:** Audited local official-paper routing ledgers: _PYQ-ROUTING-MAINS-GS1-GS2-ESSAY-2018-2023.md.

- **Years represented:** 2018
- **Paper(s):** GS-II
- **Routed question demands:** 1

Year	Paper	Q	PYQ demand (neutral rendering)	Directive / format	Source status	Owner requirement
2018	GS-II	10	Outside powers in Central Asia and India joining the Ashgabat Agreement	Discuss the implications · 10 marks · 150 words	Routed to owning topic; printed word-limit tail OCR-corrupted in scan	Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.

What this owner must now support

- Outside powers in Central Asia and India joining the Ashgabat Agreement

The table integrates the examinable demand and paper metadata. It does not turn an unkeyed objective question into a solved answer, and it does not claim that lexical presence alone proves full conceptual sufficiency.

PYQ DEMAND CARD 1 - 2018 General Studies Paper II Question 10

Demand: Outside powers in Central Asia and India joining the Ashgabat Agreement, a Discuss the implications demand of 10 marks and 150 words, exactly as recorded in the audited 2018-2023 Mains routing ledger. The ledger records that the printed word-limit tail was corrupted in the scan, and that defect is reported here rather than repaired by invented wording.

Status: Routed to this owner in the audited 2018-2023 Mains routing ledger, where the Core route is recorded as superseding the older Advanced ownership. No official answer key exists for a Mains demand and none is claimed, and no reconstruction of the corrupted word-limit tail is attempted.

Model solution: Claim: joining the Ashgabat Agreement matters less as a transport decision than as India's attempt to acquire a rules-based transit right in a region where outside powers already hold geographic and historical advantage. Named evidence and example: the Agreement signed at Ashgabat on 25 April 2011 to establish an international multimodal transport and transit corridor between Central Asia and the Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman, which India joined with effect from 3 February 2018; the absence of direct land access to Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan because Pakistan and Afghanistan lie in between; Sikri's finding that any Eurasia-to-India pipeline avoiding Afghanistan or Pakistan has to be routed via Xinjiang and then across the Karakoram and the Himalayan mountain ranges; the International North-South Transport Corridor and Chabahar port as the maritime-linked work-around; and Sikri's New Great Game framing of a region that abuts on the borders of major powers in Asia and will always attract foreign presences. Analysis: accession converts an aspiration into a transit framework that reduces dependence on direct territorial access through Pakistan, and it complements rather than duplicates the corridor projects, because a rules framework governs movement while a port and a corridor supply the physical route; the implication for outside-power competition is that India substitutes institutional participation for the geographic proximity that Russia and China already possess, which is the only lever genuinely available to a state without a land border in the region. Qualification: the Agreement is a facilitation framework and not an infrastructure-finance mechanism, so its value depends on connected ports, rail and road segments, customs coordination and Iran-related sanctions exposure; the outcome in the region is co-determined by Russian, Chinese and Western engagement rather than by India's effort alone; and Shanghai Cooperation Organisation membership, whose current tiers place Pakistan and Iran as full members, provides a platform without resolving transit access. Why this earns marks: it discusses implications rather than describing the Agreement, dates both the instrument and India's accession, and names the exact limit that separates a transit framework from delivered connectivity.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on "PYQ DEMAND CARD 1 - 2018 General Studies Paper II Question 10", every clause, bilateral/regional/systemic mapping, interests and constraints,

objective-instrument-implementation-outcome separation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, alternatives, implementation risks and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: Claim: joining the Ashgabat Agreement matters less as a transport decision than as India's attempt to acquire a rules-based transit right in a region where outside powers already hold geographic and historical advantage. Named evidence and example: the Agreement signed at Ashgabat on 25 April 2011 to establish an international multimodal transport and transit corridor between Central Asia and the Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman, which India joined with effect from 3 February 2018; the absence of direct land access to Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan because Pakistan and Afghanistan lie in between; Sikri's finding that any Eurasia-to-India pipeline avoiding Afghanistan or Pakistan has to be routed via Xinjiang and then across the Karakoram and the Himalayan mountain ranges; the International North-South Transport Corridor and Chabahar port as the maritime-linked work-around; and Sikri's New Great Game framing of a region that abuts on the borders of major powers in Asia and will always attract foreign presences. Analysis: accession converts an aspiration into a transit framework that reduces dependence on direct territorial access through Pakistan, and it complements rather than duplicates the corridor projects, because a rules framework governs movement while a port and a corridor supply the physical route; the implication for outside-power competition is that India substitutes institutional participation for the geographic proximity that Russia and China already possess, which is the only lever genuinely available to a state without a land border in the region. Qualification: the Agreement is a facilitation framework and not an infrastructure-finance mechanism, so its value depends on connected ports, rail and road segments, customs coordination and Iran-related sanctions exposure; the outcome in the region is co-determined by Russian, Chinese and Western engagement rather than by India's effort alone; and Shanghai Cooperation Organisation membership, whose current tiers place Pakistan and Iran as full members, provides a platform without resolving transit access. Why this earns marks: it discusses implications rather than describing the Agreement, dates both the instrument and India's accession, and names the exact limit that separates a transit framework from delivered connectivity.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** PYQ DEMAND CARD 1 - 2018 General Studies Paper II Question 10 **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

Counter-position / limit: A doctrine label, summit declaration, signed document, project announcement, military exercise, trade change or diplomatic statement cannot alone establish binding obligation, operational delivery or strategic outcome; test legal character, implementation, partner response, alternatives and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: Claim: joining the Ashgabat Agreement matters less as a transport decision than as India's attempt to acquire a rules-based transit right in a region where outside powers already hold geographic and historical advantage. Named evidence and example: the Agreement signed at Ashgabat on 25 April 2011 to establish an international multimodal transport and transit corridor between Central Asia and the Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman, which India joined with effect from 3 February 2018; the absence of direct land access to Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan because Pakistan and Afghanistan lie in between; Sikri's finding that any Eurasia-to-India pipeline avoiding Afghanistan or Pakistan has to be routed via Xinjiang and then across the Karakoram and the Himalayan mountain ranges; the International North-South Transport Corridor and Chabahar port as the maritime-linked work-around; and Sikri's New Great Game framing of a region that abuts on the borders of major powers in Asia and will always attract foreign presences. Analysis: accession converts an aspiration into a transit framework that reduces dependence on direct territorial access through Pakistan, and it complements rather than duplicates the corridor projects, because a rules framework governs movement while a port and a corridor supply the physical route; the implication for outside-power competition is that India substitutes institutional participation for the geographic proximity that Russia and China already possess, which is the only lever genuinely available to a state without a land border in the region. Qualification: the Agreement is a facilitation framework and not an infrastructure-finance mechanism, so its value depends on connected ports, rail and road segments, customs coordination and Iran-related sanctions exposure; the outcome in the region is co-determined by Russian, Chinese and Western engagement rather than by India's effort alone; and Shanghai Cooperation Organisation membership,

whose current tiers place Pakistan and Iran as full members, provides a platform without resolving transit access. Why this earns marks: it discusses implications rather than describing the Agreement, dates both the instrument and India's accession, and names the exact limit that separates a transit framework from delivered connectivity.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 15 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing level -> interest -> instrument -> implementation -> outcome -> alternative; state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for source, date, membership, operative status, partner agency, causation, escalation and residual risk.

How to improve this answer: For "PYQ DEMAND CARD 1 - 2018 General Studies Paper II Question 10", replace the weakest event-list point with one named actor, interest, instrument, implementation bottleneck, measurable outcome, alternative and source-date-status qualification.

PYQ DEMAND CARD 2 - 2024 General Studies Paper II Question 10

Demand: India's evolving diplomatic, economic and strategic relations with the Central Asian Republics, highlighting their increasing significance in regional and global geopolitics, a Critically analyse demand of 10 marks and 150 words, exactly as recorded in the audited 2024-2025 Mains routing ledger.

Status: Routed to this owner in the audited 2024-2025 Mains routing ledger and reproduced in the Basic owner as the anchor demand for this topic. No official answer key exists for a Mains demand and none is claimed.

Model solution: Claim: the relationship has genuinely evolved across diplomatic, economic and strategic limbs, but its increasing significance must be assessed critically against a connectivity constraint that none of the evolution has yet removed. Named evidence and example: the Connect Central Asia Policy launched in 2012 as a broad-based approach covering political, security, economic and cultural connections with Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan; the proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement now pursued as the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation that formally began on 3 June 2017 at St Petersburg with a second round in Moscow on 22-25 June 2026; the first India-Central Asia Summit held virtually on 27 January 2022, the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue in New Delhi on 6 June 2025 and the third meeting of Security Council Secretaries and National Security Advisers at Bishkek on 16 October 2025; India's full Shanghai Cooperation Organisation membership alongside the summit at Tianjin of 31 August and 1 September 2025 that adopted the Tianjin Declaration; the Ministry of External Affairs India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief current as on April 2026; and the connectivity instruments of Chabahar, contracted for ten years on 13 May 2024, the Ashgabat Agreement joined from 3 February 2018 and the International North-South Transport Corridor. Analysis: the diplomatic limb has institutionalised at ministerial and security-adviser level, the economic limb has moved from proposal to a live negotiation, and the strategic limb has acquired a maritime-linked route that bypasses Pakistan, so the direction of travel is real; yet the critical reading is that no second leader-level summit had been recorded as held by 3 August 2026, the free-trade negotiation remains open, and the corridor instruments remain developing frameworks with operating segments rather than completed, full-capacity routes, so significance is rising in engagement while remaining bounded in delivery. Qualification: the analysis must place India inside the New Great Game competitive field rather than treating it as the decisive actor, must record that the revocation of the United States Chabahar sanctions waiver effective 29 September 2025 with non-exposure assurance only to 26 April 2026 creates exposure without creating a legal obligation on India, and must concede that Shanghai Cooperation Organisation membership supplies a platform and not privileged access, particularly because Pakistan is also a full member. Why this earns marks: it satisfies the critical directive by pairing every claim of evolution with a dated limit, and it names the structural constraint instead of listing opportunities.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on "PYQ DEMAND CARD 2 - 2024 General Studies Paper II Question 10", every clause, bilateral/regional/systemic mapping, interests and constraints, objective-instrument-implementation-outcome separation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, alternatives, implementation risks and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: Claim: the relationship has genuinely evolved across diplomatic, economic and strategic limbs, but its increasing significance must be assessed critically against a connectivity constraint that none of the evolution has yet removed. Named evidence and example: the Connect Central Asia Policy launched in 2012 as a broad-based approach covering political, security, economic and cultural connections with Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan,

Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan; the proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement now pursued as the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation that formally began on 3 June 2017 at St Petersburg with a second round in Moscow on 22-25 June 2026; the first India-Central Asia Summit held virtually on 27 January 2022, the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue in New Delhi on 6 June 2025 and the third meeting of Security Council Secretaries and National Security Advisers at Bishkek on 16 October 2025; India's full Shanghai Cooperation Organisation membership alongside the summit at Tianjin of 31 August and 1 September 2025 that adopted the Tianjin Declaration; the Ministry of External Affairs India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief current as on April 2026; and the connectivity instruments of Chabahar, contracted for ten years on 13 May 2024, the Ashgabat Agreement joined from 3 February 2018 and the International North-South Transport Corridor. Analysis: the diplomatic limb has institutionalised at ministerial and security-adviser level, the economic limb has moved from proposal to a live negotiation, and the strategic limb has acquired a maritime-linked route that bypasses Pakistan, so the direction of travel is real; yet the critical reading is that no second leader-level summit had been recorded as held by 3 August 2026, the free-trade negotiation remains open, and the corridor instruments remain developing frameworks with operating segments rather than completed, full-capacity routes, so significance is rising in engagement while remaining bounded in delivery. Qualification: the analysis must place India inside the New Great Game competitive field rather than treating it as the decisive actor, must record that the revocation of the United States Chabahar sanctions waiver effective 29 September 2025 with non-exposure assurance only to 26 April 2026 creates exposure without creating a legal obligation on India, and must concede that Shanghai Cooperation Organisation membership supplies a platform and not privileged access, particularly because Pakistan is also a full member. Why this earns marks: it satisfies the critical directive by pairing every claim of evolution with a dated limit, and it names the structural constraint instead of listing opportunities.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** PYQ DEMAND CARD 2 - 2024 General Studies Paper II Question 10 **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** Status: Routed to this owner in the audited 2024-2025 Mains routing ledger and reproduced in the Basic owner as the anchor demand for this topic. No official answer key exists for a Mains demand and none is claimed. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

Counter-position / limit: A doctrine label, summit declaration, signed document, project announcement, military exercise, trade change or diplomatic statement cannot alone establish binding obligation, operational delivery or strategic outcome; test legal character, implementation, partner response, alternatives and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: Claim: the relationship has genuinely evolved across diplomatic, economic and strategic limbs, but its increasing significance must be assessed critically against a connectivity constraint that none of the evolution has yet removed. Named evidence and example: the Connect Central Asia Policy launched in 2012 as a broad-based approach covering political, security, economic and cultural connections with Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan; the proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement now pursued as the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation that formally began on 3 June 2017 at St Petersburg with a second round in Moscow on 22-25 June 2026; the first India-Central Asia Summit held virtually on 27 January 2022, the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue in New Delhi on 6 June 2025 and the third meeting of Security Council Secretaries and National Security Advisers at Bishkek on 16 October 2025; India's full Shanghai Cooperation Organisation membership alongside the summit at Tianjin of 31 August and 1 September 2025 that adopted the Tianjin Declaration; the Ministry of External Affairs India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief current as on April 2026; and the connectivity instruments of Chabahar, contracted for ten years on 13 May 2024, the Ashgabat Agreement joined from 3 February 2018 and the International North-South Transport Corridor. Analysis: the diplomatic limb has institutionalised at ministerial and security-adviser level, the economic limb has moved from proposal to a live negotiation, and the strategic limb has acquired a maritime-linked route that bypasses Pakistan, so the direction of travel is real; yet the critical reading is that no second leader-level summit had been recorded as held by 3 August

2026, the free-trade negotiation remains open, and the corridor instruments remain developing frameworks with operating segments rather than completed, full-capacity routes, so significance is rising in engagement while remaining bounded in delivery. Qualification: the analysis must place India inside the New Great Game competitive field rather than treating it as the decisive actor, must record that the revocation of the United States Chabahar sanctions waiver effective 29 September 2025 with non-exposure assurance only to 26 April 2026 creates exposure without creating a legal obligation on India, and must concede that Shanghai Cooperation Organisation membership supplies a platform and not privileged access, particularly because Pakistan is also a full member. Why this earns marks: it satisfies the critical directive by pairing every claim of evolution with a dated limit, and it names the structural constraint instead of listing opportunities.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 15 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing level -> interest -> instrument -> implementation -> outcome -> alternative; state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for source, date, membership, operative status, partner agency, causation, escalation and residual risk.

How to improve this answer: For "PYQ DEMAND CARD 2 - 2024 General Studies Paper II Question 10", replace the weakest event-list point with one named actor, interest, instrument, implementation bottleneck, measurable outcome, alternative and source-date-status qualification.

ORIGINAL MAINS 1 - 10 MARKS

Question: Explain why India's Central Asia connectivity problem is structural rather than merely technical. Answer in about 150 words.

Model thesis: The problem is structural because both plausible overland routes fail for different reasons at the same time, so the answer must state the absence of direct land access first, set the politically constrained route against the geographically extreme Xinjiang and Karakoram alternative, and close by showing that the maritime-linked work-around substitutes rather than removes dependence.

Claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification:

- India has no direct land access to the Central Asian Republics because Pakistan and Afghanistan lie in between, so the first overland option is politically and security constrained, while Sikri records that any energy pipeline from Eurasia to India not crossing Afghanistan or Pakistan has to be routed via Xinjiang and then across the Karakoram and the Himalayan mountain ranges, which is geographically extreme and would require Chinese cooperation; the owners are categorical that this is a structural rather than a merely technical problem, so both plausible overland routes carry a serious political or geographic difficulty at the same time.
- The International North-South Transport Corridor is a connectivity framework intended to open a maritime-linked route to Central Asia and Eurasia bypassing Pakistan, and the owners require it to be treated as an announced and developing corridor with operating segments rather than a completed, full-capacity corridor; the same discipline extends to Chabahar, because connectivity-project timelines routinely lag announcements, so any specific capacity, throughput or completion claim requires independent dated verification instead of being assumed to match the original announcement.
- Afghanistan sits at the centre of the connectivity problem because it is the potential land-bridge to Central Asia while being itself a source of instability that currently forecloses that option, and the owners record this as a genuine unresolved tension rather than a solved problem; the consequence for answer writing is that Afghanistan cannot be treated either as a ready corridor or as an irrelevant space, and any recommendation must be calibrated to a situation in which the shortest route is the least available one.
- The maritime-linked work-around through Iran bypasses the Pakistan land constraint but substitutes one set of external dependencies, namely Iran-linked geopolitics and sanctions risk, for another, so no unilateral connectivity solution exists and the dependency problem is managed rather than removed; the owners pair this with the timeline warning that announcements outrun delivery in this sector, which together give the honest verdict that India's Central Asia problem is not an absence of interest but the conversion of diplomatic goodwill into reliable access across contested transit space.

Qualified conclusion: The problem is structural because both plausible overland routes fail for different reasons at the same time, so the answer must state the absence of direct land access first, set the politically constrained route against the geographically extreme Xinjiang and Karakoram alternative, and close by showing that the maritime-linked

work-around substitutes rather than removes dependence.

Demand decoding: The directive **explain** requires a direct position on “Explain why India’s Central Asia connectivity problem is structural rather than merely...”, every clause, bilateral/regional/systemic mapping, interests and constraints, objective-instrument-implementation-outcome separation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, alternatives, implementation risks and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: The problem is structural because both plausible overland routes fail for different reasons at the same time, so the answer must state the absence of direct land access first, set the politically constrained route against the geographically extreme Xinjiang and Karakoram alternative, and close by showing that the maritime-linked work-around substitutes rather than removes dependence.

Analytical body:

- 1. Claim and named evidence:** India has no direct land access to the Central Asian Republics because Pakistan and Afghanistan lie in between, so the first overland option is politically and security constrained, while Sikri records that any energy pipeline from Eurasia to India not crossing Afghanistan or Pakistan has to be routed via Xinjiang and then across the Karakoram and the Himalayan mountain ranges, which is geographically extreme and would require Chinese cooperation; the owners are categorical that this is a structural rather than a merely technical problem, so both plausible overland routes carry a serious political or geographic difficulty at the same time. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
- 2. Claim and named evidence:** The International North-South Transport Corridor is a connectivity framework intended to open a maritime-linked route to Central Asia and Eurasia bypassing Pakistan, and the owners require it to be treated as an announced and developing corridor with operating segments rather than a completed, full-capacity corridor; the same discipline extends to Chabahar, because connectivity-project timelines routinely lag announcements, so any specific capacity, throughput or completion claim requires independent dated verification instead of being assumed to match the original announcement. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
- 3. Claim and named evidence:** Afghanistan sits at the centre of the connectivity problem because it is the potential land-bridge to Central Asia while being itself a source of instability that currently forecloses that option, and the owners record this as a genuine unresolved tension rather than a solved problem; the consequence for answer writing is that Afghanistan cannot be treated either as a ready corridor or as an irrelevant space, and any recommendation must be calibrated to a situation in which the shortest route is the least available one. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
- 4. Claim and named evidence:** The maritime-linked work-around through Iran bypasses the Pakistan land constraint but substitutes one set of external dependencies, namely Iran-linked geopolitics and sanctions risk, for another, so no unilateral connectivity solution exists and the dependency problem is managed rather than removed; the owners pair this with the timeline warning that announcements outrun delivery in this sector, which together give the honest verdict that India’s Central Asia problem is not an absence of interest but the conversion of diplomatic goodwill into reliable access across contested transit space. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

Counter-position / limit: A doctrine label, summit declaration, signed document, project announcement, military exercise, trade change or diplomatic statement cannot alone establish binding obligation, operational delivery or strategic outcome; test legal character, implementation, partner response, alternatives and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: The problem is structural because both plausible overland routes fail for different reasons at the same time, so the answer must state the absence of direct land access first, set the politically constrained route against the geographically extreme Xinjiang and Karakoram alternative, and close by showing that the maritime-linked work-around substitutes rather than removes dependence.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 10 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing level -> interest -> instrument -> implementation -> outcome -> alternative; state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for source, date, membership, operative status, partner agency, causation, escalation and residual risk.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, explains strategy and implementation rather than listing visits or groupings, uses named India-centric evidence and preserves institutional, status, level, causal and geopolitical distinctions.

How to improve this answer: For “Explain why India's Central Asia connectivity problem is structural rather than merely...”, replace the weakest event-list point with one named actor, interest, instrument, implementation bottleneck, measurable outcome, alternative and source-date-status qualification.

ORIGINAL MAINS 2 - 10 MARKS

Question: Comment on the proposition that membership of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation has given India privileged access to Central Asia. Answer in about 150 words.

Model thesis: The proposition fails because a mixed-membership forum cannot deliver a member-specific outcome, so the comment must state the current membership tiers exactly, name Pakistan's own membership as the reason the transit problem survives the forum, and still credit the platform value that membership genuinely provides.

Claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification:

- As of 3 August 2026 the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation has ten full members, namely Belarus, China, India, Iran, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Pakistan, Russia, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan, two observers, namely Afghanistan and Mongolia, and fifteen dialogue partners, with Pakistan a member since 2017, Iran since 2023 and Belarus since 2024, while a decision of 1 September 2025 envisages consolidating the observer and dialogue-partner categories into a single SCO Partner status whose enabling amendments had not entered into force; the owners warn expressly that Sikri's book-period note placing Pakistan, Iran and Mongolia in observer status is period-specific and must be dated whenever it is quoted.
- The 2025 Heads of State Council summit of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation met at Tianjin on 31 August and 1 September 2025 and adopted the Tianjin Declaration, Kyrgyzstan holds the 2025-26 chairmanship and the next summit is scheduled for Bishkek, while India's own accession to full membership in 2017 is treated as chronology owned by the World History and Polity owners; the owners permit the summit and declaration to be cited as dated evidence of India's continued multilateral engagement and permit no claim about the declaration's contents beyond its adoption at that meeting.
- India's full membership of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation provides a seat and a platform but not privileged influence, because the same forum includes China, Russia and Pakistan, so its outputs reflect compromise among competing major-power interests rather than an India-centred agenda, and Pakistan's own membership means the forum cannot itself resolve the transit-access problem; the owners therefore separate two claims that answers routinely merge, namely that membership sustains political, security and economic engagement, and that membership does not by itself create physical connectivity, which depends on separate corridor projects.
- This topic owns the five Central Asian Republics, the Connect Central Asia Policy, the India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue mechanisms, India's Central Asian use of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the connectivity instruments of the International North-South Transport Corridor, Chabahar port and the Ashgabat Agreement, the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation and the New Great Game framing, and its distinctive feature is that its examinable spine is a constraint rather than an opportunity, because two verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2018 and 2024 and one objective demand from 2025 are routed here; the full institutional

profile of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation belongs to topic 10, the India-China strategic relationship belongs to topic 03, the West Asian and energy-security limb of Chabahar belongs to topic 06, physical and route geography belongs to the Geography owner, and Soviet-era regional chronology with the nineteenth-century Great Game belongs to the World History owner.

Qualified conclusion: The proposition fails because a mixed-membership forum cannot deliver a member-specific outcome, so the comment must state the current membership tiers exactly, name Pakistan's own membership as the reason the transit problem survives the forum, and still credit the platform value that membership genuinely provides.

Demand decoding: The directive **comment** requires a direct position on "Comment on the proposition that membership of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation has given...", every clause, bilateral/regional/systemic mapping, interests and constraints, objective-instrument-implementation-outcome separation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, alternatives, implementation risks and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: The proposition fails because a mixed-membership forum cannot deliver a member-specific outcome, so the comment must state the current membership tiers exactly, name Pakistan's own membership as the reason the transit problem survives the forum, and still credit the platform value that membership genuinely provides.

Analytical body:

- 1. Claim and named evidence:** As of 3 August 2026 the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation has ten full members, namely Belarus, China, India, Iran, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Pakistan, Russia, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan, two observers, namely Afghanistan and Mongolia, and fifteen dialogue partners, with Pakistan a member since 2017, Iran since 2023 and Belarus since 2024, while a decision of 1 September 2025 envisages consolidating the observer and dialogue-partner categories into a single SCO Partner status whose enabling amendments had not entered into force; the owners warn expressly that Sikri's book-period note placing Pakistan, Iran and Mongolia in observer status is period-specific and must be dated whenever it is quoted. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
- 2. Claim and named evidence:** The 2025 Heads of State Council summit of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation met at Tianjin on 31 August and 1 September 2025 and adopted the Tianjin Declaration, Kyrgyzstan holds the 2025-26 chairmanship and the next summit is scheduled for Bishkek, while India's own accession to full membership in 2017 is treated as chronology owned by the World History and Polity owners; the owners permit the summit and declaration to be cited as dated evidence of India's continued multilateral engagement and permit no claim about the declaration's contents beyond its adoption at that meeting. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
- 3. Claim and named evidence:** India's full membership of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation provides a seat and a platform but not privileged influence, because the same forum includes China, Russia and Pakistan, so its outputs reflect compromise among competing major-power interests rather than an India-centred agenda, and Pakistan's own membership means the forum cannot itself resolve the transit-access problem; the owners therefore separate two claims that answers routinely merge, namely that membership sustains political, security and economic engagement, and that membership does not by itself create physical connectivity, which depends on separate corridor projects. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
- 4. Claim and named evidence:** This topic owns the five Central Asian Republics, the Connect Central Asia Policy, the India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue mechanisms, India's Central Asian use of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the connectivity instruments of the International North-South Transport Corridor, Chabahar port and the Ashgabat Agreement, the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation and the New Great Game

framing, and its distinctive feature is that its examinable spine is a constraint rather than an opportunity, because two verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2018 and 2024 and one objective demand from 2025 are routed here; the full institutional profile of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation belongs to topic 10, the India-China strategic relationship belongs to topic 03, the West Asian and energy-security limb of Chabahar belongs to topic 06, physical and route geography belongs to the Geography owner, and Soviet-era regional chronology with the nineteenth-century Great Game belongs to the World History owner. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

Counter-position / limit: A doctrine label, summit declaration, signed document, project announcement, military exercise, trade change or diplomatic statement cannot alone establish binding obligation, operational delivery or strategic outcome; test legal character, implementation, partner response, alternatives and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: The proposition fails because a mixed-membership forum cannot deliver a member-specific outcome, so the comment must state the current membership tiers exactly, name Pakistan's own membership as the reason the transit problem survives the forum, and still credit the platform value that membership genuinely provides.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 10 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing level -> interest -> instrument -> implementation -> outcome -> alternative; state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for source, date, membership, operative status, partner agency, causation, escalation and residual risk.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, explains strategy and implementation rather than listing visits or groupings, uses named India-centric evidence and preserves institutional, status, level, causal and geopolitical distinctions.

How to improve this answer: For "Comment on the proposition that membership of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation has given...", replace the weakest event-list point with one named actor, interest, instrument, implementation bottleneck, measurable outcome, alternative and source-date-status qualification.

ORIGINAL MAINS 3 - 15 MARKS

Question: Examine the instruments through which India has pursued economic and institutional engagement with Central Asia, and state what each instrument has and has not achieved. Answer in about 250 words.

Model thesis: Each instrument sits at a different evidentiary level, so the examination must run from the broad-based policy of 2012 through the proposed economic agreement and its negotiation rounds to the dedicated summit and dialogue format, and must state the unheld second summit and the open negotiation honestly rather than presenting intent as outcome.

Claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification:

- The five Central Asian Republics are Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan, and the Connect Central Asia Policy launched in 2012 aims at strengthening and expanding India's relations with those countries through a broad-based approach including political, security, economic and cultural connections; the owners insist on the word broad-based because reducing the policy to energy alone misdescribes its declared scope, and they treat the 2012 launch as the foundational Indian policy approach against which every later mechanism in this topic is measured.
- India engages Central Asia partly through existing fora described in the sources as the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the Eurasian Economic Community and the Custom Union, and it has proposed a Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement to integrate its markets with the Eurasian space; the examinable discipline is that a proposal is an instrument of intent rather than an operating arrangement, so an answer must name the proposal by its exact title and then trace what actually happened to it rather than implying that market integration has already occurred.
- The proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement is now pursued as the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation, which formally began on 3 June 2017 at St Petersburg and remained under negotiation, with the second round held in Moscow on 22-25 June 2026; the owners fix the status precisely as

under negotiation and neither signed nor in force, so an answer may cite the dated rounds as evidence of sustained economic engagement and may never assert conclusion, signature or entry into force.

- The first India-Central Asia Summit was held virtually on 27 January 2022, the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue at foreign-minister level met in New Delhi on 6 June 2025 and envisaged preparing the ground for a second summit, and the third meeting of Secretaries of Security Councils and National Security Advisers met at Bishkek on 16 October 2025, while no second leader-level summit had been recorded as held by 3 August 2026; the owners treat that absence as a candid indicator that the dedicated format has not yet institutionalised at leader level, and they require the gap to be stated rather than glossed over when a demand asks about increasing significance.

Qualified conclusion: Each instrument sits at a different evidentiary level, so the examination must run from the broad-based policy of 2012 through the proposed economic agreement and its negotiation rounds to the dedicated summit and dialogue format, and must state the unheld second summit and the open negotiation honestly rather than presenting intent as outcome.

Demand decoding: The directive **examine** requires a direct position on “Examine the instruments through which India has pursued economic and institutional engagement...”, every clause, bilateral/regional/systemic mapping, interests and constraints, objective-instrument-implementation-outcome separation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, alternatives, implementation risks and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: Each instrument sits at a different evidentiary level, so the examination must run from the broad-based policy of 2012 through the proposed economic agreement and its negotiation rounds to the dedicated summit and dialogue format, and must state the unheld second summit and the open negotiation honestly rather than presenting intent as outcome.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** The five Central Asian Republics are Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan, and the Connect Central Asia Policy launched in 2012 aims at strengthening and expanding India's relations with those countries through a broad-based approach including political, security, economic and cultural connections; the owners insist on the word broad-based because reducing the policy to energy alone misdescribes its declared scope, and they treat the 2012 launch as the foundational Indian policy approach against which every later mechanism in this topic is measured. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** India engages Central Asia partly through existing fora described in the sources as the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the Eurasian Economic Community and the Custom Union, and it has proposed a Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement to integrate its markets with the Eurasian space; the examinable discipline is that a proposal is an instrument of intent rather than an operating arrangement, so an answer must name the proposal by its exact title and then trace what actually happened to it rather than implying that market integration has already occurred. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
3. **Claim and named evidence:** The proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement is now pursued as the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation, which formally began on 3 June 2017 at St Petersburg and remained under negotiation, with the second round held in Moscow on 22-25 June 2026; the owners fix the status precisely as under negotiation and neither signed nor in force, so an answer may cite the dated rounds as evidence of sustained economic engagement and may never assert conclusion, signature or entry into force. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official

source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

4. **Claim and named evidence:** The first India-Central Asia Summit was held virtually on 27 January 2022, the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue at foreign-minister level met in New Delhi on 6 June 2025 and envisaged preparing the ground for a second summit, and the third meeting of Secretaries of Security Councils and National Security Advisers met at Bishkek on 16 October 2025, while no second leader-level summit had been recorded as held by 3 August 2026; the owners treat that absence as a candid indicator that the dedicated format has not yet institutionalised at leader level, and they require the gap to be stated rather than glossed over when a demand asks about increasing significance. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

Counter-position / limit: A doctrine label, summit declaration, signed document, project announcement, military exercise, trade change or diplomatic statement cannot alone establish binding obligation, operational delivery or strategic outcome; test legal character, implementation, partner response, alternatives and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: Each instrument sits at a different evidentiary level, so the examination must run from the broad-based policy of 2012 through the proposed economic agreement and its negotiation rounds to the dedicated summit and dialogue format, and must state the unheld second summit and the open negotiation honestly rather than presenting intent as outcome.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 15 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing level -> interest -> instrument -> implementation -> outcome -> alternative; state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for source, date, membership, operative status, partner agency, causation, escalation and residual risk.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, explains strategy and implementation rather than listing visits or groupings, uses named India-centric evidence and preserves institutional, status, level, causal and geopolitical distinctions.

How to improve this answer: For “Examine the instruments through which India has pursued economic and institutional engagement...”, replace the weakest event-list point with one named actor, interest, instrument, implementation bottleneck, measurable outcome, alternative and source-date-status qualification.

ORIGINAL MAINS 4 - 15 MARKS

Question: Examine the connectivity architecture India has built around the Pakistan transit constraint and assess how far third-party measures condition it. Answer in about 250 words.

Model thesis: The architecture is real and dated but conditioned by another state's domestic law, so the examination must set the contract of 13 May 2024 and the Ashgabat framework against the waiver revocation effective 29 September 2025 and the assurance limit of 26 April 2026, and must distinguish exposure from obligation throughout.

Claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification:

- India Ports Global Limited and Iran's Ports and Maritime Organisation signed a ten-year long-term contract for Chabahar port on 13 May 2024, with India announcing roughly one hundred and twenty million United States dollars in equipment investment and a two hundred and fifty million United States dollar credit window for mutually identified infrastructure; the owners require these to be cited as announced investment and an announced credit window rather than as delivered equipment or disbursed finance, because an announcement and a delivery are different evidentiary levels and the difference is exactly what a critical demand tests.
- The United States State Department revoked the 2018 Chabahar sanctions waiver on 16 September 2025 with effect from 29 September 2025, and a subsequent assurance of non-exposure ran only to 26 April 2026, so any status beyond that date requires fresh verification; the owners state the legal character precisely, because this is a change in another state's domestic sanctions posture that creates exposure risk for entities rather than an international legal obligation binding on India, and its practical effect is to convert the Iran work-around from a geographic question into a financing and sanctions-exposure question.
- The Ashgabat Agreement was signed at Ashgabat on 25 April 2011 to establish an international multimodal transport and transit corridor between Central Asia and the Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman, and India joined with

effect from 3 February 2018, which adds a rules-and-transit framework to India's Chabahar and corridor strategy and reduces dependence on direct territorial access through Pakistan; the owners attach the limitation directly, because it is a facilitation framework rather than an infrastructure-finance mechanism, so its value depends on connected ports, rail and road segments, customs coordination and Iran-related sanctions exposure.

- India looks to Central Asia as a long-term partner in energy and natural resources, given the region's substantial hydrocarbon and mineral endowment, and this interest is what makes the connectivity question consequential rather than merely administrative; the owners keep the claim at the level of a stated policy interest and do not attach any volume, share, price or contract figure to it, because no such figure is carried by the sources and an invented number would convert a defensible interest claim into a fabricated one.

Qualified conclusion: The architecture is real and dated but conditioned by another state's domestic law, so the examination must set the contract of 13 May 2024 and the Ashgabat framework against the waiver revocation effective 29 September 2025 and the assurance limit of 26 April 2026, and must distinguish exposure from obligation throughout.

Demand decoding: The directive **examine** requires a direct position on "Examine the connectivity architecture India has built around the Pakistan transit constraint...", every clause, bilateral/regional/systemic mapping, interests and constraints, objective-instrument-implementation-outcome separation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, alternatives, implementation risks and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: The architecture is real and dated but conditioned by another state's domestic law, so the examination must set the contract of 13 May 2024 and the Ashgabat framework against the waiver revocation effective 29 September 2025 and the assurance limit of 26 April 2026, and must distinguish exposure from obligation throughout.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** India Ports Global Limited and Iran's Ports and Maritime Organisation signed a ten-year long-term contract for Chabahar port on 13 May 2024, with India announcing roughly one hundred and twenty million United States dollars in equipment investment and a two hundred and fifty million United States dollar credit window for mutually identified infrastructure; the owners require these to be cited as announced investment and an announced credit window rather than as delivered equipment or disbursed finance, because an announcement and a delivery are different evidentiary levels and the difference is exactly what a critical demand tests. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** The United States State Department revoked the 2018 Chabahar sanctions waiver on 16 September 2025 with effect from 29 September 2025, and a subsequent assurance of non-exposure ran only to 26 April 2026, so any status beyond that date requires fresh verification; the owners state the legal character precisely, because this is a change in another state's domestic sanctions posture that creates exposure risk for entities rather than an international legal obligation binding on India, and its practical effect is to convert the Iran work-around from a geographic question into a financing and sanctions-exposure question. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
3. **Claim and named evidence:** The Ashgabat Agreement was signed at Ashgabat on 25 April 2011 to establish an international multimodal transport and transit corridor between Central Asia and the Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman, and India joined with effect from 3 February 2018, which adds a rules-and-transit framework to India's Chabahar and corridor strategy and reduces dependence on direct territorial access through Pakistan; the owners attach the limitation directly, because it is a facilitation framework rather than an infrastructure-finance mechanism, so its value depends on connected ports, rail and road segments, customs coordination and Iran-related sanctions exposure. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State

membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

4. **Claim and named evidence:** India looks to Central Asia as a long-term partner in energy and natural resources, given the region's substantial hydrocarbon and mineral endowment, and this interest is what makes the connectivity question consequential rather than merely administrative; the owners keep the claim at the level of a stated policy interest and do not attach any volume, share, price or contract figure to it, because no such figure is carried by the sources and an invented number would convert a defensible interest claim into a fabricated one.

Analysis: Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

Counter-position / limit: A doctrine label, summit declaration, signed document, project announcement, military exercise, trade change or diplomatic statement cannot alone establish binding obligation, operational delivery or strategic outcome; test legal character, implementation, partner response, alternatives and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: The architecture is real and dated but conditioned by another state's domestic law, so the examination must set the contract of 13 May 2024 and the Ashgabat framework against the waiver revocation effective 29 September 2025 and the assurance limit of 26 April 2026, and must distinguish exposure from obligation throughout.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 15 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing level -> interest -> instrument -> implementation -> outcome -> alternative; state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for source, date, membership, operative status, partner agency, causation, escalation and residual risk.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, explains strategy and implementation rather than listing visits or groupings, uses named India-centric evidence and preserves institutional, status, level, causal and geopolitical distinctions.

How to improve this answer: For "Examine the connectivity architecture India has built around the Pakistan transit constraint...", replace the weakest event-list point with one named actor, interest, instrument, implementation bottleneck, measurable outcome, alternative and source-date-status qualification.

ORIGINAL MAINS 5 - 20 MARKS

Question: Assess India's evolving diplomatic, economic and strategic relations with the Central Asian Republics against the constraint that shapes them. Answer in about 300 words.

Model thesis: Evolution and constraint must be assessed together, so the assessment must evidence the diplomatic, economic and security limbs with dated anchors, place them inside a competitive field that India does not control, and deliver a graded verdict on significance rather than an optimistic list of opportunities.

Claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification:

- The five Central Asian Republics are Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan, and the Connect Central Asia Policy launched in 2012 aims at strengthening and expanding India's relations with those countries through a broad-based approach including political, security, economic and cultural connections; the owners insist on the word broad-based because reducing the policy to energy alone misdescribes its declared scope, and they treat the 2012 launch as the foundational Indian policy approach against which every later mechanism in this topic is measured.
- The first India-Central Asia Summit was held virtually on 27 January 2022, the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue at foreign-minister level met in New Delhi on 6 June 2025 and envisaged preparing the ground for a second summit, and the third meeting of Secretaries of Security Councils and National Security Advisers met at Bishkek on 16 October 2025, while no second leader-level summit had been recorded as held by 3 August 2026; the owners treat that absence as a candid indicator that the dedicated format has not yet institutionalised at leader level, and they require the gap to be stated rather than glossed over when a demand asks about increasing significance.

- The Ministry of External Affairs India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief is current as on April 2026 and is the authoritative dated record for that relationship, and the owners instruct that this brief be cited for any specific current claim about it rather than a general assertion of warm ties; the wider methodological point is that a region-level policy claim and a country-level status claim require different evidence, so a candidate should name the dated brief when the demand turns on the present state of a particular bilateral relationship.
- Sikri frames Central Asia as a geographical area that abuts on the borders of major powers in Asia and will always attract foreign presences, which describes ongoing great-power competition for influence rather than any Indian ability to determine regional outcomes, and the owners add that Russia's and China's greater historical and geographic proximity constrains how much relative influence India can realistically build however effective its own diplomacy; the examinable consequence is that outcomes in this region are co-determined by Russian, Chinese and Western engagement, so an answer must place India's effort inside a competitive field rather than presenting it as the decisive variable.

Qualified conclusion: Evolution and constraint must be assessed together, so the assessment must evidence the diplomatic, economic and security limbs with dated anchors, place them inside a competitive field that India does not control, and deliver a graded verdict on significance rather than an optimistic list of opportunities.

Demand decoding: The directive **assess** requires a direct position on "Assess India's evolving diplomatic, economic and strategic relations with the Central Asian...", every clause, bilateral/regional/systemic mapping, interests and constraints, objective-instrument-implementation-outcome separation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, alternatives, implementation risks and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: Evolution and constraint must be assessed together, so the assessment must evidence the diplomatic, economic and security limbs with dated anchors, place them inside a competitive field that India does not control, and deliver a graded verdict on significance rather than an optimistic list of opportunities.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** The five Central Asian Republics are Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan, and the Connect Central Asia Policy launched in 2012 aims at strengthening and expanding India's relations with those countries through a broad-based approach including political, security, economic and cultural connections; the owners insist on the word broad-based because reducing the policy to energy alone misdescribes its declared scope, and they treat the 2012 launch as the foundational Indian policy approach against which every later mechanism in this topic is measured. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** The first India-Central Asia Summit was held virtually on 27 January 2022, the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue at foreign-minister level met in New Delhi on 6 June 2025 and envisaged preparing the ground for a second summit, and the third meeting of Secretaries of Security Councils and National Security Advisers met at Bishkek on 16 October 2025, while no second leader-level summit had been recorded as held by 3 August 2026; the owners treat that absence as a candid indicator that the dedicated format has not yet institutionalised at leader level, and they require the gap to be stated rather than glossed over when a demand asks about increasing significance. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
3. **Claim and named evidence:** The Ministry of External Affairs India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief is current as on April 2026 and is the authoritative dated record for that relationship, and the owners instruct that this brief be cited for any specific current claim about it rather than a general assertion of warm ties; the wider methodological point is that a region-level policy claim and a country-level status claim require different evidence, so a candidate should name the dated brief when the demand turns on the present state of a particular bilateral relationship. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership

and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

4. **Claim and named evidence:** Sikri frames Central Asia as a geographical area that abuts on the borders of major powers in Asia and will always attract foreign presences, which describes ongoing great-power competition for influence rather than any Indian ability to determine regional outcomes, and the owners add that Russia's and China's greater historical and geographic proximity constrains how much relative influence India can realistically build however effective its own diplomacy; the examinable consequence is that outcomes in this region are co-determined by Russian, Chinese and Western engagement, so an answer must place India's effort inside a competitive field rather than presenting it as the decisive variable. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

Counter-position / limit: A doctrine label, summit declaration, signed document, project announcement, military exercise, trade change or diplomatic statement cannot alone establish binding obligation, operational delivery or strategic outcome; test legal character, implementation, partner response, alternatives and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: Evolution and constraint must be assessed together, so the assessment must evidence the diplomatic, economic and security limbs with dated anchors, place them inside a competitive field that India does not control, and deliver a graded verdict on significance rather than an optimistic list of opportunities.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 20 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing level -> interest -> instrument -> implementation -> outcome -> alternative; state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for source, date, membership, operative status, partner agency, causation, escalation and residual risk.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, explains strategy and implementation rather than listing visits or groupings, uses named India-centric evidence and preserves institutional, status, level, causal and geopolitical distinctions.

How to improve this answer: For "Assess India's evolving diplomatic, economic and strategic relations with the Central Asian...", replace the weakest event-list point with one named actor, interest, instrument, implementation bottleneck, measurable outcome, alternative and source-date-status qualification.

ORIGINAL MAINS 6 - 20 MARKS

Question: Assess whether functional cooperation with China is compatible with India's competitive position in Eurasia. Answer in about 300 words.

Model thesis: Compatibility depends on separating the functional issue from the strategic relationship, so the assessment must use the energy-understanding argument as the cooperative case, weigh it against the China-dependent overland route and the mixed-membership forum, and close with a calibrated recommendation that predicts no corridor completion or negotiation outcome.

Claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification:

- Sikri argues that India must try to develop an understanding on energy with China because both are major energy consumers often seeking energy from the same sources and their competition is only benefiting the energy producers, which the owners treat as a rare explicit call for cooperative management of a shared dependency despite broader strategic mistrust; the analytical value of this anchor is that it shows competition and cooperation coexisting on a specific functional issue, so a critical answer can avoid the crude choice between pure rivalry and naive partnership.
- India's full membership of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation provides a seat and a platform but not privileged influence, because the same forum includes China, Russia and Pakistan, so its outputs reflect compromise among competing major-power interests rather than an India-centred agenda, and Pakistan's own membership means the forum cannot itself resolve the transit-access problem; the owners therefore separate two claims that answers routinely merge, namely that membership sustains political, security and economic engagement, and that membership does not by itself create physical connectivity, which depends on separate corridor projects.

- India has no direct land access to the Central Asian Republics because Pakistan and Afghanistan lie in between, so the first overland option is politically and security constrained, while Sikri records that any energy pipeline from Eurasia to India not crossing Afghanistan or Pakistan has to be routed via Xinjiang and then across the Karakoram and the Himalayan mountain ranges, which is geographically extreme and would require Chinese cooperation; the owners are categorical that this is a structural rather than a merely technical problem, so both plausible overland routes carry a serious political or geographic difficulty at the same time.
- The audited ledgers route two General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, namely 2018 General Studies Paper II question 10 on outside powers in Central Asia and India joining the Ashgabat Agreement, a Discuss the implications demand of 10 marks and 150 words for which the ledger records that the printed word-limit tail was corrupted in the scan and that the Core route supersedes the older Advanced ownership, and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 10 on India's evolving relations with the Central Asian Republics, a Critically analyse demand of 10 marks and 150 words; one objective demand is also routed here and carried as a coverage requirement only, namely 2025 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 62 on International North-South Transport Corridor connectivity, for which the official Set-A key is present locally while no option or answer letter is recorded or inferred; the locally held OCR-searchable official papers were read only to confirm printed wording and no question, key or marking scheme was imported from them.

Qualified conclusion: Compatibility depends on separating the functional issue from the strategic relationship, so the assessment must use the energy-understanding argument as the cooperative case, weigh it against the China-dependent overland route and the mixed-membership forum, and close with a calibrated recommendation that predicts no corridor completion or negotiation outcome.

Demand decoding: The directive **assess** requires a direct position on “Assess whether functional cooperation with China is compatible with India's competitive...”, every clause, bilateral/regional/systemic mapping, interests and constraints, objective-instrument-implementation-outcome separation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, alternatives, implementation risks and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: Compatibility depends on separating the functional issue from the strategic relationship, so the assessment must use the energy-understanding argument as the cooperative case, weigh it against the China-dependent overland route and the mixed-membership forum, and close with a calibrated recommendation that predicts no corridor completion or negotiation outcome.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** Sikri argues that India must try to develop an understanding on energy with China because both are major energy consumers often seeking energy from the same sources and their competition is only benefiting the energy producers, which the owners treat as a rare explicit call for cooperative management of a shared dependency despite broader strategic mistrust; the analytical value of this anchor is that it shows competition and cooperation coexisting on a specific functional issue, so a critical answer can avoid the crude choice between pure rivalry and naive partnership. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** India's full membership of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation provides a seat and a platform but not privileged influence, because the same forum includes China, Russia and Pakistan, so its outputs reflect compromise among competing major-power interests rather than an India-centred agenda, and Pakistan's own membership means the forum cannot itself resolve the transit-access problem; the owners therefore separate two claims that answers routinely merge, namely that membership sustains political, security and economic engagement, and that membership does not by itself create physical connectivity, which depends on separate corridor projects. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

3. **Claim and named evidence:** India has no direct land access to the Central Asian Republics because Pakistan and Afghanistan lie in between, so the first overland option is politically and security constrained, while Sikri records that any energy pipeline from Eurasia to India not crossing Afghanistan or Pakistan has to be routed via Xinjiang and then across the Karakoram and the Himalayan mountain ranges, which is geographically extreme and would require Chinese cooperation; the owners are categorical that this is a structural rather than a merely technical problem, so both plausible overland routes carry a serious political or geographic difficulty at the same time. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
4. **Claim and named evidence:** The audited ledgers route two General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, namely 2018 General Studies Paper II question 10 on outside powers in Central Asia and India joining the Ashgabat Agreement, a Discuss the implications demand of 10 marks and 150 words for which the ledger records that the printed word-limit tail was corrupted in the scan and that the Core route supersedes the older Advanced ownership, and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 10 on India's evolving relations with the Central Asian Republics, a Critically analyse demand of 10 marks and 150 words; one objective demand is also routed here and carried as a coverage requirement only, namely 2025 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 62 on International North-South Transport Corridor connectivity, for which the official Set-A key is present locally while no option or answer letter is recorded or inferred; the locally held OCR-searchable official papers were read only to confirm printed wording and no question, key or marking scheme was imported from them. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

Counter-position / limit: A doctrine label, summit declaration, signed document, project announcement, military exercise, trade change or diplomatic statement cannot alone establish binding obligation, operational delivery or strategic outcome; test legal character, implementation, partner response, alternatives and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: Compatibility depends on separating the functional issue from the strategic relationship, so the assessment must use the energy-understanding argument as the cooperative case, weigh it against the China-dependent overland route and the mixed-membership forum, and close with a calibrated recommendation that predicts no corridor completion or negotiation outcome.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 20 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing level -> interest -> instrument -> implementation -> outcome -> alternative; state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for source, date, membership, operative status, partner agency, causation, escalation and residual risk.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, explains strategy and implementation rather than listing visits or groupings, uses named India-centric evidence and preserves institutional, status, level, causal and geopolitical distinctions.

How to improve this answer: For "Assess whether functional cooperation with China is compatible with India's competitive...", replace the weakest event-list point with one named actor, interest, instrument, implementation bottleneck, measurable outcome, alternative and source-date-status qualification.

OPTIONAL ADVANCED DEPTH - NOT REQUIRED FOR A CORE ANSWER

Subject: International Relations | **Tier:** Advanced | **GS Paper:** GS-II. **Core area:** Continental-access constraints; the Afghanistan/Pakistan chokepoint; INSTC and Chabahar as connectivity frameworks; great-power competition without Indian determinism. **Grounded in:** M. Laxmikanth, *Indian Polity*; Rajiv Sikri, *Challenges and Strategy*; MEA India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief; 00_Master-Framework.md Sections 5-7. **FACT:** = source-grounded | **ANALYSIS:** = inference/analysis | **CURRENT:** = current anchor. *Companion:* basic/05_Central-Asia-Eurasia-and-Connectivity.md.

1. Architecture

INDIA'S CENTRAL ASIA INTEREST SET
energy/resources + counter-terrorism +
market integration + great-power balance



STRUCTURAL CONSTRAINT: NO DIRECT LAND ACCESS
Pakistan/Afghanistan sit between India
and the CARs



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ROUTE A: VIA AFGHANISTAN/
PAKISTAN (politically
constrained, security risk)



ROUTE B: VIA XINJIANG/
KARAKORAM/HIMALAYA
(geographically extreme,
requires China's cooperation)



+-----+-----+



ALTERNATIVE MARITIME-LINKED CONNECTIVITY
INSTC + Chabahar port (Iran route,
bypasses Pakistan)



MULTILATERAL OVERLAY
SCO (broad, includes China/Pakistan/Russia)
+ India-Central Asia Dialogue (region-specific)



"NEW GREAT GAME": multi-actor competition
(Russia, China, US and others) - outcome
not determined by any single power

Analytical claim: ANALYSIS: India's Central Asia policy is best understood as a response to a single binding constraint - the absence of direct land access - worked around through diplomatic (SCO, Dialogue), economic (proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement) and alternative-connectivity (INSTC, Chabahar) instruments, within a competitive multi-actor environment that India does not control.

2. Concepts and distinctions

Concept	Precise meaning
FACT: Two-route geography problem (Sikri)	FACT: Any Eurasia-to-India energy pipeline avoiding Afghanistan/Pakistan "has to be routed via Xinjiang and then across the Karakoram and the Himalayan mountain ranges" - meaning both plausible land routes carry serious political or geographic difficulty, a genuinely binding constraint rather than a solvable engineering problem alone.
ANALYSIS: INSTC/Chabahar as work-around, not solution	These maritime-linked connectivity frameworks (via Iran) bypass the Pakistan land constraint but introduce their own dependency on Iran-related geopolitics and sanctions dynamics - West Asia's constraints (topic 06) directly bear on Central Asia connectivity.
FACT: SCO vs. India-Central Asia Dialogue	SCO is a broad multilateral body including China, Russia, Pakistan and the CARs - engagement there is filtered through great-power dynamics; the India-Central Asia Dialogue is a dedicated, smaller-format mechanism allowing more direct region-specific engagement.
FACT: India-China energy-competition management (Sikri)	FACT: Sikri argues "India must try to develop an understanding on energy with China" since "both are major energy consumers often seeking energy from the same sources and their competition is only benefiting the energy producers" - a rare explicit call for India-China cooperative management of a shared external dependency.
ANALYSIS: "New Great Game" vs. Cold War-era Great Game	The contemporary framing (Sikri) describes competition among Russia, China, the US and regional powers for Central Asian influence and resources - distinct from, but historically descended from, the 19th-century British-Russian "Great Game" (World History owns that chronology).

3. Detailed causal chain: from constraint to connectivity strategy

- Structural starting point:** India has no direct land border with any Central Asian Republic; Pakistan and Afghanistan lie in between.
- Route A is politically/security constrained:** transit through Pakistan is not available given the bilateral relationship, and Afghanistan's own instability adds a second layer of constraint.
- Route B is geographically extreme and China-dependent:** FACT: Sikri's Xinjiang/Karakoram/Himalaya alternative would require both extraordinary engineering and Chinese cooperation - unlikely given the unresolved boundary dispute (topic 03).
- Alternative maritime-linked connectivity is pursued instead:** INSTC and Chabahar port route Indian goods and energy interest through Iran, bypassing Pakistan - but this substitutes one set of external dependencies (Iran-linked geopolitics, sanctions risk) for another.
- **Diplomatic engagement compensates where physical connectivity is constrained:**** SCO membership and the India-Central Asia Dialogue sustain political, security and economic ties even where physical corridors remain underdeveloped.
- India-China energy-competition management becomes rational:** FACT: Sikri's argument that both countries competing for the same energy sources "only benefits the energy producers" suggests cooperative management, not pure rivalry, is in India's own interest - a nuanced point beyond simple competitive framing.
- **Great-power competition sets the outer boundary of what India can achieve unilaterally:**** the "New Great Game" framing means India's outcomes in the region are co-determined by Russian, Chinese and Western engagement, not by India's effort alone.

4. Institutional and reform architecture

- FACT: **SCO**: the broad multilateral body through which India engages Central Asia alongside China, Russia and Pakistan; India's full membership (since 2017. provides a seat but not privileged influence given the mixed membership.

CURRENT: The 2025 summit at Tianjin (31 August-1 September 2025) adopted the Tianjin Declaration; Kyrgyzstan chairs for 2025-26. ANALYSIS: Pakistan and Iran are now full members, not observers - Sikri's observer list is period-specific.

- CURRENT: **India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue**: the more direct, region-specific mechanism - first Summit 27 January 2022 (virtual); fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue, New Delhi, 6 June 2025, which envisaged preparing the ground for a second summit; third meeting of Secretaries of Security Councils/NSAs, Bishkek, 16 October 2025. ANALYSIS: No second leader-level summit was officially recorded as held by 3 August 2026 - a candid indicator that the dedicated format has not yet institutionalised at leader level.

- CURRENT: **INSTC and Chabahar port**: connectivity frameworks under continuing development. The 10-year Chabahar contract between India Ports Global Limited and Iran's Ports and Maritime Organisation was signed 13 May 2024, with roughly USD 120 million in announced equipment investment and a USD 250 million credit window; ANALYSIS: the US revoked the 2018 Chabahar sanctions waiver on 16 September 2025, effective 29 September 2025, with a Treasury assurance of non-exposure running only to 26 April 2026. ANALYSIS: This is exposure created by a third state's domestic law, not a legal obligation on India - but it is a real constraint on the Iran work-around's financeability.

- CURRENT: **India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief (as on April 2026)**: the most recent dated bilateral-relationship record within the region.

- CURRENT: **India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation**: the current form of the "Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement" proposal - negotiations formally began on 3 June 2017 at St Petersburg and the second round was held in Moscow on 22-25 June 2026. ANALYSIS: Under negotiation; do not assert conclusion or entry into force.

5. Indian applications and boundary cases

- FACT: **Direct PYQ boundary case (2024 Q10)**: the question asks for a "critical" analysis of "increasing significance" - an advanced answer must go beyond listing opportunities (energy, market integration) to name the specific connectivity constraint (Afghanistan/Pakistan chokepoint, Xinjiang/Karakoram alternative) as the central limiting factor on that "significance."

- ANALYSIS: **Boundary case - Afghanistan's ambiguous status**: Afghanistan sits at the centre of the connectivity problem (a potential land-bridge to Central Asia) while itself being a source of instability that currently forecloses that option - a genuine unresolved tension, not a solved problem.

- ANALYSIS: **Boundary case - India-China energy cooperation despite rivalry**: Sikri's call for an "understanding on energy" with China, even amid strategic mistrust (topic 03), illustrates that competition and cooperation can coexist on a specific functional issue even where broader strategic relations remain tense.

- ANALYSIS: **Boundary case - SCO membership without privileged access**: India's SCO membership provides a platform but not a connectivity solution, since Pakistan's own SCO membership means the forum cannot itself resolve the transit-access problem.

6. Limitations and trade-offs

- ANALYSIS: **No unilateral connectivity solution exists**: both direct land routes face binding constraints, and alternative maritime-linked routes (INSTC, Chabahar) substitute one external dependency (Iran) for another (Pakistan/ Afghanistan) rather than eliminating the dependency problem.

- ANALYSIS: **SCO engagement is diluted by mixed membership**: India's participation alongside China, Russia and Pakistan means the forum's outputs reflect compromise among competing major-power interests, not an India-centred agenda.

- ANALYSIS: **Energy-source competition with China risks negative-sum outcomes**

absent the cooperative "understanding" Sikri recommends - a genuine policy choice, not a resolved matter.

- ANALYSIS: **Great-power competition sets an outer limit on Indian influence:** Russia

and China's greater historical and geographic proximity to Central Asia constrains how much relative influence India can realistically build, however effective its own diplomacy.

- ANALYSIS: **Connectivity-project timelines routinely lag announcements:** treat any

specific INSTC/Chabahar capacity or completion claim as requiring independent, dated verification rather than assuming delivery matches the original announcement.

7. Must-Know Facts for Advanced Prelims

- FACT: Sikri's Xinjiang/Karakoram/Himalaya alternative-route description

illustrates that both plausible overland pipeline routes to Central Asia face serious constraints.

- FACT: Sikri explicitly recommends India-China cooperative "understanding" on

energy sourcing, arguing that competition between the two "only benefit[s]" producer states.

- CURRENT: The SCO has 10 full members, 2 observers (Afghanistan, Mongolia) and 15

dialogue partners; Pakistan (2017), Iran (2023) and Belarus (2024) are full members. ANALYSIS: Sikri's account of Pakistan, Iran and Mongolia as observers is period-specific and must be dated when quoted.

- CURRENT: The India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief is current as on April 2026; the

fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue met in New Delhi on 6 June 2025.

- CURRENT: The US Chabahar sanctions waiver was revoked effective 29 September 2025,

with non-exposure assurance running to 26 April 2026.

8. Advanced Prelims traps

- WRONG: India's Central Asia connectivity problem has a straightforward

engineering solution. -> Sikri's own analysis shows both plausible overland routes face serious political or geographic constraints; the problem is structural, not merely technical.

- WRONG: SCO membership gives India privileged influence in Central Asia. -> SCO's

mixed membership (including China, Russia and Pakistan) dilutes any single member's privileged access; India's SCO seat is a platform, not a solution.

- WRONG: India and China only compete, never cooperate, in Central Asia/Eurasia. ->

Sikri explicitly recommends an energy "understanding" between the two despite broader strategic mistrust - cooperation and competition coexist on specific functional issues.

- WRONG: INSTC and Chabahar have already fully replaced the Pakistan-transit

constraint. -> These are developing connectivity frameworks whose capacity and reliability remain contingent on Iran-related geopolitics; do not assert full substitution without dated verification.

- WRONG: The Iran route removed India's dependency problem. -> It substituted a

sanctions-exposure dependency for a transit dependency: the 10-year Chabahar contract (13 May 2024) was followed by revocation of the US waiver effective 29 September 2025 - a change in a third state's domestic law that India does not control and is not legally bound by, but cannot ignore commercially.

9. CURRENT: Current-anchor note

- CURRENT: The India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief (as on April 2026) remains the most

recent dated MEA reference for the region. Two further dated anchors sharpen the analysis: the **fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue (New Delhi, 6 June 2025)**, which envisaged a second summit that had not been held by 3 August 2026, and the **revocation of the US Chabahar sanctions waiver (effective 29 September 2025)**, which converts the Iran work-around from a geographic question into a financing-and-sanctions-exposure question. ANALYSIS: Treat any claim about current INSTC throughput or the India-EAEU negotiation's outcome as requiring separate, dated verification.

10. PYQ-based analytical application

- FACT: **2024 Q10 (direct):** *Critically analyse India's evolving diplomatic, economic and strategic relations with the Central Asian Republics (CARs) highlighting their increasing significance in regional and global geopolitics.* An advanced answer should:

1. Name the Connect Central Asia Policy (2012) and SCO engagement as the diplomatic/economic evolution.
2. Identify the structural connectivity constraint (no direct land access; Xinjiang/Karakoram alternative equally constrained) as the critical limiting factor.
3. Discuss INSTC/Chabahar as a partial, Iran-dependent work-around.
4. Place the analysis within the "New Great Game" competitive context, explicitly noting that outcomes are co-determined by Russia, China and Western engagement, not by India alone.

11. Mains-ready framework

Central thesis: India's Central Asia policy is a diplomatic and economic response to one binding structural constraint - the absence of direct land access - worked around through multilateral engagement (SCO, the Dialogue), proposed economic integration, and Iran-routed alternative connectivity (INSTC, Chabahar), all conducted within a great-power-competitive environment that limits, without eliminating, India's achievable influence.

1. **State the structural constraint first** (no direct land access) before listing opportunities.
2. **Distinguish the two overland route options** and their respective political/geographic difficulties.
3. **Introduce INSTC/Chabahar as a partial work-around**, not a completed solution.
4. **Name the multilateral overlay** (SCO vs. India-Central Asia Dialogue) and its respective strengths/limits.
5. **Address the India-China energy-competition-versus-cooperation choice** explicitly.
6. **Place the analysis in the "New Great Game" competitive context.**
7. **Close with a calibrated recommendation** - diversify connectivity options, deepen the region-specific Dialogue, and pursue functional cooperation with China on energy sourcing - without predicting corridor completion or specific outcomes.

12. Probable questions

- FACT: **Mains (10 marks, direct 2024 PYQ):** Critically analyse India's evolving diplomatic, economic and strategic relations with the Central Asian Republics (CARs) highlighting their increasing significance in regional and global geopolitics.
- ANALYSIS: **Mains (15 marks):** "India's Central Asia connectivity ambitions face a structural, not merely technical, constraint." Critically examine.
- ANALYSIS: **Mains (10 marks):** Discuss the case for India-China cooperative energy engagement in Central Asia despite broader strategic mistrust.

13. Study links

- FACT: Foundation companion: basic/05_Central-Asia-Eurasia-and-Connectivity.md.
- FACT: Geography/basic/34_World-Regional-Geography-Continents-Countries.md - physical route geography.
- FACT: 00_Master-Framework.md Section 7 - the chronology-substitution and homogeneity analytical gaps applied to this topic.

- ANALYSIS: **Cross-links within this folder:** topic 03 (advanced) for the India-China energy-competition-management argument in full; topic 06 for the Chabahar/ Iran connectivity linkage; topic 10 for SCO's full institutional profile.

Historical PYQ Integration (2018-2023)

Status: Question-level PYQ demand is integrated into this owner. **Provenance:** Audited local official-paper routing ledgers: _PYQ-ROUTING-MAINS-GS1-GS2-ESSAY-2018-2023.md.

- **Years represented:** 2018
- **Paper(s):** GS-II
- **Routed question demands:** 1

Year	Paper	Q	PYQ demand (neutral rendering)	Directive / format	Source status	Owner requirement
2018	GS-II	10	Outside powers in Central Asia and India joining the Ashgabat Agreement	Discuss the implications · 10 marks · 150 words	Routed to owning topic; printed word-limit tail OCR-corrupted in scan	Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.

What this owner must now support

- Outside powers in Central Asia and India joining the Ashgabat Agreement

The table integrates the examinable demand and paper metadata. It does not turn an unkeyed objective question into a solved answer, and it does not claim that lexical presence alone proves full conceptual sufficiency.

CONSOLIDATED REGISTER NOTES

Central Asia, Eurasia and Connectivity: RAPID ACTOR, INSTRUMENT AND DATED-ANCHOR MAP

- What this Eurasian owner holds and how its boundaries are routed:** This topic owns the five Central Asian Republics, the Connect Central Asia Policy, the India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue mechanisms, India's Central Asian use of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the connectivity instruments of the International North-South Transport Corridor, Chabahar port and the Ashgabat Agreement, the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation and the New Great Game framing, and its distinctive feature is that its examinable spine is a constraint rather than an opportunity, because two verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2018 and 2024 and one objective demand from 2025 are routed here; the full institutional profile of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation belongs to topic 10, the India-China strategic relationship belongs to topic 03, the West Asian and energy-security limb of Chabahar belongs to topic 06, physical and route geography belongs to the Geography owner, and Soviet-era regional chronology with the nineteenth-century Great Game belongs to the World History owner.
- The five Republics and the Connect Central Asia Policy:** The five Central Asian Republics are Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan, and the Connect Central Asia Policy launched in 2012 aims at strengthening and expanding India's relations with those countries through a broad-based approach including political, security, economic and cultural connections; the owners insist on the word broad-based because reducing the policy to energy alone misdescribes its declared scope, and they treat the 2012 launch as the foundational Indian policy approach against which every later mechanism in this topic is measured.
- Multilateral channel use and the proposed economic-integration instrument:** India engages Central Asia partly through existing fora described in the sources as the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the Eurasian Economic Community and the Custom Union, and it has proposed a Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement to integrate its markets with the Eurasian space; the examinable discipline is that a proposal is an instrument of intent rather than an operating arrangement, so an answer must name the proposal by its exact title and then trace what actually happened to it rather than implying that market integration has already occurred.

4. **The India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation and its exact status:** The proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement is now pursued as the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation, which formally began on 3 June 2017 at St Petersburg and remained under negotiation, with the second round held in Moscow on 22-25 June 2026; the owners fix the status precisely as under negotiation and neither signed nor in force, so an answer may cite the dated rounds as evidence of sustained economic engagement and may never assert conclusion, signature or entry into force.
5. **Energy and resources as the substantive interest:** India looks to Central Asia as a long-term partner in energy and natural resources, given the region's substantial hydrocarbon and mineral endowment, and this interest is what makes the connectivity question consequential rather than merely administrative; the owners keep the claim at the level of a stated policy interest and do not attach any volume, share, price or contract figure to it, because no such figure is carried by the sources and an invented number would convert a defensible interest claim into a fabricated one.
6. **The two-route geography problem as a binding structural constraint:** India has no direct land access to the Central Asian Republics because Pakistan and Afghanistan lie in between, so the first overland option is politically and security constrained, while Sikri records that any energy pipeline from Eurasia to India not crossing Afghanistan or Pakistan has to be routed via Xinjiang and then across the Karakoram and the Himalayan mountain ranges, which is geographically extreme and would require Chinese cooperation; the owners are categorical that this is a structural rather than a merely technical problem, so both plausible overland routes carry a serious political or geographic difficulty at the same time.
7. **Shanghai Cooperation Organisation membership tiers as they now stand:** As of 3 August 2026 the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation has ten full members, namely Belarus, China, India, Iran, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Pakistan, Russia, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan, two observers, namely Afghanistan and Mongolia, and fifteen dialogue partners, with Pakistan a member since 2017, Iran since 2023 and Belarus since 2024, while a decision of 1 September 2025 envisages consolidating the observer and dialogue-partner categories into a single SCO Partner status whose enabling amendments had not entered into force; the owners warn expressly that Sikri's book-period note placing Pakistan, Iran and Mongolia in observer status is period-specific and must be dated whenever it is quoted.
8. **The Tianjin summit and the current chairmanship:** The 2025 Heads of State Council summit of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation met at Tianjin on 31 August and 1 September 2025 and adopted the Tianjin Declaration, Kyrgyzstan holds the 2025-26 chairmanship and the next summit is scheduled for Bishkek, while India's own accession to full membership in 2017 is treated as chronology owned by the World History and Polity owners; the owners permit the summit and declaration to be cited as dated evidence of India's continued multilateral engagement and permit no claim about the declaration's contents beyond its adoption at that meeting.
9. **The dedicated India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue format:** The first India-Central Asia Summit was held virtually on 27 January 2022, the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue at foreign-minister level met in New Delhi on 6 June 2025 and envisaged preparing the ground for a second summit, and the third meeting of Secretaries of Security Councils and National Security Advisers met at Bishkek on 16 October 2025, while no second leader-level summit had been recorded as held by 3 August 2026; the owners treat that absence as a candid indicator that the dedicated format has not yet institutionalised at leader level, and they require the gap to be stated rather than glossed over when a demand asks about increasing significance.
10. **The Chabahar contract as the concrete connectivity instrument:** India Ports Global Limited and Iran's Ports and Maritime Organisation signed a ten-year long-term contract for Chabahar port on 13 May 2024, with India announcing roughly one hundred and twenty million United States dollars in equipment investment and a two hundred and fifty million United States dollar credit window for mutually identified infrastructure; the owners require these to be cited as announced investment and an announced credit window rather than as delivered equipment or disbursed finance, because an announcement and a delivery are different evidentiary levels and the difference is exactly what a critical demand tests.
11. **The revoked Chabahar waiver as third-party sanctions exposure:** The United States State Department revoked the 2018 Chabahar sanctions waiver on 16 September 2025 with effect from 29 September 2025, and a subsequent assurance of non-exposure ran only to 26 April 2026, so any status beyond that date requires fresh verification; the owners state the legal character precisely, because this is a change in another state's domestic sanctions posture that creates exposure risk for entities rather than an international legal obligation binding on

India, and its practical effect is to convert the Iran work-around from a geographic question into a financing and sanctions-exposure question.

12. **The corridor instruments and their exact completion status:** The International North-South Transport Corridor is a connectivity framework intended to open a maritime-linked route to Central Asia and Eurasia bypassing Pakistan, and the owners require it to be treated as an announced and developing corridor with operating segments rather than a completed, full-capacity corridor; the same discipline extends to Chabahar, because connectivity-project timelines routinely lag announcements, so any specific capacity, throughput or completion claim requires independent dated verification instead of being assumed to match the original announcement.
13. **The Ashgabat Agreement as a transit-rules framework:** The Ashgabat Agreement was signed at Ashgabat on 25 April 2011 to establish an international multimodal transport and transit corridor between Central Asia and the Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman, and India joined with effect from 3 February 2018, which adds a rules-and-transit framework to India's Chabahar and corridor strategy and reduces dependence on direct territorial access through Pakistan; the owners attach the limitation directly, because it is a facilitation framework rather than an infrastructure-finance mechanism, so its value depends on connected ports, rail and road segments, customs coordination and Iran-related sanctions exposure.
14. **The dated bilateral record inside the region:** The Ministry of External Affairs India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief is current as on April 2026 and is the authoritative dated record for that relationship, and the owners instruct that this brief be cited for any specific current claim about it rather than a general assertion of warm ties; the wider methodological point is that a region-level policy claim and a country-level status claim require different evidence, so a candidate should name the dated brief when the demand turns on the present state of a particular bilateral relationship.
15. **The New Great Game as multi-actor competition without Indian determinism:** Sikri frames Central Asia as a geographical area that abuts on the borders of major powers in Asia and will always attract foreign presences, which describes ongoing great-power competition for influence rather than any Indian ability to determine regional outcomes, and the owners add that Russia's and China's greater historical and geographic proximity constrains how much relative influence India can realistically build however effective its own diplomacy; the examinable consequence is that outcomes in this region are co-determined by Russian, Chinese and Western engagement, so an answer must place India's effort inside a competitive field rather than presenting it as the decisive variable.
16. **Membership without privileged access:** India's full membership of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation provides a seat and a platform but not privileged influence, because the same forum includes China, Russia and Pakistan, so its outputs reflect compromise among competing major-power interests rather than an India-centred agenda, and Pakistan's own membership means the forum cannot itself resolve the transit-access problem; the owners therefore separate two claims that answers routinely merge, namely that membership sustains political, security and economic engagement, and that membership does not by itself create physical connectivity, which depends on separate corridor projects.
17. **Cooperative management of a shared external dependency:** Sikri argues that India must try to develop an understanding on energy with China because both are major energy consumers often seeking energy from the same sources and their competition is only benefiting the energy producers, which the owners treat as a rare explicit call for cooperative management of a shared dependency despite broader strategic mistrust; the analytical value of this anchor is that it shows competition and cooperation coexisting on a specific functional issue, so a critical answer can avoid the crude choice between pure rivalry and naive partnership.
18. **Afghanistan as simultaneously the bridge and the barrier:** Afghanistan sits at the centre of the connectivity problem because it is the potential land-bridge to Central Asia while being itself a source of instability that currently forecloses that option, and the owners record this as a genuine unresolved tension rather than a solved problem; the consequence for answer writing is that Afghanistan cannot be treated either as a ready corridor or as an irrelevant space, and any recommendation must be calibrated to a situation in which the shortest route is the least available one.
19. **Substituted dependency rather than eliminated dependency:** The maritime-linked work-around through Iran bypasses the Pakistan land constraint but substitutes one set of external dependencies, namely Iran-linked geopolitics and sanctions risk, for another, so no unilateral connectivity solution exists and the dependency problem is managed rather than removed; the owners pair this with the timeline warning that announcements

outrun delivery in this sector, which together give the honest verdict that India's Central Asia problem is not an absence of interest but the conversion of diplomatic goodwill into reliable access across contested transit space.

20. **Honest question ownership for this Eurasian owner:** The audited ledgers route two General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, namely 2018 General Studies Paper II question 10 on outside powers in Central Asia and India joining the Ashgabat Agreement, a Discuss the implications demand of 10 marks and 150 words for which the ledger records that the printed word-limit tail was corrupted in the scan and that the Core route supersedes the older Advanced ownership, and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 10 on India's evolving relations with the Central Asian Republics, a Critically analyse demand of 10 marks and 150 words; one objective demand is also routed here and carried as a coverage requirement only, namely 2025 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 62 on International North-South Transport Corridor connectivity, for which the official Set-A key is present locally while no option or answer letter is recorded or inferred; the locally held OCR-searchable official papers were read only to confirm printed wording and no question, key or marking scheme was imported from them.

Central Asia, Eurasia and Connectivity: CLOSE-OPTION AND STATUS-UPGRADE TRAPS

- Do not say that Central Asia is directly accessible to India by land, because Pakistan and Afghanistan lie between India and the five Republics and that absence of direct access is the central constraint of this topic.
- Do not describe the Connect Central Asia Policy as an energy policy, because it was launched in 2012 as a broad-based approach including political, security, economic and cultural connections.
- Do not present the proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement as achieved market integration, because it is a proposal now pursued as the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation.
- Do not assert that the India-Eurasian Economic Union agreement has been concluded, signed or brought into force, because negotiations began on 3 June 2017 at St Petersburg and the second round met in Moscow on 22-25 June 2026 with the negotiation still open.
- Do not describe Pakistan and Iran as Shanghai Cooperation Organisation observers, because Pakistan has been a full member since 2017 and Iran since 2023, Belarus joined in 2024, and only Afghanistan and Mongolia are observers.
- Do not state that the single SCO Partner status has replaced the observer and dialogue-partner categories, because the decision of 1 September 2025 envisaged that consolidation while the enabling amendments had not entered into force.
- Do not claim that Shanghai Cooperation Organisation membership resolves India's connectivity constraint, because the Organisation is a political, security and economic forum that does not by itself create physical connectivity.
- Do not treat India's seat in that Organisation as privileged influence, because the same forum includes China, Russia and Pakistan and its outputs reflect compromise among competing major-power interests.
- Do not assert that a second India-Central Asia Summit has been held, because the fourth Dialogue of 6 June 2025 envisaged preparing the ground for one and no second leader-level summit had been recorded as held by 3 August 2026.
- Do not describe the announced one hundred and twenty million United States dollar equipment investment or the two hundred and fifty million United States dollar credit window at Chabahar as delivered equipment or disbursed finance, because both are announcements attached to the ten-year contract of 13 May 2024.
- Do not present the revocation of the United States Chabahar sanctions waiver, effective 29 September 2025, as a legal bar binding on India, because it is a change in another state's domestic sanctions posture that creates exposure risk for entities.
- Do not extend the Chabahar non-exposure assurance beyond 26 April 2026, because the owners record that date as its stated limit and require fresh verification for any later status.
- Do not describe the International North-South Transport Corridor or Chabahar as completed, fully functioning corridors at full capacity, because the owners record them as developing frameworks with operating segments requiring dated verification for any capacity claim.
- Do not treat the Ashgabat Agreement as an infrastructure-finance mechanism, because it was signed on 25 April 2011 as a multimodal transport and transit facilitation framework that India joined with effect from 3 February 2018.

- Do not read the New Great Game framing as licence to claim that India can determine regional outcomes, because Sikri describes multi-actor competition and the owners record that Russian and Chinese proximity constrains India's achievable relative influence.
- Do not assert that India and China only compete in Central Asia and Eurasia, because Sikri expressly recommends an understanding on energy on the ground that their competition only benefits the energy producers.
- Do not treat Afghanistan as either a ready land-bridge or an irrelevant space, because the owners record it as simultaneously the potential corridor and the source of instability that forecloses the option.
- Do not claim that the Iran route removed India's dependency problem, because it substituted sanctions and geopolitical exposure for transit dependency rather than eliminating dependence.
- Do not quote Sikri's period-specific membership description as a current fact, because the owners require any book-period statement to be dated when it is used.
- Do not invent a corridor or project status, a route alignment, a summit outcome, a sanctions measure, a membership or participation category, an energy or trade share, a port-access arrangement, a treaty or statement wording, a border or diplomatic status, a date, a previous-year question, an answer key or a current claim for this topic.

Central Asia, Eurasia and Connectivity: ANSWER-WRITING SPINE

NAME INDIA'S PRECISE INTEREST -> IDENTIFY THE EXTERNAL ACTOR AND ITS OWN INCENTIVE
-> CHOOSE THE LEVEL: BILATERAL, REGIONAL, MINILATERAL, MULTILATERAL OR DIASPORA
-> CITE ONE DATED INSTRUMENT AND STATE ITS EXACT EVIDENTIARY LEVEL
-> SEPARATE ANNOUNCED FROM SIGNED, SIGNED FROM IN FORCE, IN FORCE FROM DELIVERED
-> NAME THE BINDING CONSTRAINT: ASYMMETRY, RIVAL POWER, PARTNER POLITICS OR CAPACITY
-> CLOSE WITH A CALIBRATED WAY FORWARD AND AN EXPLICIT STRATEGIC-AUTONOMY LINK

Central Asia, Eurasia and Connectivity: LIVE-SOURCE AND DATED-CLAIM BOUNDARY

Live official verification was attempted on 2026-09-03 in the priority order required for this topic: the Ministry of External Affairs pages first, then the Press Information Bureau, the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation Secretariat, the Eurasian Economic Union and the Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways. Every outcome is recorded exactly as observed. The Ministry of External Affairs pages returned a browser-requirement stub or the Ministry's own error page, the Press Information Bureau index returned HTTP 403, and the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation Secretariat returned only an anniversary banner. The Eurasian Economic Union and the Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways returned general background text with no dated item bearing on India, so no new live item was obtained that would add, alter or date any claim in this package. The package therefore uses only the dated official anchors already carried by the repository owners, each with its actor, exact evidentiary level and date. It invents no corridor or project status, no route alignment, no summit outcome, no sanctions measure, no membership or participation category, no energy or trade share, no port access, no treaty or statement wording, no border or diplomatic status, no date, no previous-year question, no answer key and no current claim.

COMPLETE TOPIC ASCII MASTER FLOW DIAGRAM

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 1/12: Central question and the root access condition

CENTRAL QUESTION -> how does a state with no land access build Eurasian presence?

ROOT CONDITION -> Pakistan and Afghanistan lie between India and the five Republics

|
v

AXIS 1 -> POLICY: Connect Central Asia Policy, 2012, broad-based

AXIS 2 -> FORUMS: SCO seat | India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue

AXIS 3 -> CORRIDORS: INSTC | Chabahar | Ashgabat Agreement

RULE -> the constraint is the spine of the answer, not an afterthought

MUST REMEMBER: Central Asia and Eurasia policy connects continental access, energy,...

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ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 2/12: The two overland routes and why both fail

ROUTE A -> via Afghanistan and Pakistan

FAILS ON: transit unavailability and Afghan instability

ROUTE B -> via Xinjiang, then across the Karakoram and Himalayan ranges

FAILS ON: extreme geography plus required Chinese cooperation

SOURCE -> Sikri on any Eurasia-to-India pipeline avoiding Afghanistan or Pakistan

VERDICT -> a structural constraint, not an engineering problem awaiting a solution

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 3/12: Policy classification: what broad-based actually means

CONNECT CENTRAL ASIA POLICY, LAUNCHED 2012

|-- POLITICAL -> sustained high-level engagement with the five Republics

|-- SECURITY -> counter-terrorism and security-council-level consultation

|-- ECONOMIC -> market integration proposal with the Eurasian space

+-- CULTURAL -> people-to-people and cultural connections

FIVE REPUBLICS -> Kazakhstan | Kyrgyzstan | Tajikistan | Turkmenistan | Uzbekistan

TRAP -> reducing a broad-based policy to an energy policy misstates its scope

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 4/12: Economic-integration instrument: proposal to open negotiation

PROPOSED -> Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement with the Eurasian space

-> 3 JUNE 2017, ST PETERSBURG: India-EAEU free-trade negotiation formally begins

-> 22-25 JUNE 2026, MOSCOW: second round held

STATUS -> under negotiation; neither signed nor in force

ALSO CITED -> Eurasian Economic Community and the Custom Union as existing fora

RULE -> cite the dated rounds as engagement, never as an achieved agreement

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 5/12: SCO participation matrix as of 3 August 2026

FULL MEMBERS (10) | Belarus | China | India | Iran | Kazakhstan

| Kyrgyzstan | Pakistan | Russia | Tajikistan | Uzbekistan

OBSERVERS (2) | Afghanistan | Mongolia

DIALOGUE PARTNERS | 15

ACCESSIONS -> Pakistan 2017 | Iran 2023 | Belarus 2024

1 SEPTEMBER 2025 -> decision envisaging a single SCO Partner status

PENDING -> the enabling amendments had not entered into force

TRAP -> Sikri's observer list is period-specific and must be dated when quoted

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 6/12: Dedicated regional format and its honest gap

27 JANUARY 2022 -> first India-Central Asia Summit, held virtually
6 JUNE 2025 -> fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue, New Delhi, foreign-minister level;
envisaged preparing the ground for a second summit
16 OCTOBER 2025 -> third meeting of Security Council Secretaries and NSAs, Bishkek
31 AUGUST-1 SEPTEMBER 2025 -> SCO summit at Tianjin adopts the Tianjin Declaration;
Kyrgyzstan chairs 2025-26 with the next summit scheduled for Bishkek
GAP -> no second leader-level summit recorded as held by 3 August 2026

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 7/12: Chabahar instrument priced component by component

13 MAY 2024 -> ten-year long-term contract, India Ports Global Limited with
Iran's Ports and Maritime Organisation
USD 120 MILLION -> announced equipment investment; LEVEL: announcement
USD 250 MILLION -> announced credit window for mutually identified infrastructure
LEVEL -> announced credit window, not disbursed finance
RULE -> announcement and delivery are different evidentiary levels

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 8/12: Sanctions exposure path and its consequence

16 SEPTEMBER 2025 -> United States State Department revokes the 2018 waiver
-> 29 SEPTEMBER 2025: revocation takes effect
-> ASSURANCE: non-exposure runs only to 26 April 2026
-> BEYOND THAT DATE: status requires fresh verification
LEGAL CHARACTER -> another state's domestic sanctions posture; exposure for entities
NOT -> an international legal obligation binding on India
CONSEQUENCE -> the Iran work-around becomes a financing question, not a map question

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 9/12: Corridor status ladder

ANNOUNCED FRAMEWORK -> International North-South Transport Corridor
|-- intended to reach Central Asia and Eurasia bypassing Pakistan
|-- OPERATING SEGMENTS exist
+-- NOT a completed, full-capacity corridor
25 APRIL 2011 -> Ashgabat Agreement signed; India joined from 3 FEBRUARY 2018
|-- multimodal transport and transit corridor to the Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman
+-- LIMIT: a facilitation framework, not an infrastructure-finance mechanism
RULE -> capacity and completion claims need independent dated verification

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 10/12: Competitive field and the limits of Indian agency

PROBLEM -> the region abuts major Asian powers and will always attract foreign presences
RESPONSE: sustained diplomacy through a seat, a dialogue and corridor instruments
PROBLEM -> Russian and Chinese proximity is greater than India's
RESPONSE: accept co-determined outcomes rather than claiming regional primacy
PROBLEM -> mixed SCO membership includes Pakistan
RESPONSE: the forum sustains engagement; it cannot resolve transit access
VERDICT -> multi-actor competition, expressly not Indian determinism
CLOSE DISTINCTION: INSTC, Chabahar, Ashgabat Agreement, SCO and bilateral connectivity...
CLOSE DISTINCTION: INSTC, Chabahar, Ashgabat Agreement, SCO and bilateral connectivity...
CLOSE DISTINCTION: INSTC, Chabahar, Ashgabat Agreement, SCO and bilateral connectivity...

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 11/12: Functional cooperation inside strategic mistrust

COMPETITION -> India and China seek energy from the same sources
EFFECT -> that competition only benefits the energy producers
SIKRI'S RECOMMENDATION -> develop an understanding on energy with China
COEXISTENCE -> cooperation on one function alongside unresolved strategic mistrust
BOUNDARY -> the wider India-China strategic relationship belongs to topic 03
USE -> avoids the crude choice between pure rivalry and naive partnership
EVIDENCE LIMIT: STATUS / LEVELS / IMPLEMENTATION: Map India-Iran-Russia-Central Asia...
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EVIDENCE LIMIT: STATUS / LEVELS / IMPLEMENTATION: Map India-Iran-Russia-Central Asia...

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 12/12: Answer spine for a Central Asia demand

OPEN -> state the absence of direct land access before listing any opportunity
BUILD -> policy, forums and corridors, each with one dated instrument at its level
TEST -> price sanctions exposure, the unheld summit and the open negotiation honestly
CLOSE -> convert goodwill into reliable access as the graded verdict, predicting nothing